

ARC ANTHOLOGIES:

Pillbug-Man



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What happens when a man wears a suit that looks like a pill bug and decides to be a hero? What does it look like when it is up to just one person to hold off a world-ending threat? What are the limits our beliefs can be pushed to before they break?

Arc Anthologies: Pillbug-Man is a collection of stories written over the course of five years meant to expand the Arc Universe by complimenting other books and expanding the universe with new character concepts. Some such as *They're Safe* and *Rosewood* act as prequels to the *Pink Skies* books. *Bullfighter* introduces characters later seen in other books like *Pink Mourning*. Other stories like *Crow* are meant to be a chance to delve into a character that couldn't find a spot in a book.

Given the fact these stories were written over the course of five years there are several themes this collection touches on such as love, pride, guilt, and destiny. One thing that unites these stories is they all are set early in the Arc Universe and are focused on the origin of many characters. These stories are meant to delve into their “why” and show who or what led them to their current path.

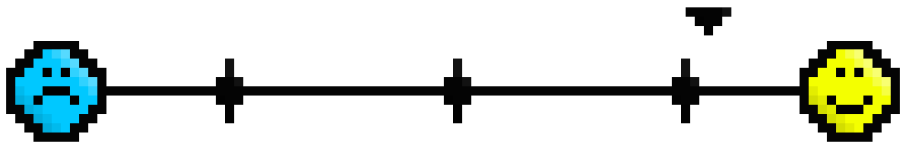
Each story could be enjoyed on its own in any order without any previous knowledge, but I sequenced the stories approximately in the order I wrote them so that way a reader could discover new things about the Arc Universe in the same way I did.

Below, I included a brief summary of each story along with a rating of how happy or sad the story is so that way you could pick one to match your current mood or perhaps turn a rough day around. These

characters mean so much to me. I hope through these stories they can mean something to you too.

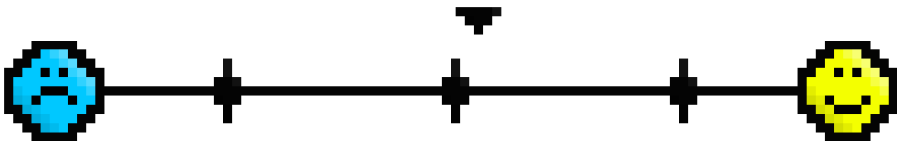
Pillbug-Man

Named after the titular hero, *Pillbug-Man* is a punctual play that follows one of the early encounters between Pillbug-Man and Justice. Far before the atrocities that awaited, the two of them dance around the delineation between hero and villain. Spurred by a dreary diagnosis in Justice’s life their relationship quickly changes.



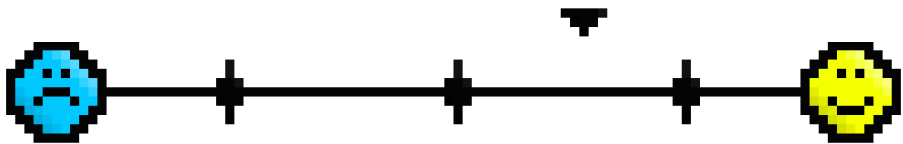
They’re Safe

Set pre-S-Day, a thunderous threat is advancing expeditiously to the Earth. Most heroes are preoccupied with other pressing issues, so it is up to the scraps to defend the Earth. The best Earth can do is a tiny team formed from the less popular Alpha Squadron heroes, America’s soldiers, whatever heroes were free, and Micro Man. It’s up to these eight eclectic heroes to defend against Atomsplitter. *They’re Safe* is a story filled with flashy fighting where this transient team must give their all to buy Earth just a few more meaningful minutes.



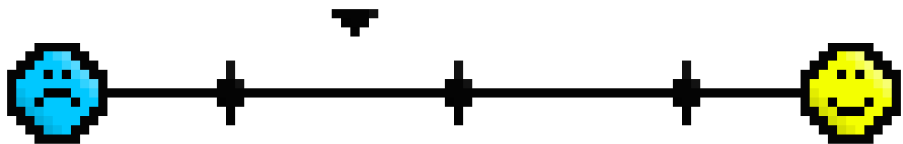
Rosewood

Set before *They're Safe*, *Rosewood* follows the government's entropic endeavor to recruit heroes to help stop Atomsplitter's soon-to-come siege. After searching across America, Colonel York has made her way to the not so riveting Rosewood, a town that Stupendous Man calls home, in hopes of recruiting him. Infamous for his strength and conviction, Stupendous Man has the potential to shift the tide of the titanic upcoming battle. Her request raises questions about moral duty and where heroes draw the line.



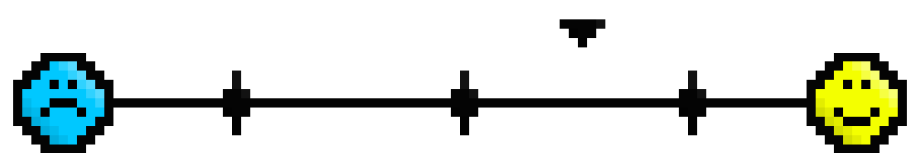
Carry Me Out

Where religious obligation and commitment to duty collide, Mongoose exists. Stuck between a painful past and the vacuum of the present, Abigail struggles to find what her role is in Skum City. Is she mean to be an embodiment of authority or an insignia of inspiration?



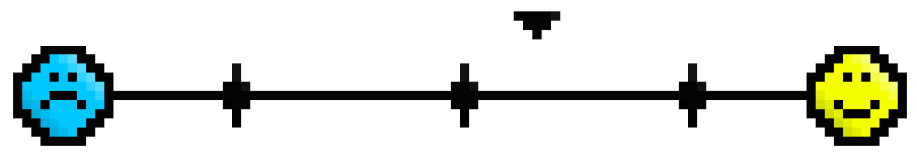
It's Like Fighting a Supervillain

College can be quite complex for some such as Momentum that finds himself still stuck pondering the past. With his good friend Tensile, who is much more practical and put-together, they train under the passionate guidance of Pillbug-Man. After an encounter with Wishing Prism these wounded heroes' internal issues begin to weirdly manifest which results in their face-to-face encounter with what withers away deep inside them.



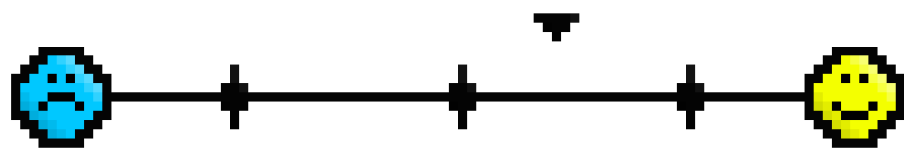
Bullfighter

Dragonflies are red. Brittany can feel blue. Dani can't know. Hell, Brittany's not even sure of herself too. Right after S-Day the world found itself descending into discordant destruction. Formerly street level heroes, Dragonfly and Rider now find themselves in the superhero spotlight. Can they live up to the laudable lives of those that are no longer?



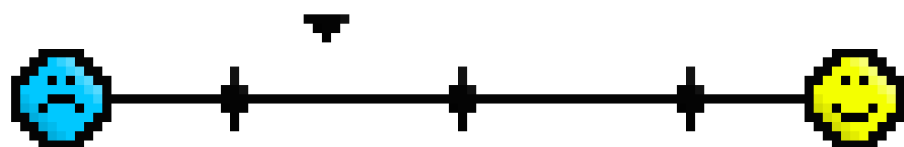
Crow

Chris was born with a gift. At least that’s what the weary god Woden believes. What he has been told was out of his control, simply a result of a chemical imbalance in his once meticulous mind, was actually the branches of the benevolent tree Yggdrasil poking through the pores of reality revealing the script to our short lives. Can Chris find a line between his own mental malleability and the dispassionate desires of an ancient god?



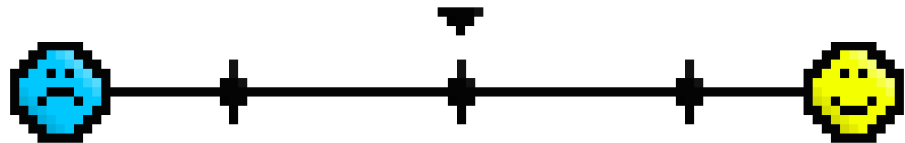
We’re The Ones Still Here

The world has settled down for now and Pillbug-Man finds himself reflecting upon his rocky past. Not all is what it seems to be with Pillbug-Man. Acting as the leader of an up-and-coming academy for heroes, who is there for Pillbug-Man? What does it mean when the mentor can’t mentally take it anymore.



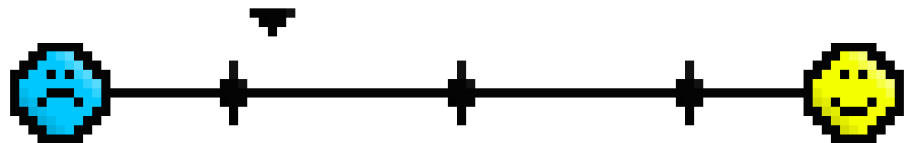
Don't Know

Croissants and hell.



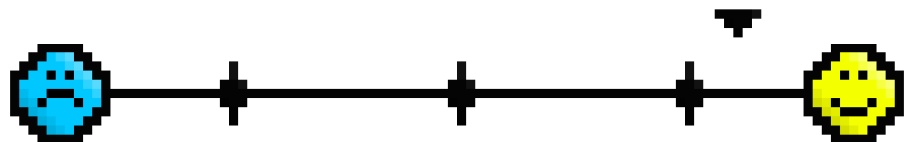
Pigeon Man

When a sphere of pure wind encases a local park, it is up to Pillbug-Man and his crew to get to the bottom of what caused it. Although, they're not the only one whose attention this anomaly caught, and they must act quickly before the military takes things into their own hands.



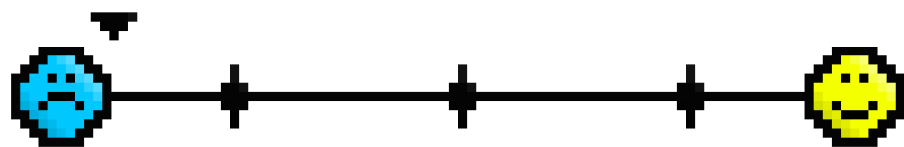
The New Year's Special

Long before a coalition would form out of concern for a current crisis, the heroes of modern day share a special night spread across their cities. While they each spend the night doing something different, it is still the same sky that they look toward when midnight strikes.



Prettier During Sunset

The death of Pillbug-Man.



Pillbug-Man

Characters:

Justice - An invulnerable hero

Pillbug-Man - A wannabe top level nemesis to Justice

Hammer - A pitbull who is Justice's sidekick

Cat-atonic - A bipedal cat the size of a man that wields a laser gun

Hostage 1

Hostage 2

Setting: It starts in a clean bank. Its granite countertops and pillars have no dust on them and it would be another normal day, except today everyone in the bank is tied against the pillars.

Scene 1

[Pillbug-Man (a man in a giant pill bug costume that is probably too big for him) stands in the center of the bank.]

Pillbug-Man: Remain calm, my lovely hostages. I shall simply steal all of the money from this bank and disperse it randomly on the streets to strangers so they don't have to worry about producing a consistent income to compete in a capitalist society and they can instead enjoy their lives and families for a couple days.

Hostage 1: I didn't understand most of what you just said.

Pillbug-Man: Zip the lips. Justice should be here any second. I want you all to look distraught. This is my big moment. I love when he first arrives. I bet today he is gonna come in through the ceiling.

[A crash can be heard as a man in bright orange spandex and cape runs in from stage left. He has a big "J" printed on his chest and orange boots. Justice looks toward the tied-up hostages.]

Justice: Is everyone ok?

Hostage 1: Of course we are. It's just Potato-Bug-Man.

Pillbug-Man: IT IS PILLBUG-MAN! I suppose your dog sidekick is just around the corner. I don't fear Hammer anymore. I brought my own sidekick! GET OUT HERE, CAT-ATONIC!

[A big, muscular cat in a trench coat and a fedora steps out from stage right. He reaches into his trench coat and pulls out a huge gun.]

Cat-atonic: Moo-Rowr

Pillbug-Man: Oh, you are in for it now. BLAST HIM!

[The big gun Cat-atonic is holding starts glowing and humming. He points it at Justice. Pillbug-Man runs up to Justice.]

Pillbug-Man: WAIT! Let me hit him first!

[Pillbug-Man runs toward Justice.]

Pillbug-Man: EHHHHHKKK!

[Pillbug-Man slaps Justice lightly. Justice does not flinch. Pillbug-Man shrieks with joy and claps his hands then runs to the side as the gun Cat-atonic is holding starts to sparkle. There is a bright flash then a VROOM. The stage lights up blue.]

[When the bright light fades, the ground is darkened around Justice, but Justice is unfazed.]

Justice: I don't have time for this.

[Justice flicks his finger which creates a shockwave that knocks down Pillbug-Man and Cat-atonic]

[Justice dashes to Pillbug-Man and lifts him up, pinning him to the wall.]

Justice: Alright, do you give up now, Doodlebug-Man?

Pillbug-Man: Oh, I LOVE this part of the fight so much I am going to pretend you said my name right. Why of course I—wait, where is Hammer? He hasn't shown up. Tell me I am enough of a threat to at least bring your dog?

[Justice sets down Pillbug-Man.]

Justice: He has been sick. He got cancer and it has gotten a lot worse. I was about to take him to the vet for the final time, but I had to pause to stop you.

Pillbug-Man: Oh, Heavens! Why didn't you say anything? Why are we here? Let's help out your dog! Come on, Cat-atonic! Start the Evil Pizza Delivery Bicycle! We will meet you at your home, Justice.

Justice: What? You don't even know where I live.

Pillbug-Man: OF COURSE I DO. I am your nemesis after all.

[Pillbug-Man and Cat-atonic run off the stage and Justice follows shortly after.]

Hostage 1: WAIT! WHAT ABOUT ME!

Hostage 2: Shut up, Man. They are helping his dog. I for one don't mind sitting here for a bit. Before this happened, I was on my way to the dentist. This is a win for me.

End Scene

Scene 2

[Pillbug-Man and Justice are now in a car in the vet's parking lot. Pillbug-Man is wearing a Hawaiian polo and khaki shorts. Justice is wearing a button-up shirt with a sweater and khaki pants.]

Pillbug-Man: You know, I don't consider myself a villain. I consider myself THE villain. I mean I routinely fight others to free fellow citizens from the shackles of modern society so they can live the lives of their dreams. It's really diabolical. Think about how mad company CEOs are that their workers are happy.

[Justice is reaching one hand to the back of the car to pet Hammer. Cat-atonik is in the back of the car as well and has pushed himself as far away as possible from Hammer. Justice's eyes are tearing up.]

Justice: Um, you know I am not sure if right now is the moment to have this conversation, but you don't sound evil to me. That kind of sounds thoughtful, Roly-Poly-Man.

Pillbug-Man: Ew, don't say that. My mom died when I was born, and my dad lived with her parents to help raise me. Her parents would drink all night long and my dad would always clean up after them. He recycled every bottle and tucked them in once they passed out. Some nights they would yell at him for helping them and said they just wanted to be left alone. They said he was causing problems. I always respected my dad, so I knew when I grew up, I wanted to be as evil as him.

[Justice sniffles]

Justice: Wow. There is some serious emotional damage there that needs to be unpacked by a medical professional. Can we just focus on what's going on right now for a little bit?

Pillbug-Man: Do you know why I chose a pill bug as my costume?

Justice: Why?

Pillbug-Man: Because we know so little about how they process pain. They don't feel emotions, no agony, no despair. They simply exist. I think there is something so beautiful about that. I think we should all live a little more like a pill bug.

[Pillbug-Man puts his hand on Justice's shoulder.]

Justice: You're right. Hammer can probably sense my sadness. Let's get moving on this.

[Justice and Pillbug-man got out of the car]

[Justice opens the car's back door and Cat-atonic dashes out of the car and into the nearby woods. Justice reaches in and lifts Hammer out of the car. Hammer's once muscular legs are now covered in saggy skin. His once bronze mane is now stained gray. His once wide eyes now struggle to stay open.]

[Justice puts a leash on Hammer and walks him over to the grass.]

Justice: Come on, Buddy. How about one last bathroom break?

[Pillbug-Man walks over to Hammer and bends down to pet him]

[Hammer growls at him and backs up.]

Justice: Easy, Hammer. He is on our side now. There is no more fight—

[Justice is cut short. He stops talking, clears his throat, and snuffles. He looks away from Pillbug-Man.]

Justice: You know, I am the strongest man in the world . . . and I can't even do this. How can I stop a meteor heading for Earth, but not even . . . not even take my dog in for a vet appointment. I don't get it.

Pillbug-Man: I believe false strength comes from thinking you have to do everything alone. True strength comes from knowing you have people that can help you bear the load.

[Pillbug-Man pets Hammer then reaches for the leash in Justice's hand.]

Pillbug-Man: Let me help you take him in. It's time.

[Justice wipes his face and turns around to look at Pillbug-Man.]

Justice: You're right. Thanks, Pillbug-Man. You are the best nemesis anyone could ever ask for.

[Pillbug-Man, Hammer, and Justice walk into the Veterinary Clinic.]

End Scene

Scene 3

[Justice gets out of his car in his driveway. He is alone and carrying a cardboard box. He starts walking up to his house and sees a pill bug crossing his driveway. He pauses, then reaches down to pick it up and he carries it to the other side of the driveway. He keeps walking up to his house and walks in the door. You can hear a conversation vaguely.]

Justice: Don't worry, Honey. He is at peace now . . .

End Scene

They're Safe

Before S-Day

Micro Man stood atop a skyscraper in Tokyo. The rain fell down his copper-colored metallic suit. He wore a silver helmet that covered his whole face. Little copper balls rolled across it and each of them had a camera attached to it which sent video to the helmet of the suit which allowed him to see the heroes across the roof.

Soldier 32, H8ywire, Battle Gal, Western Man, and Orange Android talked to each other building a plan. Soldier 32 checked his ammo as the rain smeared the black paint strips under his eyes.

"H8ywire, you sure this rain isn't gonna mess with your circuitry?" Soldier 32 asked.

"Why would it? My mechanics are state of the art," it responded as the cogs inside of the robot crunched against their metal casing.

"Orange Robot, why is it that only six of us are left to defend from this off-world threat?" Battle Gal asked.

"Please don't call me a 'Robot'. I am a member of the Alpha Squadron, and I should be respected as such. As to your question, the rest of them are preoccupied with other matters," he said.

"Hmph. You'd think for something like this a few more of the capes would swoop down to help us," Western Man said as he adjusted his cowboy hat.

"Are there seriously no other heroes available currently?"

“Let me check the database. All of Asia’s heroes are currently stationed for a predicted Kaiju attack. Australian heroes are currently fighting off a continent-wide mutant spider invasion. Europe’s heroes are protecting the government from an attack by the King’s Covenant. Antarctica has only one hero and Polar Vortex could not make it. Africa’s heroes are deployed in South America as of now to help with the natural disaster relief. We are all that is left,” Orange Android responded. The rain glistened as it rolled down the orange panels covering his innards. It soaked into the long cape hanging from his neck. The blue lights in his eye sockets glowed in the night.

“And who is that?” Soldier 32 asked as he pointed his gun toward Micro Man. His blonde hair was soaked by the rain.

“Hey, don’t you know anything about firearm safety?” Micro Man asked.

“That is one of the few American heroes that has any chance of making it past the first minute of this fight. Make no mistake. It is probable that none of us will make it out of this alive,” Orange Android said.

“Isn’t Justice supposed to be able to fly at light speed and punch with enough force to explode the sun? Why can’t he handle this?” Western Man asked.

“He’s busy,” Orange Android said.

“Doesn’t matter anyways. Ain’t nothing I can’t kill. You’re looking at the best bounty hunter on Earth,” Western Man said.

“Tighten up over there. Our sensors are going off. She is on the way,” their earpieces chirped out.

“Affirmative, Colonel York. The problem with that, Western Man, is this creature is not from Earth,” Orange Android said.

Whhhherrrrrr. THUMP! The sky flashed white, and a metallic pod flew down then anchored itself into the roof. *Hiss.* The rain turned to steam as it pattered off the pod.

“At the ready! If we fall here, so does Earth,” Orange Android said as he raised his fists into the air.

thump. A metal scrap flew off the pod to reveal the darkness within. The heroes peered cautiously into the void. *SHING!* A golden trident flew out of the pod and into Soldier 32. *Shink.* The weapon penetrated his body and golden points erupted at his spine. Soldier 32’s eyes opened wide, and his fingers loosened around his gun.

“It . . . *kuk* . . . was an . . . *uck* . . . honor,” he choked out as blood filled his lungs.

CRASH! The pod erupted to reveal a seven-foot-tall purple woman that wore a blue suit and had a long yellow cape. *THUMP. THUMP. THUMP.* She ran forward toward Soldier 32 knocking Battle Gal and Western Man to the side. Western Man’s pistols slid out of his hands, and he darted after them. *Shlink!* The woman ripped the trident from his chest and kicked him off the building. Soldier 32 fell to his death silently for he could not scream.

“Hopefully the rest of you are stronger or Earth will fall quicker to Atomsplitter than I expected,” she said with a grin that revealed her yellow teeth. She mounted her trident into the concrete then cracked her knuckles.

“Team, this is it! Give it everything you got!” Orange Android shouted. Micro Man stood still in fear.

Orange Android flew forward, and the woman extended her arm. His body phased through her then he reappeared behind her. **Bzzzz.** Orange Android's eyes flared as scorching rays blasted out from them. The beam ricocheted off her armor and pierced through Battle Gal's body. Orange Android froze as he watched Battle Gal grasp at the gaping hole in her stomach.

"NO! Not Battle Gal too!" H8ywire's speaker box screeched.

Atomsplitter grabbed Orange Android while he was dazed and threw him into the ground. His mechanical parts crunched across the concrete. She dragged him against the cement until he was balled up. **WHIP!** She threw the ball of mechanical parts at Battle Gal who was keeled over on the ground. **POP!** Her body erupted in red and shrapnel.

Whirrrrr. A jet booster sputtered on H8ywire's back as the gears in its bodies whirled.

"I was programmed to serve under three rules. Do not harm humans. Obey my orders. Protect my own existence. Lucky for me, you don't qualify as human."

Schink. Its arm retracted into its body and a metal saw blade spun out. **Fwoosh!** H8ywire flew forward as the jet kicked in. **Bzzzzzzz!** The saw grinded against Atomsplitter's gauntlets. She reached forward and sunk her hand into H8ywire's chest. Its left arm retracted, and the barrel of a shotgun flew out. **BOOM!** H8ywire shot

Atomsplitter in the face and she loosened her grip. **Fwoosh!** H8ywire flew back out of her hands.

Micro Man remained frozen. Western Man awaited the perfect shot. H8ywire landed on the ground.

“You robots all fail to impress me. No fun when you don’t get to rip a heart out,” Atomsplitter said. She dropped a chunk of metal from H8ywire’s chest to the ground.

“I stand tonight as the final dam preventing the flood of blood onto humanity. You will not prevail. On board weapons proven ineffective, activate protocol 66.”

H8ywire’s eye turned red, and it anchored its feet into the ground as the jet on his back burnt brighter and brighter. **FWOOM!** H8ywire let go of the ground and flew forward. **Bang! Bang! Bang!** H8ywire fired his shotgun as he flew forward. Atomsplitter stood unphased. The saw on his left arm retracted and a thin spear formed in its place. **Shink.** The spear pierced Atomsplitter’s skin and H8ywire stuck to her. **Whir!** His legs contorted to wrap around her.

“Do not let this sacrifice go in vain.
Beep. Beep. Beep.”

BOOM! H8ywire exploded and smoke erupted around Atomsplitter.

“You got kids?” Western Man asked Micro Man.

“...”

“Well, if you do, I’d take this chance to run back home to them.”

Western Man spun his guns then pulled back on the hammers. **Click. Click. Bang! Bang! Bang! Bang!** He rapidly fired into the smoke at the black shadow of Atomsplitter. A large purple hand appeared out of the cloud and waved it away. Atomsplitter stood unphased.

“I reckon since all I brought were guns this leaves me few options,” Western Man said. He reached into his pocket. He pulled out some metal pieces and dynamite. As Atomsplitter walked forward he hunched over and fumbled with his guns. He turned back around to Atomsplitter and pulled up one massive gun with a bundle of dynamite in the barrel.

“Have a taste of some MANIFEST DESTINY!” Western Man shouted. **Click! Bang!** The dynamite chunk flew toward Atomsplitter and she swatted it to the side. **Boom!** It exploded off in the distance. Atomsplitter stepped forward and picked up Western Man. He hit the butts of his guns off her head to no avail. She threw him off the roof.

“You! Why haven’t you attacked yet?” Atomsplitter questioned Micro Man.

The carnage flashed in his brain. *All of them are gone. I am it.*

Pure instinct took over. Micro Man spoke into his wrist, “York, Atomsplitter took them all down in seconds. Where is my backup?”

“Quantum Break is on the way, we still have hope,” the voice in his ear shouted.

FWOOSH! A woman in bright red spandex slammed into Atomsplitter who slid not more than a few inches across the ground and otherwise was undamaged. **BOOM! BOOM! BOOM!** Quantum

Break slammed her fists against Atomsplitter. With each punch a rush of air blew past Micro Man. Atomsplitter grabbed Quantum Break. Her purple fist squeezed around Quantum Break's neck.

She's not gonna win. You need to get in the game.

Atomsplitter's eyes glowed red. **ZZZZZZZZZZZZ!** Micro Man saw Quantum Break's head glow red before the laser's from Atomsplitter's eyes broke through the other side. Atomsplitter threw Quantum Break to the side and her limp body rolled across the roof of the building until she fell off the edge. Atomsplitter reached for her trident and pulled it from the ground.

"Alright. Atomsplitter just killed our heavy hitter. I need an evac now!" Micro Man shouted.

"I am not evac-ing you Micro Man. If Atomsplitter escapes us she will level a city every hour. You must fight her," the static covered voice said.

"Did you just see what I saw?!?! She is going to kill me! How am I supposed to fight her?"

"Judging from your file . . . I assume you will use some microbots or your size manipulation powers to defeat her."

"Are you insane?" Micro Man exclaimed.

"I would like to think I'm not. Listen, just hold her off for about thirteen minutes. I called Justice. He is a few galaxies away, but he can get to you eventually."

"Alright . . . I can do that. Is the building clean of people?"

"Yes."

"What about the city?"

“How much do you need cleared?” the voice from his ear asked.

“I need a five-block radius ASAP,” Micro Man said.

“I’ll let you know when it is clear.”

Come on. People are counting on you. Focus.

For some reason, instead of Atomsplitter, he thought of when his daughter tripped about three years ago. She sat on the ground hugging her knee as he walked over. Her braided, golden hair laid on the cement next to her head.

“What’s wrong, Sweetie?” he asked.

“I scratched my knee, Dad.”

“Aw, let me take a look.”

She moved her hands away from the scrape to reveal the tear in her skin to her father.

“How do you feel?” he asked.

“Sad. It hurts,” she said with a snuffle.

“You know I sometimes get hurt while I’m out there.”

“How do you deal with it?”

“I try to tell a joke. It distracts me,” he said.

“Can you tell me one?”

“Alright, here’s one. Ask me, ‘What’s up?’”

“What’s up?”

“The gas prices,” he said with a smile.

“I don’t get it . . .”

“Yeah, you wouldn’t, I guess. Here, let me try this one. A man walks into a bar. What does he say?”

“I don’t know, Dad.”

“He says ow!”

She laughed quietly as he reached his finger over to wipe away a stray tear.

“Does it feel better?” he asked.

“I think so, Dad.”

Micro Man smiled. He snapped back to the present.

“Just tell a joke . . .” he muttered. The fear left his body to be replaced by practice in the field.

“Here goes nothing,” Micro Man said as he reached for his feet to stretch out.

“Good luck, Micro Man.”

“TINY MAN! I LEFT YOU FOR LAST. On my world, it is good etiquette to kill the weakest last,” Atomsplitter said. She pointed her trident at him. Her voice boomed, making Micro Man’s hair stand up.

“Yeah, well on Earth we do normal things like hold the door for each other!”

She ran at him.

Micro Man reached into his belt and pulled out a small metallic ball. It was the size of a penny, and it had two wings wrapped tight against it. He pulled up a holo-keyboard on his wrist. The rain poked holes in his hologram temporarily as the drops fell through while he typed away.

“On my mark I need two microbots set to detonate in fifty seconds, one microbot for flight, and all other available microbots set to storm,” Micro Man said. Atomsplitter got closer to him.

Atomsplitter pulled her trident back and with a grunt she flung it forward.

“NOW!” Micro Man shouted. He smacked his right wrist. **ZIP! ZIP! ZIP!** Micro Man disappeared as a microbot flew past the trident. He held tight to the microbot while it buzzed through the air.

“WHERE DID YOU GO, METAL MAN?” Atomsplitter shouted.

bzzzbzzzzzzzzzzbzzzzzzzzzzBZZZZZZZZZZZZ. The wind blew around Atomsplitter. Copper waves rolled through the air. Slowly, the city below became less visible as more microbots swarmed around her. She swatted at them, but as she knocked some to the ground, more took their place. **BZZZZZZZZZZZZ.** Her eyes turned red, and she blasted the clouds of microbots to no avail. **BOOM!** Atomsplitter clapped her hands and the microbots flew backwards in a shockwave. **pop, pop, pop, pop.** The microbots began to fizzle and slowly fell out of the air.

Micro Man flew past her avoiding detection and landed inside Atomsplitter’s ear. He ran in until he reached a wall of textured, purple pulsating flesh.

“Good thing this race has an eardrum,” Micro Man whispered.

He threw two microbots as hard as he could into the ear then he started running. **BOOM! BOOM!** Micro Man leapt out of the ear and slapped his left wrist. **Zoop. Zoop. Zoop.** The explosion knocked him forward while he returned to normal size. He tumbled across the ground and one of his shoulder plates flew off. **Dink, dink, di...nk.** He watched it fly off the building. His vision began to blur.

Ted sat quietly at a small table in a cafe.

He ran his hands through his short locks of black hair then said, “No, you’re on time! I actually got here a little early.”

“Well, sorry to have kept you waiting then!”

“How has your day been so far, Janet?” Ted asked.

“Not too ba—What is that on your face?” she asked. She raised her finger to point at a burn across his right cheek.

“Nothing at all, just a scuffle I got into the other day.”

“You’re not like a boxer or something, are you? I don’t even know what profession gives you something like that. I’m not looking to date someone who is going to get themselves killed.”

“No, I’m not a boxer.” Ted chuckled then said, “I do something better for a living.”

A waiter approached them then asked, “What can I get for you both today?”

Janet looked toward Ted. Her mouth opened.

"EEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEEE"

Micro Man's eyes ripped open. Atomsplitter rocked back and forth. She held her hands up to her ears. He could tell she was screaming, but he couldn't hear anything over the high-pitched ringing. Slowly, he heard the microbots rolling across his helmet. He shook his head then stood up.

He dashed over to Atomsplitter and jabbed at her. *thud. thud. thud.* His fists bounced off her stiff body. Micro Man pulled back his arm. As he swung his left arm up, he slapped his left wrist. *Zoop!* *Zoop! Zoop!* Micro Man grew three times his size before he uppercut Atomsplitter. Now twenty feet tall, the ground cracked below him. He grabbed Atomsplitter and repeatedly smashed her against the concrete roof.

“A little over five minutes passed,” the voice from his watch said.

Micro Man threw Atomsplitter against the ground. He bent his legs to jump into the air. As he pushed off the ground, he smacked his right wrist. *Zip! Zip! Zip!* Micro Man shrunk to just one tenth of his normal size and he flew up through the air. Once about thirty feet up, he smacked his left wrist. *Zoop! Zoop! Zoop!*

CRASH! CRASH! CRASH! CRASH! Micro Man smashed through the floors with Atomsplitter stuck beneath him. They landed on a floor where weight racks, treadmills, and lifting benches surrounded them. A crack had formed across Micro Man’s visor and all the lights inside it went out. “Just the Two of Us” by Grover Washington played quietly.

“Just the two of us. We can make it if we try,” Ted sang quietly to himself. He stood in a kitchen, their kitchen. He used one hand to stir spaghetti on the stove and another to hold an ice pack against his ribs. The front door opened, and Janet walked in with their daughter, Morgan.

As he looked at the stove, he heard Janet say, “Morgan, take those shoes off. I don’t want mud all through the house.”

“Alright, Mommy.”

thump. thump. thump. thump. Morgan ran into the kitchen and embraced her father.

“Daddy, you missed it! I scored my first goal of the season!”

Ted winced then set down the ice pack.

“Wow! That is awesome sweetie!”

“I’m sorry. Did I hurt you, Dad?” Morgan asked.

“No, not at all. I just had a long day at work and I’m a little tired.”

“You think you will ever get to make it to one of my soccer games, Dad?”

“We’ll see! Hopefully, but my work is a little crazy,” Ted said.

“Oh . . . okay,” Morgan said meekly.

“I’ll be there for all your games, Morgan,” Janet said.

Morgan looked up to her dad and said, “VERY CLEVER, HUMAN!”

Atomsplitter stood up and cracked her neck.

Micro Man ripped his helmet off and gasped for air. He grabbed the microbots rolling across it and put them in his pocket. Blood trickled down from his nose. He rubbed his hand across his face then stood up. Atomsplitter approached him. Dark, purple blood dripped from her ear.

“There is more where that came from,” Micro Man said.

Micro Man reached for the weights next to him and tossed them at Atomsplitter, but she flicked them away. **ZZZ!** Atomsplitter blasted lasers from her eyes at Micro Man. He rolled away so he was behind a weight rack. His tongue was dry as sweat beaded on his forehead. He paused to catch his breath.

“About five minutes left,” the voice from his watch said.

“Great—” Micro Man began to say.

Atomsplitter kicked over the weight rack, and it knocked Micro Man to the ground. She reached down through the weights and picked him up. **THUD!** She punched him in the stomach, and he flew into the wall. He let out a gasp of air. Blood splattered from his mouth as plaster erupted around him.

“.” Micro Man tried to speak but the air was knocked out of him. He pulled up his holo-keyboard and clicked away. Following that, he reached into his belt and pulled out some microbots.

“Surrender and I will kill you quickly,” Atomsplitter said.

Micro Man shook his head in disdain and threw a microbot at the ground below. **boom.** He slapped his right wrist. **Zip! Zip! Zip!** Micro Man shrunk down and fell through the small hole in the floor. **boom, boom, boom, boom, boom, boom.** He fell through the openings in the floor as he used up the microbots left in his pocket. One microbot remained as he fell into the next room. **KERPLUNK!** Micro Man fell into a pool in the basement of the building.

Ted was holding the baggy hands of a dying man. Ted's clothes were soaking wet, but the room was dry. He swallowed heavily while the man waved Janet and Morgan out of the room.

"You're going to be ok . . ." Ted said. His body shook violently to try and warm up.

"Don't kid yourself. I'll be dead by dawn. Just promise me you will look after my daughter . . . that's what matters to me. Please put this superhero stuff behind you," the man croaked.

"But . . . I can't pro—"

"Just please say it. I can't die until I know there will be someone else here for my daughter," the man whispered to Ted.

"I . . . will . . . watch her," Ted said in between deep breaths. His teeth chattered.

"SAY it . . ."

"I'll stop being a superhero . . ."

"Thank . . . you . . ." the dying man said. Ted looked over at the heart monitor. *Beep. Beep. Beep. Zzzzzzzzzzzzzzzzzzz.*

Zzzzz. The wristband on Micro Man's right wrist fizzled. Micro Man awoke and ripped it off. He gulped water from the pool to quench his thirst. It burned his throat as it went down. *crash. Crash. CRASH!* Atomsplitter fell through the ceiling and into the pool. The force from her landing in the pool formed a wave that pushed all the water out and Micro Man onto the deck by the deep end.

"Are you done running?" Atomsplitter asked from the bottom of the now empty pool.

"Depends, are you done killing?"

Micro Man reached into his pocket. *One microbot left.*
Schkkkkkkk. Atomsplitter scraped her trident across the pool floor as she approached him from the shallow end. Her eyes slowly began to glow red. Once she reached the deep end, she looked up at Micro Man. He leapt down at Atomsplitter. **SCHINK.** Atomsplitter thrust her trident up and impaled him. He reached toward Atomsplitter pushing the trident further into himself. He reached forward and jammed the microbot into her right eye. **Bzz Boom!** The force of the explosion knocked Micro Man back into the side of the pool. When he collided with it, the trident flew out of him and landed to his side. Purple blood gushed from Atomsplitter's empty eye socket. Murky, red blood slipped out of Micro Man's stomach.

"Just about three minutes left. You can do it, Ted!"

"I . . . don't know, Boss. It isn't looking so good right now," Micro Man choked out.

"RETCHED HUMANS! WORTHLESS! You fight for what reason?!?! You simply extend your suffering. Blood drips from your essential organs and you still chatter," Atomsplitter roared.

"I guess they don't have . . . children where you come from . . ." Micro Man mumbled.

Atomsplitter walked toward Micro Man. He picked the red tipped trident up from the ground and pointed it toward Atomsplitter. She smacked it away and grabbed Micro Man. She threw him up through the ceiling. **CRASH!**

Micro Man flew up into the lobby and tumbled across the ground. He laid sprawled out.

Ted dug through the closet for his suit. His hands were bleeding. They stained all the clothes he touched dark red, but he didn't seem to care.

"Ted, what are you doing?" Janet asked.

"Honey, they need me! There is something big coming. It's really bad." Ted rubbed his bloody hand through his hair. The streaks of white he possessed turned crimson.

"I don't care. We need you! I thought you promised my dad you were done with this five years ago! Your daughter needs you! I NEED YOU!"

"You don't understand what is coming. If I don't stop it, it could come for you guys," Ted said.

"Please, Ted . . . it's been twenty years of you doing this. You've done your job to protect the world, to protect us. There are others out there just like you that can handle this. Let someone else fix it," she pleaded.

Ted grabbed a suitcase out of the closet then stood up. He said, "I do this because I love you and Morgan more than anything in the world. She won't get any more time with me if we're all dead."

"Please . . ." she said. Her eyes glistened.

Ted reached his hand out and put it on Janet's shoulder. A damp and sticky brown spot grew across her green shirt. The blood mixed with the soft cloth and spread across her body.

"Don't . . . come back then," she said.

". . .okay," Ted said. He quietly walked out of the room.

"Ted, don't die please."

Ted looked back at her. **THUD!** The ground erupted below them.

Atomsplitter landed right in front of Micro Man. He attempted to crawl away from her. Micro Man laid on the ground and pulled himself forward leaving a red smear behind him. He rapidly gasped for air as his body erupted in pain. Micro Man was ripped back. Atomsplitter grabbed him by the leg. He couldn't feel her hands wrapped around his ankle. **HRGHH!** Atomsplitter threw him up against the ceiling. **Crash!** He hit the ceiling then fell back down. **SMASH!** She slammed her fist into him as he fell to the ground. **CRASH!** Micro Man flew through the side of the building, and he skidded to a stop against the street. It was quiet outside.

Atomsplitter stepped through the hole Micro Man left in the building. He closed his eyes. It felt like ice had filled his veins and while he couldn't feel much of his body, he knew that he was shaking violently. Snot dripped from his nose.

"You fought well, Micro Man," she said.

"I think . . . I could say the same to you."

"You jest, but this is no laughing matter," she said.

"It is to me."

"Alright, Ted. The city has been cleared," that pesky voice in his watch said. That selfish, selfish, selfless voice.

Micro Man reached his right arm towards his left wrist and grazed it. **ZOOP! ZOOP! ZOOP! ZOOP!** Micro Man grew larger and larger. His skin felt as if it would rip apart as his body increased in

size. **ZOOP! ZOOP! ZOOP! ZOOP!** His very atoms felt as if they were separating from each other as they grew hundreds of times their size. The electrons moved farther and farther from the protons at their core. Micro Man screamed in pain as he grew to be as tall as the skyscraper he stood on only minutes ago. He reached down and ripped the building from its base then spun it toward Atomsplitter.

CRASH! CRASH! CRASH! CRASH! Floors collapsed in on themselves against her. Micro Man screamed with rage as he crumbled the building to dust. Once the final floor smashed into Atomsplitter, Micro Man continued to slam his gargantuan hand into the ground until it grabbed her. He ripped her from the ground and threw her into the building next to them. **CRASH!** Micro Man leapt into the air and slammed down on the building. He fell through each of the floors knocking Atomsplitter down with him. Once the building was destroyed, he got up and jumped into the air. He curled his legs and crashed into the ground. **KA-BOOM!** He got back up and rapidly punched the ground. Micro Man roared. His fists, the size of garbage trucks, slammed into the street forming a crater. He stopped to inhale. With each breath, winds at the speed of over sixty miles per hour blew past him. **Zoop! Zoop! Zoop!**

Micro Man shrunk down. He stood in a crater over a hundred feet wide. In the center, the dust settled. He saw a black outline stand up and walk towards him.

“Im . . . possible,” Micro Man said. He collapsed to the ground in exhaustion.

Atomsplitter emerged from the cloud of debris. Limping, she slowly approached him. Oozing, purple cuts were scattered across her

body. Her eye socket had stopped bleeding and instead was now a damp, black gash.

She picked him up and ripped off his chest piece. His boots were pulled off his body, next she peeled off his leggings, his sleeves were pried off, and finally she tore off his gauntlets. Micro Man squirmed to try and shake free from her grasp. She grabbed the wristband from his left arm and crushed it to dust. Ted hung in the air wearing a white spandex suit.

“No more running. Your time is up.”

beep. beep. beep. beep. The gauntlet on the ground rang quietly.

“Actually . . . I think yours is . . .”

shhhhhhhHHHHHHHHH . . . BOOOOOM!

An orange blur blew past Ted and into Atomsplitter. She loosened her grasp on Ted and the shockwave from the collision knocked him back. **BOOM! BOOM! CRACK! BAM!** Justice slammed his fists against Atomsplitter. With each punch, Ted was knocked farther and farther back. He closed his eyes.

They're safe.

Rosewood

Stupendous Man flew through the sky over Rosewood. The wind blew through his hair as the small town carried on beneath him. The air rolled down his dark blue spandex and golden boots. His bright yellow cape ruffled in the air. In the center of his chest, he had a large S. The blonde hair on his head was slicked back perfectly.

Rosewood was a small town about thirty minutes from anything of note. Comprised mostly of chain restaurants and craft stores, few people stayed here past high school.

That's what set Stupendous Man apart from everyone else. He was the only thirty-year-old around that wasn't currently spending their nights helping a child with math homework. Born and raised a Rosewood resident, Stupendous Man never left the comfort of his hometown.

He possessed the strength to explode the sun, but he never used it for anything more than stopping a drunk driver. He had the ability to clap a planet out of existence, but all he used it for was high fiving kids. He could shout and the country would go deaf, but all his voice was used for was cheering on the local high school football team.

As he soared above, Stupendous Man noticed a small, blond-haired girl looking through a forest for her lost baseball. She slowly waded through the forest, careful not to graze any poison ivy which was about the most dangerous thing in this town.

Her name was Piper and Stupendous Man had always kept a close eye on her. At the age of twelve, she had yet to find a good

friend in life. Her obsession with animals gave her a large heart. She couldn't bear to see a worm on the sidewalk after it stopped raining, and she checked outside her window before she went to bed every night for any stray animals that could be injured. He liked that about her. She cared for what might seem insignificant to others.

Unfortunately, this meant she usually wasn't good at keeping up with trends thereby keeping her out of social circles.

He continued watching as she walked forward. A thorn scratched her frail leg. She bit her lips and continued onward. Piper put her hands up over her eyes and searched around for the small, white ball. With a gust of wind, Stupendous Man appeared next to her.

"What are you looking for, Sweetie?"

"Stupendous Man! I lost my baseball somewhere around here. Do you see it?"

"That shouldn't be too hard for me to find! What's that on your leg?"

Stupendous Man kneeled and looked at the scratch on her leg.

"It's nothing. It doesn't hurt that bad," she said.

Stupendous Man exhaled quietly, and cold air blew out of his mouth and the cut froze over.

"Well, now it shouldn't hurt at all!" Stupendous Man said. He searched for the ball with his x-ray vision. He flew away and returned with it.

"Thank you!" she said.

"It's my pleasure!" Stupendous Man responded as he passed it over to her.

Piper gave him a hug and then ran off out of the forest. Before Stupendous Man took off flying, he heard something with his super hearing.

“Piper, you’re such an idiot.”

“Yeah, I don’t know why we invited you to hang out today.”

“I’m sorry guys, it was a mistake,” Piper said.

Stupendous Man appeared next to them.

“Do I hear a problem here, girls?” he said. His eyes glowed red.

“No, Mr. Stupendous,” the first girl said.

“We’re sorry. We were just mad Piper kept losing the ball,” the other girl said.

Stupendous Man’s eyes continued to glow brighter and brighter.

“Maybe I could just laser you both just a teensy bit right now and Piper won’t have to deal with this anymore?” he suggested.

A tear rolled down the first girl’s face. The other held her hands in front of her eyes to hide Stupendous Man from herself.

“OH! I’m just messing with you! You’re all good!”

Stupendous Man said jovially. His eyes stopped glowing. The girls laughed nervously.

“I can see my joke was not well received, but I hope you all have a nice day regardless!” he said. He patted them on the shoulder. Stupendous Man reached his arms into the air to fly away but noticed a woman in a military suit standing off to the side of the field.

Ugh, Colonel York is back again.

Stupendous Man appeared next to her.

“Nothing I love more than a meeting with you! Are you here to request the usual?” he asked with a wide, but fake grin. His pearly white teeth glistened as the sun reflected off them.

Colonel York’s teeth were a yellow tint from all the years of coffee drinking. Part of the stain likely comes from the coffee in the president's office. She thought he could serve some of the best coffee in the world, but it usually meant she would be having a long few days after.

Colonel York had this same conversation with another hero just two days ago. They always say yes. They had to. For the human race, for their family, for her own sake. She had to form the best team possible for what awaited them. Stupendous Man was the only one who had ever said no. He was going to crack whether he knew it or not.

The images in her briefing from a few weeks ago hurtled through her mind as she began to speak. She hadn’t been able to stop thinking about the picture of the large, purple alien wielding her golden trident stained with blood. The name “Atomsplitter” haunted her dreams.

“I think a great conflict is approaching us as a human race. We need you,” she said. That was a classic first line. Most people were sold at that.

“Same thing you said three days ago. I get the gist. Big threat coming, can’t tell me because government stuff, but you want my help. Perhaps we should take this conversation somewhere else.”

Stupendous Man grabbed Colonel York's hand and with a gust of wind they stood in a field surrounded by a forest. Colonel York adjusted the collar to her suit. Stupendous Man smiled as he took in a deep breath of the oak trees that surrounded them.

"I want you to take this position in the Capitol. We need someone like you on our side."

"What exactly is your side again?" he asked.

"Law, Order, Justice. We are just trying to keep everyone safe, like you do for these people. We just do it on a larger scale."

"Uh-huh. What if I refuse for the fifth time? Will you stop coming back?" he asked.

"I'm not sure why you would refuse. This is a real shithole," Stupendous Man clenched his fists as she spoke, "Is there anyone you know here anyway?"

Colonel York noticed his response. Perhaps she was pushing too hard, she wondered. Stupendous Man thought about the people he graduated with. He hadn't seen them in years. Almost no one came to the reunions.

"I know plenty of people. I stay in close touch with a lot of my friends from back in the day," he said. He started to float around her.

"Why would you stay here? You enjoy hanging around closeted racists? Did you never find anyone that liked you outside of this dinky town, so you decided to settle? Do you get off to the god complex?" she asked. At this point, anger had taken the best of her. The thought that someone wouldn't be willing to lay down their life for the betterment of society like those that came before them enraged her.

“I’m not a god, I’m a guiding light. I’d take a closeted racist over someone openly racist. At least they know it’s bad to be that way. I don’t think anyone here is unsalvageable. They just need someone that believes in them,” he said.

“That’s a job for parents,” she responded.

“Not all parents are good at their jobs. I’m not leaving here.”

“Listen. I was a little harsh on this town. But these people are less than a fraction of a percentage of every life on this planet. They are worth no more than anyone else.”

“They’re worth more to me,” he said. He continued to float in circles around her.

“Why are you so insistent on staying here?”

“Because I believe people can be better.”

“Don’t give me that cliché crap. Why don’t you care about the other people that may die if you don’t help? I bet they could be better too,” Colonel York asked.

“Because I know these people. This town raised me when I fell from the sky as a baby. I’ve witnessed love bloom between others, the birth of children, the wonder in a young human’s eyes on Christmas morning, the way a father prepares sandwiches delicately for the youth to eat, and grandparents pushing their bodies to their limits so they can go to their descendant’s soccer games. I know every single person here and everything about them.

“A million people could die right now on the other side of the globe, and I wouldn’t care. Hundreds of humans have died since I started this sentence, and I don’t feel a thing. But I feel it when even

one person in this town dies. It's different when you know them," he said.

"Don't you realize that everyone thinks that? It's what makes you human. The fact that things can change so quickly, and you can't do anything about it," Colonel York said.

"But I'm not human and I can do something about it."

"Countless children and families will suffer if you choose to stay here."

"As long as none of the kids here die," Stupendous man said before landing on the ground right in front of her. They stood inches apart. Stupendous Man's cape ruffled through the stale air as Colonel York's hands instinctively reached for the gun in her holster.

"You don't scare me. If you refuse to come with us to help, then I have no choice but to treat it as treason," she said.

"Not like the government can do anything about it."

"Then on behalf of the United States of America I am turning you in!" Colonel York said as she raised her hand into the air.

"Ku—yu—am!"

The walkie-talkie on her hip sputtered out noise.

Moments ago, dozens of snipers got into position in the trees surrounding Stupendous Man and Colonel York as they spoke. Silently, they slung their ropes over the branches and used the spikes in their boots to scale the oak. Each of the soldiers retrieved a case off their back and opened it to reveal metal pieces lying in black foam. Delicately, dozens of sniper rifles were built.

The captain put the scope on and flipped it up. He lifted it to his eyes and watched as they continued talking in the distance over a mile away.

“Sound off when in position,” he whispered quietly into their comms.

Countless voices muttered out “in position” simultaneously.

Stupendous Man landed in front of Colonel York and the safety on the rifle clicked off. Colonel York reached for her gun.

“Don’t fire until you see the mark. Copy?”

Sweat beaded on his head as he watched them continue to talk. Stupendous Man’s cape fluttered behind him, but he wasn’t moving.

Why is his cape moving?

The captain’s sweat rolled slowly down his forehead and soaked into the cotton of his visors.

“Did you copy that?” he asked. No one responded.

“DID ANYONE COPY ME?”

We’ve been ambushed! There must be more than one. I’ve had my eye on him this whole time!

He reached for the walkie-talkie on his belt, “COLONEL YORK, IT’S AN AMBUSH! GET OUT OF THERE!”

As he spoke, the forest disappeared from his sight as color blurred around him and wind blasted past him. Instantaneously, he was in the middle of Antarctica. The captain was thrown forward and slid across an icy lake as a sonic boom cut through the air.

“I wouldn’t try anything with the snipers. I took care of them already,” Stupendous Man said. Colonel York’s eyes opened wide, but she maintained her confident posture.

“How?”

“I didn’t kill them. They are just away. I’m going to play nice with you and try my hardest not to kill anyone today. Know this, if a single civilian gets hurt in your escapade, I will topple the White House tonight. The only reason I haven’t done that yet is it hasn’t gotten in my way,” he said. His eyes lit up red.

“BETA SQUAD ATTACK!” she shouted.

Zoop! Zoop! Zoop! A speck in the air grew to the size of a man and punched Stupendous Man in the face. This man wore a suit of copper with a silver helmet that had small balls rolling across it. Stupendous Man stood unphased. He clapped his hands and with a boom the forest in front of him parted and the man in the copper suit went flying back. Stupendous Man grabbed onto the air around his neck and flung his arm forward. Something tumbled across the ground and static spread through the air before revealing a man lying on the ground with a knife in his hand.

With a boom, the ground beneath Stupendous Man erupted in flames. A woman wearing a maroon hood reached toward the quiver on her back. She notched some arrows and shot them forward. Stupendous Man’s eyes glowed red and he blasted each arrow out of the air. The sky cracked as a woman in red spandex flew forward. She spun in the air and spiraled into Stupendous Man. With a grunt, he held her back then slammed her into the ground.

The man in the copper suit put Stupendous Man in a chokehold. With a gust of wind, they were gone. Stupendous Man reappeared alone.

“What did you do to him?” Colonel York shouted with her gun pointed toward Stupendous Man.

“I put him on the moon. He probably has about ten seconds before his head bursts open,” Stupendous Man said as he shrugged his arms.

“BRING HIM BACK, NOW!” she shouted.

Stupendous Man blinked away and returned with the man in the copper suit. He threw the man forward. The man reached for his silver helmet and tore it off. His face was a dark blue as he heavily gasped for air. The archer, the invisible assassin, the woman in red spandex, and Colonel York surrounded Stupendous Man. Colonel York’s gun snapped back and forth as she shot at him. The assassin spun around him slicing at his body while the woman in red spandex pummeled him. The archer waited for an opening and rattled off arrows into him. Stupendous Man stood in the center of the chaos and heard something with his super hearing. He discerned the rattling of a shopping cart. Stupendous Man disappeared.

“WHERE IS HE! IS EVERYONE ACCOUNTED FOR?” Colonel York yelled.

In the parking lot at the front of a Transaction Tavern, an elderly woman rolled her cart up to the side of her car. She slowly walked over to the trunk and beeped the keys to open it. Stupendous Man appeared next to her. He waved to her with a grin on his face.

Every week at the same time Mrs. Frickly would go and get groceries. She would spend exactly forty-three minutes in the store before coming out. Mrs. Frickly usually bought too much to carry as she wanted to make sure she would have ample snacks for her grandchildren. Stupendous Man never skipped out on helping her put the groceries in the car, not since her husband had passed away five years ago.

“Let me help you with that, Mrs. Frickly!” he said.

“Oh, you are just the sweetest,” she said. She slowly walked to the driver’s seat. In an instant, all the groceries were loaded into the back of the car, and the shopping cart was back in the store. Stupendous Man opened the door for her and waited for her to sit down. He closed the door and waved to her as she drove off.

Stupendous Man reappeared in the field and grabbed the archer by her head and flung her into the assassin. The trees shattered as their bodies crashed through them. The man in the copper suit got up and slowly stepped forward. Stupendous Man reeled his arm back then smashed it into the metal man’s chest. He went flying off into the distance. Stupendous Man grabbed the woman in red spandex and spun her around before slamming her into the Earth. The sound of her smashing through the ground grew quieter and quieter as she fell farther and farther down. Stupendous Man turned his head toward Colonel York.

“I think we’re done here,” he said. Stupendous Man reached his arm forward and crumpled her gun then dropped it to the ground.

“There is big stuff out there, Stupendous Man, the kind of stuff only you can deal with.”

“And if it poses a threat to Rosewood, I will handle it,” he said.

“You’re insane. There is more to the world than Rosewood,” Colonel York said.

“Not to me.”

“Whatever, keep your stupid beliefs. It will feel heroic till it isn’t anymore. You should be doing more than stopping teenagers from drunk driving,” she said.

With a gust of wind, Stupendous Man disappeared.

In a small three-bedroom and two-bathroom house, a father set down his beer bottle. The table shook from the force as the foggy liquid bubbled while it settled in its glass container. He ran his one hand through his scraggly, brown beard as his other hand unbuckled his belt. His eyes scanned the room, and he only got angrier when he saw the torn, flower-covered wallpaper on the wall, the cracked tile in the floor, and the door with a hole in it. The leather on the belt was worn down with cracks from years of wear.

Mr. Roberts hadn’t always been so easy to anger. He had watched his parents yell at each other all the time as a kid and he vowed to never do the same. In elementary school, he was thought to be the nicest kid any of the teachers had ever met. Whether it was due to a lack of practice in managing his emotions or some form of cruel irony he became quick to lash out as he grew older. The fear of becoming like his parents kept him from ever seeking help.

“I didn’t want to do this, but you made me,” Mr. Roberts said to his son cowering on the ground. The son covered his face as he curled up in the corner. He had been in this situation numerous times

before. It was never as bad as he thought it would be. Even knowing that, he couldn't help but fear his father at this moment.

"Dad, I'm sorry. I'll do better next time, just please don't hit me," his son said in between sharp breaths. The man's body rocked back and forth in a drunken stupor as he held the belt with his shaky hands.

Stupendous Man appeared in front of him. He could smell the beer on the man's raspy breaths. The son peeked between his fingers to see the stalwart hero standing in front of him. His father had taught him not to cry but seeing Stupendous Man with his deep ocean colored suit and golden boots brought waves of relief. The overload of emotions brought his tears forth.

"And who do you think you are coming into my house like this?" the father asked wildly. The belt cracked as he pulled it taut in his hands.

"You know who I am."

Stupendous Man reached his hand forward and pinched the belt. It snapped. The two pieces of worn leather lost their rigidity and fell toward the ground.

"Mr. Roberts, what are you doing right now?" Stupendous Man asked. The father stared blankly forward. A shudder spread through his body. It started in his legs and spread up through his torso then out through his arms and head simultaneously. It awoke something inside him.

"I . . . Oh my. . . I'm so sorry . . . I don't know what got into me . . ." he said.

“Alcohol affects people in different ways. Some people don’t handle it as well. I keep an eye on you, and I noticed every time I have to stop you from doing this you bought alcohol the week before,” Stupendous Man calmly said as he rested his hand on the father’s back. Mr. Roberts flinched slightly at the touch of him.

“I am not going to hurt you. I want to help you,” Stupendous Man said.

“I’m a horrible person. Please break my arms. I don’t want to ever hurt my son,” Mr. Roberts said. He collapsed at Stupendous Man’s feet. He laid his head on the golden boots as he wept.

Stupendous Man kneeled next to the man and carefully thought about what to say next. Since he never really had parents, he had trouble relating to others that dealt with these issues. He opened his mouth and said, “And you won’t.”

The father wiped away his tears then said, “But that’s only because you keep stepping in to stop me.”

“Each time you wait longer and longer before you buy alcohol again. There’s a good father in you, Mr. Roberts. We just need to get past this hurdle, and we will be in the clear. Besides, I’ll always be here to step in,” Stupendous Man said.

Stupendous Man turned to the son on the ground and helped him up.

“You okay, Son?”

“I will be. Thank you, Stupendous Man,” the boy said after sniffing.

“No, thank you for being so strong. It’s not fair you have to deal with this. But know that I will always protect you when your father fails you. Don’t fear him for I will always be listening,” Stupendous Man said. He tapped his finger against his ear.

Stupendous Man raised his arms into the air to fly off before pausing to turn around. He looked back to see the son walk over to his father. They hugged and Stupendous Man disappeared.

As he flew above the town, he watched the school buses depart from Rosewood elementary school and saw the line of parents waiting to pick up their children. He noticed the cars waiting for fast food to bring home to their families. He listened to the conversation an elderly couple had about how excited they were to see their grandchild this weekend as they walked through the small, local park.

Colonel York might be right that I could achieve more if I left here. But these people are capable of achieving so much if they have someone that believes in them.

After flying in the sky for a little longer, Stupendous Man descended to land by a soccer field where dozens of little kids were kicking a ball across the grass. Half were wearing red shirts, and the other half were wearing green. On the sidelines, parents sat in folding chairs and cheered at every movement the kids made. The sun began to set in the distance as a cool breeze blew past. The lofty smell of mud had been kicked up into the air.

“Hey, Stupendous Man! You’re a little late to the game today! No worries, I got a cold Gatorade waiting for you if you wanted to pop a squat over here and watch with us!” one of the dads said. He had a dark black beard that was well kept with white bleeding in from the

edges. The man wore a bright polo shirt and khaki shorts with close toed sandals.

“That’s a job for parents.” Colonel York’s words echoed in his mind.

“As long as it is a purple one!” Stupendous Man responded.

He accepted the Gatorade and sat in the empty foldable chair next to the father.

“How was your day today?” the man asked.

“Not too bad, met some new people which you don’t get to do often around here,” Stupendous Man said.

“Did you never find anyone that liked you outside of this dinky town, so you decided to settle?”

The father chuckled then said, “No kidding, have you gotten a chance to try the new pizza place? It’s run by the same family that has the taco place but might be good!”

“I haven’t yet, maybe I’ll try it out tomorrow,” Stupendous Man responded.

“You’re insane. There is more to the world than Rosewood.”

One of the girls in a red shirt kicked the ball and it slowly rolled past a girl in a green shirt standing in the goal. The parents and Stupendous Man erupted in applause.

“Who do you think is gonna win tonight? The Red Elmos or the Green Apples?” the father asked.

“I’m thinking Red Elmos, but who’s to be sure,” he said as he finished reliving the conversation in his head.

Not to me.

Stupendous Man took a sip of his purple Gatorade and leaned back. A girl in a green shirt threw the ball back onto the field.

Carry Me Out

"I need a father. I need a mother. I need some older, wiser being to cry to. I talk to God . . ." – Sylvia Plath

Abigail Atner held the golden rod steady as she paced down the center aisle of her church. All eyes were on her as she carried the Light of Christ to the front of the room. She delicately lit the right candle then the left, just as she was trained, before quietly turning around. Her father watched her proud that his daughter was finally contributing to church and moving closer to God. Perhaps he just liked the fact it was *his* daughter in front of everyone.

She stumbled on her way back and fell forward. Her eyes shut closed to hide the impending impact from her mind. When she reopened her eyes, she was in the body of a fifty-year-old woman falling through the air. Air rushed across her suit and synthetic hairs fluttered in the wind. The wind effortlessly crossed over her dirty Kevlar costume lit by the moon.

In her arms, a woman screamed out in rage. She had long, red hair. Instead of hands, at her elbows, blades replaced her forearms. She swung viciously at Mongoose and the blades scratched into her armor. Abigail took the hits as what mattered was making sure she held Blady toward the ground so she would break the fall. With a loud thud they both collapsed against the concrete. Mongoose slowly rolled herself off Blady and stood back up. She stared at Blady who had made an imprint in the ground.

Blady stirred slightly.

“Why won’t you die?” Mongoose asked as she walked forward. She kicked Blady in the stomach and she went flying into the air. Midair, she repositioned herself, so she landed on her feet and slid to a stop with her blades scratching against the ground.

“How’d you find me? I’ve done everything to keep you heroes off my back,” Blady said.

“Your stench hangs heavy in the air. Any half-decent predator could smell you,” Mongoose said. This was a half-lie.

Blady ran forward and jumped up. She spun through the air. Her blades crashed against Mongoose’s body. Her years of training were apparent as she ran through every move she knew dancing around Mongoose dabbling her with slashes.

What would happen when she had performed every move she had been taught and Mongoose still stood? Never before had someone so carelessly experienced her assault. Mongoose raised her arms up to block any attacks from reaching under her armor. She just needed to get one good hit in. If she could grab Blady it would be over. She watched Blady dance through the air looking for any sort of pattern.

Her moment to strike arrived. Mongoose ripped her arm out and grabbed Blady’s upper arm. Mongoose pulled her close and broke the blades over her knees. The bodies of the blades flew upward. Mongoose grabbed them and jammed the pieces of metal into Blady’s chest. She staggered before falling forward onto her knees. Mongoose

rammed her foot upward into Blady's chin and she was knocked onto the ground.

As Blady clung to her life quietly in the night, Mongoose returned home to obtain her next mission.

The following evening, Abigail was awoken from her sleep by letters clicking. White tiles flipped over one another to slowly spell out a message on her split-flap display. She calmly donned her costume while she waited for the address to form. Abigail lifted the heavy Kevlar outfit over her body, so it covered her skintight spandex suit. The headpiece to the suit was connected to the torso and she slipped her face into it.

The first part of the address was spelled out. "193". The board continued to hum as letters slowly fell into place.

Her hands, covered in scars and weathered skin, tightened the strap beneath her chin. The headpiece covered her entire face with two pieces of black plastic over her eyes. A pair of low ears pointed out of the top of the helmet.

"193 Levi Drive."

Abigail finished tightening the straps on her gloves and walked over to the table by her bed. She picked up a frame containing the picture of a man and a woman and held it to her chest briefly. The Mongoose exited her room.

It was the middle of the night when she parked her car one block from the address. She dove into the shadows of the buildings and emerged from the alleys to see a large warehouse. Three men stood at the entrance each of them with crowbars in hand.

The moon cast a large shadow from the warehouse onto the ground, and she used it to disguise her approach.

“You hear about the assassinations at the other sites? It’s ramping up,” one of the men said. Mongoose continued to approach while they spoke. She remained hunched over and close to the ground.

“They couldn’t even get an ID on the bodies . . . they were so mangled,” another guard said. Her foot contacted a can, and it rattled across the ground.

“What was that?” the first man asked. Mongoose stood up straight and the men locked eyes with her.

“Thank God. It’s just a superhero. Kill her!” the man shouted as the other two charged Mongoose. She ran forward and grabbed the men by their head then lifted them into the air. They struggled briefly before she slammed her fists together. Their skulls collided and shattered instantly. Porous chunks of gray matter and bright red blood just now touched by oxygen splattered through the air. The bodies fell to the ground and all that was left in her hands were chunks of flesh. She flicked her hands clean and continued her approach.

“Holy shit. You guys aren’t supposed to kill people,” the man said. He began to run toward the door of the warehouse.

From a distance, all that could be made out were two shadows. The one with pointed ears bent to the ground and moved its hand around until it picked up what it was looking for. The other was sprinting with its legs extended and arms swinging. A thin, pointed object flew through the air and pierced the running shadow in its neck.

Mongoose approached the man squirming on the ground as he attempted to pry the piece of bone from his neck. She ripped it out and blood erupted in bursts. He opened his mouth to speak but was stopped by her boot coming down upon him. Her sole squelched when she rubbed it against the ground.

She ripped his chest open with her bare hands and scraped away the flesh at the surface to reach his ribs. Each rib cracked when it was torn out and she did not stop until eight of them lay on the ground. Once she had that many, she nested them in between the base of her fingers and stood back up.

Seconds before, a grunt in the warehouse listened to the sound of bones cracking outside. She waved her hand to signal everyone to get to their positions. Had everything in her life led to this? Was she meant to be mercilessly killed by some vigilante? This was supposed to be a temporary gig. She was going to do this for a few months just so she could get off the ground. Perhaps she was never going to get the chance to open that café. Her hands had a slight shake as they put her hair into a ponytail. Less hair out meant less for the monster to grab at. She retreated into the shadows.

Mongoose kicked the door open. With a loud groan it swung forward. As soon as she entered, she was greeted by gunfire. Bullets fired off and lodged themselves in her skin. Her body rocked back and forth from the force of the metal piercing her body.

The gunfire ceased and she fell to the ground.

“Did we get her?” the grunt with the blond ponytail asked. She stepped from the shadows. Nineteen people followed behind her.

Bullets clinked against the ground, but no one was moving. Mongoose stirred slightly.

“Something isn’t right. Get back!” a grunt shouted.

“No. No one could have survived that,” she said. She inspected Mongoose.

Mongoose swiped her arm forward and a piece of bone ripped into the woman’s skin. She began to collapse to the ground and as she did Mongoose leapt up. Mongoose wrapped her arms around the woman’s neck and positioned herself behind the woman. She pushed the rib cage fragments against her back.

“Walk,” a raspy voice demanded.

“Please. I didn’t . . .”

“WALK!”

She took one step forward. Her eyes were shut as her lips began to quiver. At this moment, all the woman could think of was the last time she had eaten a meal with her family. It had to have been

Christmas. She hadn't given the meal much thought as it was assumed an Easter breakfast was guaranteed.

"Don't shoot. Just let us by . . ." the blond-haired grunt said.

Bone began to dig into her flesh. Mongoose urged her to pick up the pace as blood began to trickle slowly down the woman's back.

The echo of a gunshot rang through the warehouse. A small chunk of metal lodged itself in the woman's forehead. Another life gone. All her hopes, dreams, and aspirations worthless. Mongoose pushed against the back of the woman and used her as a battering ram. She ran forward and more grunts began firing. The woman's lifeless corpse flopped up and down with each step Mongoose took. Her tied hair waved in the air.

Once Mongoose reached the group, she flung the corpse forward, knocking down about three of them. She fought the rest all at the same time.

Frequently, a fight such as this would be described as a dance. The hero would effortlessly bounce between each criminal delivering swift blows and evading retaliation. Light shines upon them as this pillar of human morals and determination pushes forward to create a better day for society.

Not tonight. Each punch delivered by Mongoose was slow and deliberate. Her fists spent whole seconds smashing against a face as blood splattered into the air and flesh tore. She did not evade every hit. When someone was lucky enough to make contact, she staggered back

before continuing her assault. At one point, she managed to catch an arm flying toward her. She slammed it down against her knee and the forearm separated from their body.

A bright light did not shine down upon her. Dim, artificial light caressed the carcasses and illuminated Mongoose. All she shared with these heroes was determination. Her soul burned with rage as she tore down every adversary. Like a wild animal, she mauled each of them.

When no one was left standing, she turned around and went home. She showered, prayed to God, then went to bed.

The following morning, Abigail sat in a diner across from her friend, Ahisma. Waiters quickly bustled around as plates clattered against each other and people chattered over their food. Bright red and white tiling covered the floor. The worker's suits were a similarly bright, but fake, color.

Abigail carefully watched the box TV above the kitchen. Four people were being interviewed. One of them was a man wearing a bright green costume that resembled a snake. He stood proudly behind three other women.

The one front and center wore jeans and had her hair tied back by a bandana. Long chains hung from her hands. Another woman wore a green Kevlar suit with large shields on both of her arms. She had a large H plastered on her helmet. The final woman was shorter than the rest and wore a leather jacket with a necklace on. A small, yellow totem hung on it.

“How did you guys manage to stop that drug sale?” the news reporter asked.

“Well, once Totem managed to find the location, it didn’t take much for Hero and I to capture each of the criminals,” the woman with the chains in her hands said.

“I was there too! I coiled around a couple of them so the team could get some easy hits in!” the man in the snake suit said.

“What bullshit,” Abigail said. She looked over to Ahisma.

“What? The Protectors for Profit? You know people don’t have to pay anymore to get help from them,” Ahisma said. She looked up from her menu. Her black hair was tied in a bun.

“It’s not the money. It’s the game they play. You can’t capture villains. People die. It’s a part of life,” Abigail said. She took a sip of her black coffee.

“Abby, you know I don’t like talking about this. Besides, people need something to look up to and that’s what heroes do.”

“That’s what God does,” Abigail said.

“As far as I see it, he hasn’t felt the need to inspire hope recently.”

“He does in me.”

“There’s a difference between authority and inspiration,” Ahisma said sharply.

“Only one of those gets results,” Abigail responded.

“Are you talking about that board of yours? Don’t tell me you got another message—Let me see your hands,” Ahisma said. She reached over the table.

“No,” Abigail said. She resisted the pull on her arms. Eventually, she gave up and her hands came into view. Ahisma stared quietly at the gashes across her knuckles. Scabs scattered her palms.

“Abby, oh my . . . How many were there?”

“About twenty-three.”

“Did you leave any alive?”

“No.”

“How could you do that? You’re not in the army anymore and you don’t have to kill. We do things differently at home because it isn’t a war here.”

“That’s what you don’t get. It is a war—”

“I know and you’re God’s soldier. It’s not God sending those messages on your board,” Ahisma said. She knew Abigail’s usual speech by heart.

“Who could it be then?”

“What can I get for you girls?” a waiter asked. Neither of them had noticed his approach.

“I’ll just take the breakfast special,” Abigail said.

“Same for me, but scratch the bacon,” Ahisma said.

The waiter nodded before walking off. Ahisma took a sip from her iced water.

“You can’t trust that board. We have no idea what it is or why it keeps sending you to these places,” Ahisma said.

“Why can’t I trust it? Every single time it takes me right to criminals.”

“And how do you know they deserve to die? What if you get led to some kid spraying graffiti?”

“Because God knows who needs to die,” Abigail said. She sipped her freshly filled cup of coffee.

“It’s not God sending you those messages. I don’t know how that board works but it could be anything. It could be a rival gang specifically sending you after enemies to open territory or maybe it’s an evil magician tricking you.”

“Then I will kill them too,” Abigail said. This discussion seemed pointless to her.

“You don’t care about justice or God. You just need someone telling you what to do. You don’t care if it’s your parents, the army, God, or anyone else! I know how you work, but I don’t get why you won’t listen to what I tell you then!”

Abigail did not respond. They had been through this conversation numerous times before, but this was the first time Ahisma

said that. Perhaps that new, slightly deeper cutting comment would change the normal outcome.

Each time Ahisma would desperately plead to Abigail. She knew the kind of person Abigail was before her time serving. She had been the only person there for Ahisma all her life. Ahisma still remembered every name she had been called. Her parents would tell her things like, “It gets better when you grow older.” Maybe they would say, “Don’t listen to them. You’ll be more successful someday.” It never changed and it only became more common as she aged. Even worse, she wasn’t more successful than them. Abigail was the only person by her side through it all.

But she was different after her time in the army was done. They used her then dumped her. A soldier left to wake up and go to church or cook meals. You can’t just go back to normal.

Abigail grew frustrated. Ahisma would never understand. She got to just stay here. She still had her parents. She had a husband. She didn’t know what it was like to be alone.

“You don’t get it. I have no one. I’m too old to ever have kids and no man is going to even think of coming near me. My parents were dead weeks after I got back. There’s nothing to my life. This board gives me purpose. I’m fifty years old, Ahisma. There isn’t a happy ending for me past this point.”

The reporter on the TV stopped interviewing the heroes and it cut to a news anchor at his desk.

“Reports are just coming in of a massacre that occurred in a warehouse last night. Twenty-two were found dead. Bodies are still being identified,” the man said.

“I though you said there were twenty-three?” Ahisma asked.

“There were.”

“There was only one survivor from last night. She has been put in emergency care at Anika Hospital,” the man continued to say.

“I didn’t finish the job . . .”

“Don’t do it,” Ahisma pleaded.

“What are you going to do? Call the Protectors on me?” Abigail asked.

“You aren’t the government’s puppet anymore. You can decide who you want to be.”

“Go back home to your husband,” Abigail said. She got up to leave.

That night, Mongoose approached the hospital. She looked up at the tall building to see a bright red cross glowing in the night.

A metal plate crashed into the back of her head, and she turned around to see Hero step out of the shadows. Chainlink, Cobra Commando, and Totem stood behind her.

“I don’t want to hurt you guys. We’re on the same side,”
Mongoose said.

“I beg to differ. I’ve read mongoose kill snakes to eat,” Cobra
Commando said.

“This doesn’t have to end with bloodshed,” Hero said.

Totem was quietly muttering something to herself as they spoke. Yellow energy began to form around her. Abigail knew their conversation was simply a distraction so Totem could charge up. It was time for Mongoose to take action.

“When doesn’t it end that way?” Mongoose asked. She ran forward and rammed into Hero, knocking her into Chainlink. They both toppled to the ground.

With a swift strike from Mongoose’s boot, Totem went spiraling through the air and crashed against the ground. The yellow energy faded as she lost consciousness. She ran forward and grabbed Cobra Commando by his head. She twisted it around but heard no crack.

“You knew my power was to contort, right? Or did you just try and kill me?” Cobra Commando asked.

He twisted his body, so he wrapped his legs and arms around her. Mongoose flexed her arms while he continued to tighten. Like taffy stuck to your teeth, she eventually pried him off and flung him into the ground.

A chain lashed outward and struck Mongoose across the face. Her helmet tilted sideways. As she adjusted it, Hero ran forward. She shouted out before leaping into the air and smashed her fist into Mongoose's face. Her helmet ripped off her head and clattered to the ground.

Abigail staggered back and was met by Chainlink's fist. The two heroes rallied Abigail between each other like a tennis ball. She was knocked from Hero to Chainlink and back to Hero as they pummeled her.

At this instant, all she could think of was the smell of the pews in her church. The dried oak that would creak at the slightest touch. To the right, her mother was beginning to doze off as the sermon dragged on. Abigail quietly drew pictures on the back of the offering envelopes to kill time. Pictures of fantastical heroes bashing away fictitious villains were etched on the back of the paper.

Abigail was lashed again and toppled over toward Hero who uppercut her. She flew through the air and tumbled across the ground. The scrapes from the sidewalk quickly healed.

Abigail spit blood from her mouth.

"She has a name. Her name is Afra. She has dreams. She is no different from any of us," Hero said.

"You don't get to just execute people," Chainlink said.

Abigail quietly picked herself up then said, "She should have picked a better profession."

“Please. I don’t want to keep fighting,” Hero said.

Chainlink’s chain swung toward Abigail. She grabbed the end of it and ripped it toward herself. Chainlink went flying and Abigail’s fist rammed into her stomach.

A small grunt of pain escaped her mouth with the blood she spit out onto Abigail. Chainlink fell to the ground. Hero ran forward and rolled her over. She ignored Abigail who walked past her.

“Stop her . . .” Chainlink whispered into Hero’s ear.

“But you’re bleeding,” Hero said.

“I am going to be fine. Afra won’t be.”

Abigail entered the lobby of the hospital. The bright blue, fluorescent lights shined down on her. The patients quickly grew quiet once she stepped forward. Blood dripped off her costume.

She approached the clerk and asked, “Afra. What room?”

“I can’t tell you that, Miss.” the clerk said. His voice cracked from the fear rising out of his stomach.

Mongoose slammed her fists down on the counter.

“... 236.”

Abigail walked past the bright red sign and into the hallway leading toward the stairwell. The echo of her boots rang through the corridor. It was quiet. The nurses stood frozen watching her continue her approach.

She opened the door to the stairs and was ripped back. Hero tore her away from the door and threw her against the ground. Abigail pushed herself back up. They stood there quietly staring at each other. Crimson fluid dripped off their outfits and bruises covered their faces.

“I can’t let you kill her,” Hero said.

“You people love telling others what to do,” Abigail muttered before running forward. She crashed into Hero and knocked her against the wall. The wind was knocked out of Hero when Abigail’s fist collided with her stomach.

“You fight in this fake war where you smile for the cameras, and the bad guys drop quips. That isn’t what it’s like in real war. People get shot and when you open your eyes all you can see is that you’re the one holding the gun,” Abigail said. Her fists continued to racket off Hero’s bones.

“We stand for something . . . People need something to look up to. They need to see that they can be better, that they can be more,” Hero choked out.

“No. They need authority.”

Abigail threw her to the side and Hero slid across the ground. She continued up the stairs and marched to Room 236. She kicked open the door and saw Afra lying in the bed with the blanket covering her body. Tubes poked out from the blanket and entered machines next to the bed where the screens showed various lines pushing up and down.

Abigail stomped forward and slammed her fist down into the bed. Her fist crashed through a pile of pillows and into a beartrap. It snapped down on her arm, and she screamed out in pain. The door to the hospital room closed and she turned around to see a man standing behind her. He wore cargo pants, a camo vest, and had black paint striped under his eyes. His hair was spiked in the air and an assault rifle hung over his back.

She knew who this was. Soldier 21, one of the government's lackies. Where he was, Battle Gal and H8ywire were likely one step behind.

"From one soldier to another, I must say I respect you," Soldier 21 said. He watched Abigail squirm. She couldn't tell if he was disgusted or enthralled.

"What are you doing here? Government only sends you out to clean up messes and I was just about to finish cleaning up this one," she said. She clenched her muscles, seizing from the pain, and wondered what he was doing here. There were no government missions in progress on home territory as far as she knew.

"One hundred and thirty-six kills. You are incredible," he said. His blue eyes shined under the hospital lights.

"I only ever killed ten people while serving."

"The war never stopped, Abigail."

"Why aren't you helping me?" Abigail pleaded.

“Just heal it off. That is one of the powers the government’s experiment gave you after all.”

“I can’t. I just keep healing over the metal teeth. I can’t heal until it’s off me.”

“Glad to hear it’s working as planned.”

“As planned?” Abigail asked. She slowly began to put the pieces together. They were here to clean up a mess. They were sent to kill her.

“You’re out of control, Abby. You served a real purpose here. A soldier on the streets willing to eliminate any criminal that stood in your way. I know how you think. You’re a fighter and a doer, but you’ve gone off the rails. Government thought with your parents out of the picture they could point you in a direction with that fancy board.” Abigail’s stomach dropped at the suggestion of her board’s true origin.

“I thought it was a little crazy myself, but they knew you were a religious freak, so they thought you’d bite. I’ll be damned if their plan didn’t turn out perfectly. Except, at this point you’re a rabid animal snapping at anything that gets too close. I’m here to clean up the mess.”

“My parents? WHAT DID YOU DO TO THEM?”

“Made their lives mean something,” he said.

“I’ll kill you as soon as I get this off,” she said. She began to muster her strength in order to take action.

“Sounds like a plan,” he said.

“Was Afra ever alive?” Abigail asked. She winced. The slightest movement of her arm caused the teeth to dig farther into her flesh. She questioned where she had gone wrong to force the government to sick their hounds on her.

“Never. Just needed to get you here,” he said.

“You are a controlling piece of shit and I’m going to be sure that you end up in Hell even if it takes dragging you down with me,” she said. Abigail slowly stood back up.

“I think it’s best you stay down,” he said. Abigail stumbled toward him. The wall behind him erupted from a woman crashing through it. She donned bright red and yellow armor. She wielded a mace in her hand. Her golden helmet glistened under the artificial lighting. She knocked Abigail back. A tall robot followed her. It was in similar proportions to a human but rounded in between its limbs and had only one large, blue eye.

Battle Gal’s mace smashed into Abigail’s face, knocking her to the ground. Soldier 21 stepped onto the bear trap on her arm. It pressed into her flesh, and she screamed out in pain. The teeth drew blood that pooled around Abigail.

“Wonder if it has hit bone yet?” he asked.

Chainlink appeared in the hole created by Battle Gal. She was hunched over as the weight of tonight bore down on her.

“What the hell . . . is happening in here?” Chainlink asked.

“It does not concern you,” Battle Gal said.

“I came here to protect lives. Not a single person is going to die tonight,” Chainlink said.

“H8ywire, take care of her,” Battle Gal said. The robot nodded and began stepping toward Chainlink who prepared for another fight.

Abigail took advantage of the brief moment Battle Gal was looking away to rip her arm back. She shouted in agony as her hand tore off her body. Flesh tore from flesh and ligaments separated from bone. The pain was so immense it was barely possible for her mind to register it.

She grabbed the bear trap and threw it at Soldier 21’s face. It collided with him, and he went flying backward. Before the bear trap could crush his face against the wall, a chain whipped forward and yanked the bear trap. Chainlink ripped it backward, so it collided into H8ywire.

“I said NO KILLING!” Chainlink shouted.

Solider 21 collided with the wall and slumped over. Chainlink continued to swing the bear trap, offensively scraping it against H8ywire’s body.

Chainlink knew she would not win this battle. Her energy had been drained from her fight earlier and this mechanical marvel would likely pose a threat even if she was at her best. Her only hope was to hold out long enough for Abigail. She was able to beat all the

Protectors earlier; there was no doubt she could handle Battle Gal then H8ywire. She just needed time.

Abigail's left arm hung in the air. Blood spurted out of her wound. It quickly healed over, and a stump of flesh was formed at the end of her arm. For the first time she could remember, there was no anger, at least she didn't feel any. Where would she have directed it? Everyone had used her.

Everything had been meaningless. All those people dead at war, but at least she thought she had to do that to protect her family at home. Without them, why bother protecting home? After their funeral, the mysterious board appeared. She thought God had finally taken pity on her and decided to give her another purpose. From the very start, it was a hoax.

She'd channeled everything she felt into hunting criminals. If she erased enough evil from the face of this Earth maybe it would bring her parents back to it. Maybe if she served God enough, He would forgive her for what she had done while serving. At the very least, she may be granted the opportunity to meet with her parents after. It had been acceptable for emotions to burn brighter than ever because it was directed by the Man up high Himself, but it was the man in the chair the whole time. Authority never cared about what happened to her, just what she could do.

Abigail was so deep in thought she didn't think about the fight going on in front of her. She mindlessly dodged swings from the mace. Chains rang out from Chainlink swinging the beartrap against

H8ywire's body. The robot detangled the beartrap from her chains and threw the hunk of metal off to the side.

"I was told you were a warrior. Has your spirit finally broken?" Battle Gal asked. She had a sly grin. It was clear she enjoyed what was happening right now.

Had God ever been there? Were those Sundays wasted? If God was never here, then where were her parents?

Chainlink wrapped the chains around H8ywire's neck and pulled downward. The robot collapsed to the ground and while it was restrained, she spoke, "Abigail, I know what it's like to be angry. To feel like you've been doing everything for the wrong reasons. To be angry at the world. To be angry at God. There's never anywhere to put it all, but tonight there is. Fight back!"

Abigail continued to effortlessly dodge Battle Gal's attacks. She knew she could just give in. Without her mission, there was no purpose anymore. She watched Chainlink continue her onslaught against H8ywire. Chainlink stumbled and H8ywire's body whirled. His arm spun upward, knocking her back.

She flew into the wall cracking the plaster. H8ywire stepped forward while Chainlink shakily pushed herself back up. Her arms trembled as the weight of her own body felt to be too much. H8ywire's leg rotated upward, kicking Chainlink in the stomach. She rolled backward so she now lay on the ground facing the ceiling. Her breathing was slow. She stared upward.

Abigail didn't know if she wanted to end it here, but Chainlink wasn't supposed to stop now. She was still young. There was still time to be saved.

Battle Gal swung forward again, but Abigail grabbed her by the wrist with her right hand and held her steady.

"Go ahead. Hit me with your left hand," Battle Gal said with a smirk.

Abigail rammed the stump of her arm against Battle Gal's face. Teeth flew into the air and as she stumbled backward her helmet was ripped off by a right hand. Abigail held the helmet in her hand and swung it forward. It smashed against Battle Gal's head. The metal rang out.

Abigail continued to swing it right then left, right then left, crashing it into her skull. Battle Gal fell to the ground, and Abigail lifted the helmet into the air planning to pierce her chest with it. She deserved it after all, didn't she? H8ywire stumbled toward Chainlink. She deserved this, didn't she?

Abigail began to swing the helmet downward but instead threw it to the right. It flew and sliced H8ywire's body right beneath the head. His head separated from his body, and he stumbled to the ground.

She picked Battle Gal up by her shirt. Battle Gal spit blood from her mouth onto Abigail's face. The red slowly slipped down her purple cheeks.

“You’re a killer. You were one in the military. You were one at home. It’s what you do. What’s one more . . .”

Abigail looked over to Chainlink who continued to breathe quietly on the ground. Her blue and white striped shirt was stained dark brown from oil and blood.

“You can’t make it on your own. You need someone guiding you like a missile whether it be the military or the idea of God. I know people like you. You self-destruct on your own.”

Visions of her parents crossed her mind. She inhaled heavily. Her chest ached from the night’s battles.

Abigail let go of Battle Gal who collapsed onto the ground.

She hobbled over to the hospital bed where she had originally believed Afra to be resting. Sparks flew off H8ywire’s body, blood seeped out of Battle Gal’s mouth, and Chainlink exhaled slowly. Abigail kneeled at the bedside and looked up to the ceiling.

She screamed.

Chainlink tilted her head to the side and watched Abigail wail in agony through her squinted eyes. At this moment, Abigail could finally see through the cracks. The government may have been the one pulling the strings, but it was the world that had left her so vulnerable. It was everything’s fault. Every single thing in her life had closed off any other option. Her youth had been wasted at war and no one valued what remained after.

Without her board dishing out directions, there was nothing to use as a guiding star in this dark sea. Now no longer distracted by looking at the sky for directions, it was apparent how lost she was. With no mission to hide behind all Abigail could do was soak in the fact she knew she would never have kids. There would be no celebration of her daughter's baptism. She would never come home to a partner that made her dinner. No one knew her favorite type of candy. There was no white picket fence in her future. No dog would ever come when she called.

No one left in this world loved her. She was a ghost in the making to others. These people didn't believe in spirits but would still tune in to watch celebrities hunt them on the travel channel. They'd walk past and listen to her moan, crying out for someone to please save her before she sunk below the surface. No one would stop because what benefit would saving her provide? There was a He waiting at home that would fix her. There would never be relief from this anguish.

She wiped her eyes with her only arm and looked over at Chainlink who stared quietly at her.

"I'm sorry . . ." Chainlink muttered through her torn lips.

Abigail picked up Chainlink so she rested over her shoulder and carried her toward the front desk. The path stormed across minutes ago now felt long and unbearable. Right foot first then the left foot. That was the only way to make it out. That's all she had ever done. One foot in front of the other. She returned to the desk at the front and laid Chainlink's body on it.

A nurse ran forward then looked Abigail up and down. He stared at the stump where her arm should be. Her mouth was dry from the battle and her muscles ached. Blood rapidly pumped across her body as the adrenaline still coated her veins.

“We—We can help treat that,” he said. Abigail heard what he said but could barely understand it. Her world spun around her now that it had been ripped up by the roots.

Abigail knew how these people saw her. She was a feral animal cornered and beaten. They didn’t see her as an equal. Support came from a place of pity instead of comradery. She would never be viewed like the other heroes. Any semblance of nobility was masked by a thin spattering of blood.

“STAY AWAY FROM ME!” she shouted before pushing him to the side.

On the way out she grabbed her helmet off the ground and slid it over her head.

“I need a father. I need a mother. I need some older, wiser being to cry to. I talk to God, but the sky is empty.” – Sylvia Plath

It's Like Fighting a Supervillain

A couple sat on a pair of wire chairs outside of a restaurant waiting to place their order. He intermittently held eye contact with her as he shuffled in his chair. It was a hot day early in the summer and he was hoping she couldn't see the sweat stains on his back. She was hoping he couldn't see the sweat pooling beneath her armpits.

He had heard good things of this French restaurant and had been waiting to take her to this place since they first started talking. It was toward the outskirts of Skum City, so hopefully that would mean there wouldn't be much chance of getting caught in a brawl. His hair wasn't sitting quite how he wanted it to when he was styling it this morning, but hopefully it looked good for her. Her brown hair looked beautiful as the sun revealed the countless tones usually hidden underneath artificial light.

She was excited to try something from the menu in front of them. His hair looked so cute with some of it sticking up in the back. There was something about his nervous smile that made her smile too. If only he could maintain eye contact with her so she could enjoy the color of his irises.

A purple blur whizzed past them followed by a gust of wind knocking their menus into the air.

Was that Crepe Palace? Momentum thought. He swung through the air holding two miniature harpoon guns in his hands. Sticking out of each barrel was an anchor attached to a long rope

threading through the gun and onto loops of wire hanging pooled on a belt attached to his waist. One was currently anchored above in the top floor of a tall building. As he prepared to fire his other anchor to continue moving, he craned his neck back to stare at the random couple.

That was the place we went to together last—

Momentum collided with a sign attached to the side of a building. He slid down the brown printing that spelled out “Springer’s Clocks: The hour hand made by our hand”. Falling a short distance, he landed on the sidewalk. The muffled sound of clocks clicking and ticking could be heard through the glass windows.

A gloved hand reached out to him, and he grabbed hold of the yellow spandex.

“Dom, you must stop looking backward when you’re swinging,” Tensile said.

Momentum brushed some debris off his purple spandex suit. He bent down to retie his shoes. They had come loose while whirling through the air. The tips of his boots were coated in steel that was prime for bashing criminals with.

“Sorry, it’s just—” he stopped talking as he already knew what she would say if he told her what distracted him. She wouldn’t have understood. She couldn’t fathom looking backward while swinging.

“How did you even catch up to me?” Momentum asked.

“Cutting through the buildings is a lot quicker than swinging around them,” she said. She adjusted her purple leather jacket. They had been training together for months now, but Momentum kept making the same mistake of looking back. You’d think it would be obvious to watch where you’re going when swinging at high speeds, but somehow, something would always break his focus.

A gray ball rolled up to them and unfolded to reveal a man. He wore a light gray, skintight suit with large, curved metal pieces covering his back. The backing of his suit was a darker color and split into seven dark colored panels covering him from his head down to his legs. Six fake arms limply stuck out from the panels on each side of the suit.

“What are you two doing back here? Wishing Prism is a few more blocks down,” Pillbug-Man said. Momentum opened his mouth in preparation for admitting to his mistake. “WAIT! Are we doing a quick pep talk before the fight? I’m so glad that lesson stuck with you,” Pillbug-Man said. His voice raised in pitch signaling him getting more and more excited thinking about pep talks.

“Yeah, we were just about to put our hands in,” Tensile said. She tightened the endless, purple scarf that cascaded down her chest then extended her hand outward. Momentum briefly looked over to her then down at her hand. He put his hand over hers.

Pillbug-Man put his hand in then said, “Team on three. One. Two. Three!”

“Team!” they shouted.

Pillbug-Man rolled across the ground tearing up concrete on his approach to Wishing Prism who hovered in the air. He had two strands of dark green cloth stretching down from his shoulders and past his feet. They flapped in the wind as smoke spewed out of thin air. A golden triangular prism floated where the man's head should be.

Tensile spun her scarf through the air, crashing the cloth against the countless mirages of herself that surrounded her. She regretted having to eliminate each of these women with long, black hair that naturally curled in on itself stylishly covering their foreheads in dark locks from existence. To remove perfection from this realm seemed like a fruitless endeavor. Alas, there could only be one.

In the background of the battle, Momentum swung across the street picking up civilians so he could relocate them farther from the fight. The green storm of energy forming above Wishing Prism cast an eerie aura that contrasted the purple spandex of his suit and reflected off the metal around his waist.

Instantaneously, he felt lighter. Each movement he made felt predetermined and perfectly executed. He could control his inertia as he whirled through the air and effortlessly spun from civilian to civilian.

Pillbug-Man was stopped in his tracks by a man in bright orange spandex. He wore a long cape, and a large "J" was printed on his chest. Pillbug-Man uncurled and stared at his unaged friend.

“Justice?” Pillbug-Man asked. His heart pattered at the sight of his long-gone enemy to almost best friend.

“Indeed. It is good to see you, Nemesis,” Justice said.

He said the word. He called Pillbug-Man his nemesis. His brown beard was perfectly trimmed around his face, and his abs were incredibly chiseled, but Pillbug-Man knew this wasn’t real. This was a manifestation of his greatest wish. Wishing Prism was trying to slow them down.

“You’re—You can’t be real. You’ve been gone for decades,” Pillbug-Man said.

“I have been waiting for the right time to see you again.”

“Nope. Not doing this today. Today’s been a good day so far,” Pillbug-Man said. The emerald tinted clouds continued to grow above them.

Justice rolled his eyes. He let loose a calm sigh then said, “You caught me. I am not real, but the fact that you did not help the actual me enough will always be real.”

“I was always there for you. I always believed in you.”

“If that was true, then why do you spend your days trying to atone for it?” Justice asked.

“It’s not atoning. I’m just making no other superhero turns out like you even if I have to train every single one of them,” Pillbug-Man said.

“You disappoint me even in the afterlife,” Justice said. He slammed his fists together and cracked his knuckles. One step at a time, he approached Pillbug-Man who slowly stepped backward.

“You never could hurt me when you were a villain. Maybe you can try now? It could not hurt to give it a shot,” Justice said. He smirked. Pillbug-Man staggered away from him. Pillbug-Man knew it was a mirage. He just had to believe that, and Justice could be easily dispatched.

A metal boot flew through the back of Justice, and he erupted in a plume of green smoke. Momentum skid to a stop next to Pillbug-Man.

Pillbug-Man laughed nervously before saying, “Wow, you must have done a good job fighting your mirage to be able to help me out.”

“I never had anything show up,” Momentum said as his hook retracted back into his gun.

Pillbug-Man wondered how it was possible. He had seen Justice and Momentum had seen clones of herself. There was no way Wishing Prism forgot to make Momentum’s wish come true. It was supposed to be the same for everyone. He would summon a manifestation of the person or thing you wanted most.

“Interesting. I think it is about time we wrap this up!” Pillbug-Man said with a wink.

Pillbug-Man wrapped into a gray ball and rolled forward, increasing in speed. He rolled off a car, rocketed upward, uncurled,

and uppercut Wishing Prism crashing his fist against the triangular prism. Wishing Prism fell backward and tumbled across the ground. Numerous smaller golden prisms slid out of his pockets. Pillbug-Man stuck the landing as Wishing Prism fell unconscious.

At that instant, the weight of the world bore back down on Momentum. His movements became uncertain, and he could feel his sweaty hair latching to the back of his ear. The plaque stuck to his teeth returned to perception and his stomach felt tight against the lining of his pants.

“Wishing Prism is going to prison!” Pillbug-Man shouted. He briefly maintained his pose before hunching over. His lungs tore oxygen out from the air flustered by his burst of action. Beneath the suit, his once muscular legs were now covered in saggy skin. His once auburn hair now stained gray. His once wide eyes now struggled to stay open past eight in the evening.

“Getting a tad old for this. Regardless, that’s how you knock a criminal unconscious. I learned that because of experience from the other end!”

Tensile walked over and stared at the body on the ground. She said, “You can’t just knock someone unconscious. It is an unbelievably small middle area unconsciousness falls between brain damage and them getting back up.”

Momentum skid to stop next to her. He said, “I don’t know, Mal. Looks pretty unconscious to me.”

“Dom gets it. That was pretty exciting, right?” Pillbug-Man asked, nodding chalantly toward Momentum. He had been working to pull Momentum out of a slump for a while now. It would be done in due time.

“Yeah, it was a little fun,” Momentum said before giving a quiet laugh. He wasn’t sure if he was comforted by Pillbug-Man’s indiscrete hints. Did his apparent empathy outweigh in value Momentum’s awareness that others could see through his facade?

“I almost saw some life in those eyes when you crashed into the mirage of Justice,” Tensile said.

“We’ll rekindle that love of life for you, Dom. All in due time,” Pillbug-Man said.

“I wouldn’t say that’s—” Momentum began to say.

“Nope. Say nothing more. You needn’t feel any guilt. Each hero must have a journey of self-discovery, and this is yours,” Pillbug-Man said without letting Momentum say another word. Pillbug-Man was familiar with helping others and he would pull Momentum through this slump.

“I’ll handle the clean-up. We can’t have anyone getting their hands on this magic crap, but I will meet you guys at the 7-Eleven tomorrow for our next lesson in heroics,” Pillbug-Man said.

That night, Momentum sat on his bed playing with one of Wishing Prism's triangular prisms. He flipped it across his hands knowing what it was capable of. He had felt the power of a wish being granted earlier today. For a brief period, there was levity. For less than a minute he had truly enjoyed his current life and stopped looking backward.

Time was what he had been told would make these things occur. Perhaps time still would make his wish come true, but he now had an opportunity to skip to the end.

He spoke quietly to the innate prism when he said, "I want to love myself." Momentum didn't know what he expected, but he at least thought there'd be some smoke or maybe some lights when he made his wish. Instead, the prism sat quietly in his hands. Disappointed, he went to bed.

In the quiet of the night, he could hear that his heart was bleeding. Darkened, viscous droplets hit the ground and rang out in moments of silence alerting him to problems still unsolved. Rose-tinted glass surrounded his soul.

Later the next day, Momentum sat outside a 7-Eleven with Pillbug-Man. Both of them wore their costumes. Pillbug-Man quietly sipped on the large, red straw jammed into his Big Gulp as the evening sun beat down on them both. He had filled his Big Gulp with each of the different slushie flavors, so he was drinking a gray mush at this

point. Momentum had stuck to only filling his with Dr. Pepper flavored slushie.

Just a few blocks down the street was where they had fought Wishing Prism. The road was now blocked off so it could be cleaned up for cars to drive on again. No villain activity was predicted for today, but their time together would be a chance for Pillbug-Man to impart another lesson.

“You would not believe how hot this suit gets,” Pillbug-Man said. He continued to slurp down his drink.

“Can’t you take some of it off?”

“Never! Not while I’m on duty.”

Tensile stepped out of the 7-Eleven with lemonade flavored Vitaminwater. They both booed her when they saw she had not gotten a slushie as well.

“I bet you think you’re better than us because of that,” Pillbug-Man said, smiling as he looked at the drink in her hands.

“I don’t need to get a healthy drink to show I’m better. It’s already a commonly accepted fact,” she said with a slight smile. She sat down next to them.

Momentum scoffed before saying, “Have fun drinking sour water.”

“I will,” she said.

They quietly sipped their drinks. Few people walked by this section of the town, but the rare passerby would crane their head as they tried to understand what Pillbug-Man was wearing.

“The real reason I asked you guys to meet me at this 7-Eleven was because we need to work on our one-liners. It’s the pinnacle of heroics. The phrase as you knock someone out. Something like, ‘You’re going back to your cage you overgrown avifauna!’ In this game, similes and metaphors are your friend,” Pillbug-Man said.

“What’s the difference between those? Isn’t it just that a simile uses like or as?” Momentum asked.

“Don’t be a simpleton, my prodigy. A simile uses those words but that’s because it is to say something is *like* something else. It’s frail and timid. It’s afraid of making a statement. A metaphor is to say something *is* something else. You’re calling someone out then. There’s no room for misconception.”

“What about an analogy?” Tensile asked.

“Please don’t bring up random words, Tensile. This is serious business,” Pillbug-Man said. Tensile rolled her eyes.

“It’s coming back to me. I remember learning about that in English class. Similes and metaphors are stupid, especially in stories. People should just say how they feel. Why hide it?” Momentum asked.

“Well, where’s the fun in just telling people how you feel? That’s not very coy. Saying you feel sad doesn’t do anything. Do *you*

feel anything if I say I'm sad? No, because I know for a fact you are not very apathetic, Dom" Pillbug-Man said.

"Do you mean empathetic?" Tensile asked.

"Both apply. Metaphors and similes sell emotions. It allows the heartless fools of the world to understand. Even the most scientific among us know what it feels like to stub a toe. So, if I compared that to the feeling of breaking your heart then you suddenly understand how I feel," Pillbug-Man said.

"Sounds like a lot of semantics to me," Momentum said.

"You say semantics, I say see-my-emotions cause I got em!" Pillbug-Man said. He lifted his slurpy triumphantly into the air. Momentum stood up and struck a pose as if he had just uppercut a supervillain to mimic him.

"Let me try here . . . Time to put you back where you came from like a boomerang!" Momentum shouted.

They stared at him quietly as they wondered how to respond.

"Come on guys. It wasn't that ba—"

Momentum collapsed to the ground. It felt like a rock was pushing its way up and out of his throat. His esophagus burned. This object scraped against his innards.

"Dom! Are you okay?" Tensile asked. She watched as he dry-heaved trying to remove something from within.

His chest flared with pain while his airways clogged. Momentum's eyes watered. A pink object emerged from his mouth and slipped out onto the ground. It was a crystalline ball that rolled to a stop leaving a trail of blood. In the center of this sphere a small fire burned. This flame defied the laws of nature as there was no opening that could provide oxygen.

"It's never good when you throw up an object," Pillbug-Man said.

The spherical rock slowly floated up into the air just a few inches above the ground and began expanding in size. Its smooth edges began to crack, and more rock pierced out randomly. It continued to grow, and the shape molded until it resembled a human figure wearing a long dress. The crystalline creature's face was featureless, and the surroundings reflected off its salmon-colored skin. Seeing that yet another battle was about to start, the few civilians around them fled to the surrounding streets. If any of them had the money to, they would have already moved their homes to New Hope City.

With a roar, the monster waved its arm and shards of glass sprayed out at Momentum. Pillbug-Man rolled to the right and tackled Momentum out of harm's way. Tensile ran at the beast and whipped her scarf at it. It bounced off the creature's skin. It roared and threw another clump of glass forward. Tensile pulled her scarf tight between her two hands. The glass bounced against the taut cloth and rocketed back into the monster. She shook the cloth briefly to rid it of any glass shards before wrapping it around her neck again.

Pillbug-Man smelled the air. The sweet scent of flowers filled his nose. He looked around. There was nothing but buildings and concrete as far as the eye could see.

Momentum stumbled to his feet and fired his anchor into the building to the right. He accelerated upward as he launched his body into the air. With two more swings, he had maneuvered himself so he swung into the creature from behind. His metal boot crashed into the creature's skin and a rupture of pink glass sprayed out against him. He tumbled against the ground.

"What is this thing and why did it come out of Dom?" Tensile asked.

"Why was Dom the first thing it aimed at?" Pillbug-Man asked.

"Those two things must be related," Tensile said.

"This seems supernatural. Dom, did you mess with any of Wishing Prism's stuff?"

"Maybe a little," he said. He slowly picked himself back up.

"What did you wish for?" Pillbug-Man asked.

He considered how to phrase it to not seem too pathetic. "I asked to clear myself of any issues."

"Ugh. Who knows what happens when someone inexperienced uses those weapons," Tensile said.

“Wait, you actually did that though? That’s wonderful! If this is a manifestation of your inner struggles that means I can finally help you by punching it! This is so much easier!” Pillbug-Man said.

After attempting to battle the creature for about ten more minutes all they had accomplished was getting additional, meaning more than the morning’s zero, glass shards ingrained in their body. They hid behind a car to catch their breath as serrated fragments sprayed around them.

“You said this was a manifestation of your issues, right? I thought you said you were seeing a therapist, Dom,” Tensile said.

“I was, but I felt we had made enough progress.”

“Maybe you need to revisit that therapist,” she said, followed by a short chuckle.

“I understand what you’re going through, Dom. I lost my best friend many years ago and I still think about him every single day. It’s like a cloud you can’t get away from constantly keeping any sunshine from healing your skin,” Pillbug-Man said.

“That was a good simile,” Tensile said.

“Thanks. We’re going to get through this together,” Pillbug-Man said. He looked at the cuts and scratches etched across his arm. The glass had torn into him like thorns from a plant. It shouldn’t hurt as much as it did. He had gone through much worse in his youth and managed to pick himself back up. How could a few scratches sting so

greatly? These scratches felt more along the lines of abrasions or perhaps even lacerations.

“I—I can’t keep going. I’m too weak and it’s my fault we’re dealing with this. If I had just dealt with my problems quietly like everyone else then none of this would have happened,” Momentum said. Pillbug-Man looked at Momentum and saw his grandparents. Weak eyes. Hopeless words. A broken heart. His dad may not have been able to save his in-laws, but he never gave up trying. Pillbug-Man would do no different today.

“Dom, look into my eyes when I say this. No one deals with these things quietly. You are not too frail. You are not adrift. You are not beaten. We are not leaving your side until this battle is won. You are not alone.”

Momentum’s body shook thinking about continuing the fight. Blood seeped from his nose like a creak in the spring once the ice began to melt and the water had been finally set free to flow once more, soaking in the fresh air. His body was the beaten shore as the waves grew aggressive while the storm rolled in. Shards of glass etched his body. If each were a small, black circle you could connect the dots to make an animal, but who’s to say what it would be.

“No! I’m not strong enough. Stop trying to help me. If I could be helped, I would have been already,” he said.

“You don’t need to be strong right now. We’re strong enough to get you through this. That’s what friends do,” Tensile said.

“You listen here, Dom. I’m going to tell you what I told an old friend a long time ago and you better listen closely because this may be the best sentence I have ever crafted in my entire existence. False strength comes from thinking you have to do everything alone. True strength comes from knowing you have people that can help you bear the load,” Pillbug-Man said.

Dom sat speechless. He was astounded by his friends’ unyielding belief in him even when he had given them no reason to believe otherwise. How could they speak with such confidence about his own abilities given his performance? The ship was littered with holes, but they insisted on bucketing out water. The sun was setting, but Pillbug-Man would spin the entire world just so Momentum could have one more hour of daylight.

The creature began floating upward.

“Woah. It can’t start floating up. That’s cheating!” Pillbug-Man said.

Momentum peaked out and attempted to fire a harpoon into the crystal creature in hopes of reeling it in, but it avoided the shot effortlessly. He was not willing to go in for another kick as he feared a spray of glass.

“How are we supposed to beat this now?” Momentum asked.

Tensile analyzed their surroundings, assessing how high the buildings were. She could leap out of a window and attempt to bring it down with her, but their adversary was too far away from any jumping

off point to reach by herself. She needed something to gain distance with. A plan burst into her mind, and she began giving commands.

“Dom, I need a taut zipline. If you can get up in the air, then you can fire a shot into the buildings on opposite sides of the streets. I will be waiting on an upper floor and assuming you keep those lines connected, I can slide down them and dismantle the creature,” Tensile said as she pointed to the window she would be waiting at.

“I’ll be a sitting duck then. It’ll shoot me with glass,” Momentum said.

“You aren’t alone in this, Dom. I shall be a decoy,” Pillbug-Man said. Miniscule shards of glass lodged themselves across his body. They were invisible to the eye, yet each movement caused him to wince. Knowing this was his best shot of saving Momentum, he ignored the pestering of his muscles.

Tensile held out her hand, “On three?”

Pillbug-Man put his hand in, “One.”

Momentum put his hand in, “Two.”

“Three,” Tensile said.

Pillbug-Man curled up into a ball and started crashing forward. Shards of glass flew toward him and covered his trail. His body ached as he forced himself to continue rotating forward. He couldn’t stop until this was dealt with.

Tensile broke into a sprint and crashed through the front window of a building to their left. She needed to get up the stairs before Momentum got into position. She ran into the lobby and approached the back door. Tensile whipped her scarf forward so it wrapped around the doorknob and tore it back, ripping the door to the stairway off its hinges. Two stairs at a time, she climbed upward.

Momentum peaked out from behind the car and assessed where to begin his approach. In his periphery, Pillbug-Man continued to draw the creature's fire. He needed to be careful of where his grappling hooks pierced the building as if he were to use a window as an anchor it would simply shatter, resulting in him losing position. He saw the three movements he had to make to gain verticality before he could get into position.

He aimed his left arm out and lined up his sight on the wall. With a boom, the grapple flew out and pierced into the concrete. His arm was ripped taut as the gears in his gun began to tear the metal cord back. Dom burst into the air, gaining the creature's attention. He flew upward toward the building to his left. Wind crashed into his hair. Before colliding with the wall, he fired his right gun. The metal wire rang out as the gears dug into it yanking Dom to the right. The crystal creature changed targets and fired glass shards at Dom. Most of them narrowly missed him unable to keep up with his changing trajectory, but one shard pierced his right arm.

Pillbug-Man uncoiled upon noticing the creature had lost interest in him and watched Momentum scream out in pain. The muscles in his arms continued to be pulled on while the gun retrieved

its cord. Tensile watched from her position in the building to the left as Dom continued to fly toward the right building. Anxious to release the tension on his right arm, Dom aimed his left arm at the building. Tensile stood in and prepared to get into position. A burst of steam erupted from his left hand as the grappling hook shot out and latched itself onto the building. He released the right grappling hook and began flying toward Tensile, ready to get into position.

This time, the crystal creature fired its glass at the wire. It snapped. With nothing connecting the wire to the building, it immediately twisted back onto Dom's belt, and he began falling downward.

"NO!" Pillbug-Man shouted. He looked around for something he could use as a ramp and coiled back into a ball. He raced forward toward a parked car with an angled hood. Pillbug-Man's spherical form rolled up the car, and he rocketed through the air. He soared upward and uncoiled. Tensile watched through the window as Pillbug-Man flew into Dom and pushed him upward.

"Just do it with one wire!" Pillbug-Man shouted before falling back toward the ground. He angled his back downward and slid against the ground, his metal plates grating against the concrete until he slowed to a stop. Dom used this new momentum and spun around midair. He aimed his right arm toward Tensile. The anchor rocketed out from the barrel and lodged itself into the wall. The teeth of the glass shard dug into his flesh as the movement shook his arm. He

began closing distance with the wall, biting his lip to cope with the searing pain.

Tensile leapt through the window creating an eruption of glass. She held her scarf taut and fell onto the wire. The scarf held her weight as she slid down it closer to Momentum on the other end. Her body rocked back and forth as she gained momentum.

“Throw me!” Tensile shouted over the wind rushing past her. She let go of one end of the scarf just before crashing into Momentum. He grabbed that end with his left arm and threw her at the creature. She spiraled toward the creature and collided with it, knocking it to the ground. Right before they smashed against the street, Tensile kicked off the monster and flipped back onto the ground.

Tinted glass erupted from the ground and for a brief moment it appeared as if the sky was pink. The shards clattered against the concrete around them. The small sphere rolled to a stop against the ground. The fire still burned within it.

“Return to nothingness you transparent travesty,” Tensile muttered.

“I think that one was just an insult,” Pillbug-Man said.

The orb began slowly floating upward. Momentum returned to the ground next to them.

“Wait, that looks like what happened when it first formed,” Momentum said. Tensile knocked it out of the air with her scarf and the orb rolled across the ground before floating back up into the air.

“I think this monster must exist somewhere. It used to be within you, Dom. When you wished it gone, you expelled it into the world. It can’t be destroyed,” Pillbug-Man said.

“It can’t just stay out here,” Tensile said.

“It’s okay. I know what I need to do,” Momentum said. He approached the floating orb. He reached up toward it, but Pillbug-Man swatted his arm away.

“Let me take it. I don’t have much longer left here anyway. It can die with me in ten years, maybe fifteen if I’m feeling lucky. You got at least sixty to go.”

Pillbug-Man had watched his father wear himself to the bone to make those that never valued him happy. He could do the same for someone who actually cared about him. Momentum looked into his eyes. Pillbug-Man’s eyelids were patterned with the crevices and peaks of age.

“No. It’s my problem. I am the one that has to carry it,” Momentum said. He knew it was his own responsibility. It was time for him to hold this part of himself. It was time to come to terms.

“But I can help you. I can take it away. You can finally be happy,” Pillbug-Man said. He yearned to make sure just one person would be okay. He was willing to give up anything to not lose someone else.

“I already am,” Momentum said. He took the orb out of the air, stuffed it into his mouth and swallowed. It got stuck at the top of his

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throat, so he pushed it down again, swallowing harder. Summoning all his might, he forced his issues back down. It scraped against his insides resisting being sent back to where it came from. Momentum could feel it scratch and cut his throat on the way down.

His body thrashed upward, and his spine arched backward before he slowly toppled to the ground. He fell looking up at the sky. The blue slowly dimmed to let in black as his body continued to approach the ground.

The plinking of water echoed as a bucket filled. It was placed by his friends to catch each droplet of his heart so it could be poured back in. Whether the heart is half-full or half-empty wasn't the question. Instead, the only unknown is when it would be refilled.

His body radiated wondrous colors. When he looked at his hands, they played back memories as if his skin was a screen. Every decision was shown in vibrant hues. His body projected each moment into the dark abyss. Recollection of who he once was cascaded against the perception of what he was going to become.

Each body part began to embrace its own memory. His legs glowed green as memories of picnics and parks irradiated from him. Pillbug-Man and him were sitting in the grassy plains on a checkered picnic blanket. It was a cool fall day, and they were laughing as Tensile cocooned herself in her never-ending scarf in an attempt to stay warm.

The dark blues of innumerable night skies illuminated his arms. Pillbug-Man held a lightning bug in his hand and was attempting to explain the similarities of them to pill bugs. Momentum and Tensile

listened to him while they stared at the stars, stagnant in the sky. It was comforting to know the stars would still be there tomorrow.

His torso flashed through violet tinted images of anyone who had ever shared one piece of themselves in hopes of building up someone else.

“I should’ve been better,” Dom said to Mallory. They were walking back to their dorm after a long day of classes. The sun was setting in the distance, making the buildings appear black against the orange sky.

“I can’t relate,” she said. Instead of carrying an overstuffed backpack like Dom, she wore a satchel that only functioned to hold her laptop.

“I just spent so long never feeling like enough. It’s easy to make a habit out of it,” he said. He watched her to see if she would show some semblance of emotion.

“You’re enough for me,” she said, continuing to avoid eye contact, or at least remaining uninterested in creating it.

“. . . But I’m just you’re friend. It’s different,” he said.

Mallory looked over to him. Her brows were furrowed, and she grit her teeth as she spoke, “Are you saying my judgement isn’t *good enough*?”

“No—I . . . I just meant that . . .”

She looked at his forehead and noticed sweat beading on his skin. Was it because his backpack was too heavy, because it was a warm evening, or was he just not used to having to walk around?

“My judgement is flawless, so *do not* question it,” she said.

“Thank you . . . I think,” he said. They continued to walk down the street.

Bright red flared across his head pouring over the memories of those he’d loved. It all formed a rainbow of moments all leading to this singular instance.

“I want to love myself.”

Momentum fell into Pillbug-Man’s arms. On his bedside stand, the triangular prism opened. Green smoke slipped out of the open casing and dissipated into the stale air.

“So, are we meeting again tomorrow?” Tensile asked.

“Obviously! We never finished coming up with your one-liners,” Pillbug-Man said as they walked off together.

Bullfighter

BR + DF

Wood creaked as the stacks of boxes rocked from the gust of wind created by Cicada Man bursting through the air. Dragonfly mimicked each turn he took. She slowly closed the distance between them. Bat-Rider galloped on the ground right below. Rider's Bat snapped upward, presumably at a fly, with its tongue spinning wildly sloshing drool onto Rider's visor. Bat was just barely small enough to be able to run between the stacks of crates in the warehouse.

"Take it easy, Bat. Remember, we don't eat the criminals!" Rider said. She held onto the harness attached to Bat's back. Bat gleefully howled scampering forward. His thick, prickly hair flopped with each leap. Each strand of hair had to be at least six inches long.

"With the Alpha Squadron gone and it being seventeen years since my last heist I figured you would cut me some slack!" Cicada Man shouted.

"Evil will never catch a break as long as Dragonfly and Bat-Rider are on the scene!" Dragonfly shouted. She reached into her utility belt and pulled out a short rod that extended into a staff.

"Bat-Rider should come first!" Rider said.

"Why is that?" Dragonfly asked.

"It would be alphabetical. It looks more professional," Rider said.

“Makes sense to me,” Cicada Man said.

“You don’t get a vote!” Dragonfly said. She thrust her arm forward and the staff flew through the air piercing Cicada Man’s wings. He tumbled to the ground and Bat-Rider approached him. Dragonfly landed on the ground next to Bat-Rider. Cicada Man slipped off his gloves.

“Bat, don’t let his hands touch you or you’ll be poisoned!” Rider said. Dragonfly’s plastic wings popped back into her suit. She was covered in red armor with bulbous pieces of plastic around her hands and feet. Her stomach was lined with yellow plating, and she wore a red helmet with a green visor.

“I just threw my staff, so I’m stuck in close-range too,” Dragonfly said.

“You really should start keeping more than one of those on you,” Rider said. She reached into her pockets hoping to find something of use. Cicada Man watched them talk to each other.

“Bat has all those satchels strapped onto him. Why don’t you keep one on him?” Dragonfly asked.

“Because staffs aren’t my schtick. It’s okay. We’re still getting the hang of this,” Rider said. Cicada Man turned around and began sprinting away.

“He’s getting away! Get on!” Rider said. She hopped onto Bat then reached her hand down and lifted Dragonfly onto Bat’s back.

“Grab on!” Rider shouted. Dragonfly clasped her hands around Rider’s gray chest plate and Bat began galloping forward.

“Fetch, Boy!” Rider shouted. Bat howled and ran toward the staff Dragonfly had thrown at Cicada Man during their chase. He snapped it up like a twig. Cicada Man continued sprinting forward. He detached his wings to minimize his own weight.

Rider grabbed onto the staff and tried to pry it out of Bat’s mouth as her legs held tight to the harness. Dragonfly grasped Rider tight to keep herself from falling off the hairy beast. Rider’s leather vest flapped in the wind, thwapping against Dragonfly’s helmet.

“LET GO OF THE STICK, BOY! LET GO!” Rider shouted. She ripped the staff out of his mouth and passed it back to Dragonfly. Dragonfly shook the drool off in the wind.

“You think you can catch him?” Rider shouted.

“If you can give me a boost!” Dragonfly said.

Rider nodded and pat Bat on the side of his chest. Bat let loose another howl before leaping upward. Dragonfly pressed a button on her chest and her green wings extended out from her back. Bat grabbed hold of Dragonfly with his claws.

“Don’t throw her too hard!” Rider said.

Bat grumbled before flinging his arm forward. Dragonfly soared through the air. As she closed the distance between her and Cicada Man, she extended her arm forward. At the moment she flew

over him, she slammed her staff against the back of his head. Cicada Man tumbled to the ground and Dragonfly landed in front of him. Cicada Man stood back up and thrust his hand toward Dragonfly. She slapped his hands away with her staff.

“It’s time for you to crawl back to whatever hole in the ground you emerged from!” Dragonfly said. She spun her staff in the air then held it out toward him.

Cicada Man cackled to himself. He darted forward and in an instant Dragonfly swiped at his feet. Cicada Man fell to the ground and Dragonfly slammed her staff down on his emerald-green helmet knocking him unconscious. Bat-Rider skid to a stop next to them and Rider hopped down.

“Nice work, Dragonfly!” Rider said.

“Couldn’t have done it without you, Rider,” Dragonfly said. Bat grumbled.

“You too, Boy,” Dragonfly said. She rubbed the top of his coarse head.

“Police should be on the way. Let’s head home,” Rider said. Dragonfly agreed and they walked toward the entrance of the warehouse. It was strangely quiet in the warehouse. Only faint noises of the crowds could be heard through the walls. The boxes towered over them, and through the glass ceiling the moon could be seen sparkling.

“Before we go out there, remember that we did good work today,” Rider said. She lifted the visor up on her motorcycle helmet for a moment.

“I know,” Dragonfly said.

“Look at me. Just follow my lead and I’ll get us out of here,” Rider said before closing the visor. Dragonfly stared where her eyes just were. What color were they? She had always felt they were green but tonight they seemed a little blue. Did she see some brown too? Whatever they were, they were beautiful.

She grabbed hold of Dragonfly’s arm with one hand and the handle to the entrance with her other. Dragonfly’s stomach had been churning at the thought of stepping outside, but a feeling of warmth spread out across her body from where Rider’s hand gripped her hand tight. The door slid open to reveal police officers standing at barricades keeping back hundreds of angry citizens shouting at the top of their lungs.

Dragonfly used the hand Rider wasn’t holding onto to block out the flashing blue and red lights from the police cars. Rider led Dragonfly past the police. Bat followed behind them. “Thanks for the help in there, officers,” Rider said.

“We figured you had it covered,” one of the officers responded. He had been holding back a smile with pursed lips, but for a brief second Rider saw his crooked teeth shine before he closed his lips again. The officer pulled up his pants and wiped at his mustache.

Rider pushed forward through the crowd. Bat snarled at the officer as he walked past. The officer jumped back and let loose a slight yelp before adjusting his sunglasses. Once they made their way past the officers, they were surrounded by two opposing waves of people each shouting at the top of their lungs.

“BLOCKBUSTERS!”

“YOU SHOULD BE IN JAIL!”

“IF I DIDN’T TRUST THE NORMAL SUPERHEROES,
WHY WOULD I TRUST THE GAY ONES?”

“STAY OUT OF OUR CITY!”

“Don’t listen to what they’re saying—” Rider began to say. A brick smashed against her helmet through the plastic and into her face, stopping her mid-sentence. She collapsed to the ground and reached at her nose.

“RIDER!” Dragonfly shouted.

Dragonfly adjusted herself so she stood in between Rider and where the brick came from as she kneeled to look at her face. Blood slipped from Rider’s nose and dripped onto her jeans. Rider wiped it away with her leather gloves. A gash stained with sediment had formed on the side of her face. Dragonfly stared in horror at the damage from the brick. Bat howled and the ocean of citizens leapt backward in fear.

“BAT, GET US OUT OF HERE!” Dragonfly shouted. Bat leaned his head down and they both got on his back. He leapt into the

air and landed on a distant building before scampering off into the night.

Rider laid out on a couch in her apartment. Dragonfly walked into the living room with a bowl of warm water and a clean rag. Bat was asleep in an extra-large dog bed across the room.

“How do you feel, Dani?” she asked as she sat down next to Rider.

“Luckily my teeth are intact, Brit. Can’t have one of my best features go awry,” Dani said. She chuckled then rubbed her hand across the gash on her cheek. Brittany smiled for a second. Dani reached for the rag in Brittany’s hand and dipped it into the water before rubbing it across her face.

“Let me handle that,” Brittany said.

“Don’t you worry. I got it under control,” Dani said.

“They don’t deserve our help,” Brittany said.

“I just don’t get why they think we’re gay. Guess I’m doing a good job keeping my secret identity if they don’t know I have a boyfriend I met up for lunch with earlier in the day,” Dani said. She winced as the water soaked into the gash.

“Yeah, we must do a good job with that,” Brittany said. She let loose a slight laugh watching Dani slowly rub the cloth against her face. “You need someone else to do it to make sure it gets clean,”

Brittany said. She took the towel from Dani's hand and stared into the crimson flesh on her face.

"How's it looking? I do a good job?" Dani asked.

"Pretty good. I'll just clean it up," Brittany said. She delicately wiped at the gash, lifting the cloth up when Dani winced.

"You don't have to be afraid. Just get it over with," Dani said with a pained smile. Brittany continued to quietly wipe at the gash removing each particle of stone.

"You know that isn't everyone, right?" Dani said.

"I know."

"I understand it looks bad out there, but there are millions of people at home right now that appreciate what we do. I get why those people are mad out there. I would be too after what just happened in Hope City," Dani said,

"Where are the other heroes? It'd be better if it wasn't just us out here," Brittany said.

"They'll come back. Heroes always do," Dani said.

"And until then we just have to fill in all the gaps?"

"Wouldn't be heroes if we did otherwise," Dani said. Brittany forced a smile. She continued to dab at the consequences of the public's hatred. They heard the front door open, followed by the sound of a bag dropping against the ground.

“Oh my God! Dani, what happened?” Owen asked. He ran over to her.

“Move it, Brit,” he said. He shoved Brittany out of the way so he could get a look at Dani’s cheek.

“I was working on it!” Brittany said.

“Sorry, but . . . Honey, are you okay?” Owen asked. He grabbed the cloth out of Brittany’s hand.

“I’m all good. We had it under control,” Dani said.

“WHAT! Your cheek, while still beautiful, looks horrible right now!” Owen shouted. He gave the rag back to Brittany then stepped backward.

“I’m gonna be sick. I can’t handle this blood and stuff. Give me a second.”

Owen walked over to the sink in the kitchen. His shaggy, blond hair hung over his face as he hunched over. He could see his reflection in the metal. Brittany listened to him gag although she didn’t hear anything hit the sink. She looked over to Dani who shrugged. Owen leaned back up and took a deep breath.

“No need to worry anymore. I am all good. Dani, we did not graduate college just so you could get killed out there! I mean, I don’t really mind if you get killed out there, Brittany. Not that I want you to, it’s just, you know . . . No offense, of course,” Owen said.

“None taken, of course,” Brittany said.

“Although, Dani, I need you to stay alive! You are the only thing good in this world. You are my everything! I wouldn’t be able to suffer through my job at the law office if you weren’t here too!”

“I’m all good, Owen,” Dani said.

“But what if you weren’t! You call yourself Bat-Rider, but you might as well be a bull fighter! It would probably be safer than riding that bat out there,” he said. Bat let loose a grumble without opening his eyes. Owen looked over to Brittany who was still wearing her red suit.

“You are literally wearing the same red as the cape bull fighters use! Except, I wish you were just fighting bulls. You both are going out there and wrestling with masochists nearly every week,” Owen said.

“The bulls don’t charge because it’s red. They would charge at any color. They just use red because the bull’s blood blends in with it,” Brittany said.

“That doesn’t make me feel any better! I want no blood coming out of either of you! I know you don’t do this for the thrill but no matter what your reason is, someday there is going to be a bull that is too big,” Owen said. He finished his spiel and plopped down onto the carpet.

“I just . . . I care so much about you both, Dani much more, but a lot about both of you.” Brittany extended the bloody cloth out to him.

“Do you want to help us finish cleaning this wound?” she asked. Owen gagged, swallowed deeply, then extended his arm out.

“I always want to help,” he said.

In the chaos of the world after S-Day, Dragonfly and Bat-Rider fought off villain after villain that desired to take advantage of this absence in heroes. For a long time, they stuck to the lowest tier of villains which included the likes of Pillbug-Man, Cicada Man, Mole Meister, and Bowling Boy.

As society grew more and more aware of the guaranteed absence of heroes, stronger villains began to take action. Eventually, Dragonfly and Bat-Rider found themselves in Skum City investigating a bomb threat from Titanium Fist.

They stepped through the entrance of the Transaction Tavern and noticed the countless shopping carts lining the walls. Each were filled to the brim with an assortment of groceries: bread, meat, berries, soda, and milk. Bat sniffed at the berries in the produce section before sticking out his tongue and snapping up the entire display of raspberries.

“You think this is actually Titanium Fist?” Dragonfly asked.

“It might have been a prank call or perhaps a copycat,” Rider said.

“I hope you’re right. You know this guy was capable of fighting the entire Alpha Squadron at once?” Dragonfly asked. She panned her head across the store. It was silent inside the Transaction Tavern. At this exact moment, Dragonfly realized she had never been in a grocery store when it was silent. If she listened closely, she could hear the hum of the produce coolers.

“My reputations precedes me,” a robotic voice boomed through the speakers in the store. Bat instantly ran to Rider’s side and Dragonfly pulled out a staff from her belt.

“Still think it’s a prank call?” Titanium Fist asked from the speakers. Dragonfly was too scared to speak. She remembered growing up and seeing the videos of the Alpha Squadron fighting Titanium Fist. His mech suit couldn’t be dented. She remembered how his fists would fly off knocking even Hellraiser back.

“It’s possible. I still don’t see you,” Rider said.

“How about you check the store? Should probably make sure there’s no bomb,” Titanium Fist said. His microphone clicked off and “As Long As It Matters” by Gin Blossoms started playing through the store speakers.

“Why is he playing music?” Dragonfly asked.

“He’s just trying to get in our head. Don’t worry. We’ll search the store,” Rider said. Dragonfly’s breaths grew rapid, and she nervously adjusted her helmet.

“Why—Why aren’t the police coming in? Where’s the bomb squad? Shouldn’t the army be here?” Dragonfly asked. Rider put her hand on Dragonfly’s shoulder causing Dragonfly’s shuddering to briefly cease.

“You know why they aren’t here,” Rider said. She lifted her visor and Dragonfly looked into her eyes. Her breathing slowed.

“Then let’s just leave. If no one else cares than why should we?”

“If this bomb exploded it would kill hundreds of thousands. This could be another S-Day if we don’t stop it. We can’t lose two of our major cities. We’re going to do this,” Rider said. She closed her visor then turned to walk deeper into the store. Dragonfly grabbed her hand.

“I don’t want to lose you. This isn’t Cicada Man or something. This is big league stuff. I don’t want to die today,” Dragonfly said.

“No one’s dying. We’ll stick together and search aisle-by-aisle,” Rider said. She held up her pinky and pointer finger as a rockstar would do shaking it in the air.

There were twelve aisles in the store. They walked up to the endcap before the first aisle. Rider counted down from three with her fingers then all of them leapt into the center of the aisle. It was empty except for stacks of bread that had been knocked to the ground when the civilians fled from the building.

“Going to have to move faster. No telling if I put a timer on the bomb,” Titanium Fist said over the speakers.

The three of them gathered at the endcap before the second aisle and Rider leaned her head to the right so she could see into the aisle. It was empty except for mounds of uncooked pasta and tortillas. Any of these aisles could be holding a trap from Titanium Fist.

“We need to start leap frogging. Keep being cautious, but alternate aisles,” Rider said. Dragonfly was drenched with sweat beneath her suit. In most fights, her helmet felt like a shield from the outside world. It was something to protect her from the citizens, but today it felt like a cage, and she was waiting to be slaughtered. Nevertheless, she nodded her head and ran to the endcap before aisle three. If Rider was going to put her life on the line, so would she.

Dragonfly leapt into the center of aisle three. It was empty. The shelves were stacked to the limit with neatly organized piles of canned vegetables.

“Clear,” Dragonfly said.

Rider nodded and ran to the endcap before aisle four. Dragonfly just knew this was going to be the one Titanium Fist was in. She didn’t know if she was more scared of herself finding him or Rider stumbling into him. Rider peaked her head into the aisle. It was empty.

Dragonfly sighed and moved to the endcap before aisle five. She said a quick prayer then tilted her head to see into the aisle. It was

full of crackers and chips, but nothing appeared to be a bomb.

Dragonfly nodded and Rider snuck over to the endcap before aisle six.

Rider looked into the aisle then nodded her head. As Dragonfly moved to the endcap before aisle seven, she considered the fact that this was perhaps a prank call. Maybe it was all an elaborate scheme by some sick, twisted civilian.

Dragonfly investigated aisle seven. It was lined with energy drinks and a shopping cart sat on its side in the center of the aisle. A purse sat in the section where a child would go, and coins had spilled out from the open zipper across the floor.

“Clear,” Dragonfly said.

Rider ran to the endcap before aisle eight. In all those years Dragonfly had watched her heroes fight on the screen, all she had ever wanted was to be like them. She had never thought of the fear that they must have faced. Perhaps that went away when you joined the strongest team in the world. Maybe you didn’t feel that fear when it wasn’t just you, your best friend, and a bat.

“Clear,” Rider said.

Dragonfly ran to the endcap before aisle nine. She knew if he were here, they would find him soon, although she questioned if he would wait till the last row. She held her staff tightly with both hands and looked into the aisle. Nothing but dog food.

“Clear,” Dragonfly said.

Rider snuck to the endcap before aisle ten. Dragonfly tried to remember the fights she had watched. She was hoping to think of how the Alpha Squadron had defeated Titanium Fist. There had to be another way beside punching him.

“Clear. Maybe we’re all good. Let me take these last two rows,” Rider said.

Before Dragonfly could say anything, Rider ran to the endcap before aisle eleven. She looked over into the aisle.

“Clear.”

Dragonfly’s heart skipped a beat as Rider immediately ran to the endcap before aisle twelve. Rider peered into the last aisle.

“Clear.”

Dragonfly let loose the breath she had been holding for the past three minutes. “As Long As It Matters” stopped playing on the speakers.

An automated message played over the speakers, startling them both. Dragonfly held her staff outward, and Rider hopped onto Bat.

“Thank you for shopping at Transaction Tavern! Please consider signing up for our new member’s program and get a Tavern Membership Card.”

The store fell silent. All that could be heard was the shuffling of their boots, the raspy breaths from Bat, and the hum of freezers.

“Next, we search the—” Rider was cut short as the ground erupted from beneath them. An enormous mechanical titan flew up from the floor crashing into Bat-Rider, knocking Rider off Bat. Dragonfly was pushed to the side and stared up at Titanium Fist who was even larger than she could have ever imagined. The silver head to his suit grazed the ceiling, knocking sediment down to the ground. He effortlessly held Bat taut in his arms, unphased by the creature’s thrashing.

Titanium Fist clenched his hands closed on Bat’s wings. Bat howled in agony as his wings were crumpled. Titanium Fist pulled his hand back then flung Bat through the roof, shaking the building from Bat’s weight when he flew through it.

“BAT!” Rider shouted.

“You ever thought about your legacy? Mine was going to be destroying the Alpha Squadron, but then they went and destroyed themselves. Do you have any idea what it’s like to spend your entire life waiting to do something only to have it taken away from you?” Titanium Fist asked. Dragonfly averted her eyes.

“I used to be in the big leagues. Now look at what they send to stop me. I’m stuck fighting the scraps. I’m quite frankly surprised that the Hero Hunters haven’t taken you two out yet. There never was a bomb. I just wanted to lure some heroes. To feel something. To be someone, but no one will remember me for killing you,” Titanium Fist said.

Dragonfly looked at Rider and noticed a difference in her posture. Her fists were raised but not clasped tight. Her legs were firmly on the ground, but not bent and ready to act. Dragonfly reached into her utility belt and pulled out a spare staff. She tossed it over to Rider who quickly extended it outward.

“You—You get one chance to surrender before we bring you in!” Dragonfly said. A shiver rolled across her spine. She thought about using the wings on her back, but she couldn’t leave Rider.

“Neither of you have powers. This one doesn’t even have her trusty steed anymore,” Titanium Fist said. The metallic head slowly rotated toward Rider. His glowing red eyes scanned the ground. The red aura rose up to Rider’s helmet reflecting off it.

“I don’t need Bat to beat you,” Rider said.

Rider ran forward and spun her leg through the air. Her boot collided with the metal suit of armor and bounced off it with a dull ring. Rider stumbled backward.

One of Titanium Fist’s gauntlets disconnected from the suit and blasted into the air. Before Rider could regain her footing, the fist collided with her and smashed her against the wall shattering her helmet. The fist flew back onto the arm of the suit and Rider collapsed to the ground. Blood seeped out from her forehead. Strands of her black hair became stuck in the viscous fluid.

“RIDER!” Dragonfly shouted.

Rider did not move.

Dragonfly spun her staff in the air then ran toward Titanium Fist. A gauntlet flew at her from the side, and she jammed her staff into the ground. It bent backward before launching her upward and she flew over the fist. She rocketed through the air and extended her staff outward. Just before she collided with Titanium Fist, a second gauntlet exploded out from the suit.

It instantly crashed against her, knocking her through the aisles. Dragonfly flew past dog food, energy drinks, crackers, canned vegetables, and finally through bread. The loafs padded her landing as she tumbled into the produce section.

Through Dragonfly's blurred vision, she could see that her yellow chest plate had been cracked and when she tried to open her wings, she found one of them snapped. She pushed her hands against the ground to try and get back up. She could feel the floor vibrate with each step Titanium Fist took. Her bones rattled with each move he made. When he finally made it to the produce area, Dragonfly was already standing up.

Her legs appeared to be okay, but she could feel that something was wrong around the side of her stomach. She didn't dare look to see what it was.

"You were wrong when you said we didn't have powers," Dragonfly said.

"Is your power believing in lost causes?" Titanium Fist asked.

Dragonfly slid up her visor and spit out blood. She slid it back down.

“My power is that I’m still here.”

She could hear a cackle from Titanium Fist’s speakers. Another fist flew forward and Dragonfly held her staff in a defensive position. The fist collided with Dragonfly’s staff, and she pushed back against the gargantuan hand. Underneath the dull hum of the hand’s magnets, Dragonfly could hear her staff groan. She held her core tight and continued to push against the hand as her feet slid against the ground. Perhaps she stood a chance.

A second fist flew forward and collided with the first fist combining their strength. The force of this knocked Dragonfly into the wall. Her staff fell out of her hands, and it rolled to a stop in front of her.

Dragonfly slowly pulled herself forward toward her staff while Titanium Fist approached her. Each step he took rocked the building. Dragonfly could not fall yet. Any member of the Alpha Squadron could have at least taken seven hits from his fists, and she had only taken two.

She grabbed her staff and held it upward. Dragonfly pushed it against the ground and used it to help her stand back up. The staff bent as she exerted her body’s weight against it. Cracks from Titanium Fist’s attack spread through the staff, and it snapped beneath her. Dragonfly fell back to the ground with a cry.

Titanium Fist picked her up. Her body hung limp in the air. He threw her through the wall. Dragonfly erupted out of the other side in an explosion of plaster. She rolled across the ground past the police barricade and into the crowd outside.

They cleared out around her so there was a line leading from the building and a circle of concrete around where her body was laid sprawled out. Dragonfly looked up to see a helicopter circling above. She knew there were children at home glued to the TV, but she wasn't sure who they were cheering for.

“BOO!”

“Please . . . get out of here . . .” Dragonfly said. Blood seeped out from her lips.

“KILL HER!”

“It isn't safe here. You . . . need to leave,” she said. Her head spun with pain from the collisions and her helmet did little to lessen the agony. It did nothing to deafen their shouts.

“FINISH HER OFF!”

The crowd's cheers grew quiet when Titanium Fist stepped out from the grocery store. They silently watched him stomp toward her body. Dragonfly attempted to pick herself up, but her elbows buckled under her own weight.

Something lifted her up from under her arm and she looked to see a woman from the crowd pulling her up.

“Thank . . . you . . .” Dragonfly muttered.

“She’s right here. Finish her off!” the woman said. She held Dragonfly up as sacrifice.

Dragonfly closed her mouth. Through her cracked visor, she watched Titanium Fist’s head rotate toward the woman. Steel groaned against itself as his suit slowly moved. The red light scanned the woman. He extended his arm out so his hand rested right in front of them both. His smallest finger was larger than their legs.

“Kill this blockbuster,” the woman said. She bit her lip with excitement. Dragonfly could taste iron but smelled and saw titanium. Her senses were overwhelmed with metal.

Titanium Fist flicked his finger and the mass of metal tore through the woman’s lower body. Her legs exploded backward in a burst of red and her intestines hung out from under her stomach. After a brief moment of shock, the crowd burst into a frenzy attempting to escape.

Dragonfly shrieked and fell back to the ground without the woman propping her up. The woman’s hand still held tightly to Dragonfly’s arm and Dragonfly watched as she slowly uttered her last words.

“Kill . . . her . . . kill the hero . . .” the woman whispered before her head tilted to the side.

“Do you see this, Dragonfly? All of America watches as you make your noble last stand. I can see the police officers hiding behind

the cars, not a soldier in sight, no military helicopters, nor the boom of a hero flying toward me. The very citizens you swear to protect offer you up for sacrifice. Not a single person cares what happens to you,” Titanium Fist said. His voice echoed over the panicked screams of the crowd.

Dragonfly wiped at the blood on her visor but only managed to smudge it into the cracks. She threw off her helmet, and it tumbled into the crowd. A crazed civilian tripped over it into another person, knocking them both to the ground. Dragonfly was surrounded by a hoard of people running in all directions but standing above she could Titanium Fist towering over her.

She curled into a ball to keep the crowd from trampling her. Boots smashed against her chest and shouts echoed out from around her. It would only be a matter of seconds until the crowd cleared enough for Titanium Fist to find her.

Two hands grabbed her armpits and pulled her into the crowd. She attempted to pry them off her, but she was unable to shake free from their grasp. The strong scent of cologne filled her nose.

“Please don’t fight me, Miss. We gotta get you out of here,” a deep voice said.

She turned around to see a man in a bright orange polo pulling her back. The Transaction Tavern logo was printed on the shirt, and she read the name “Richard” on a nametag tacked to his shirt.

“I . . . Don’t help me,” Dragonfly said.

“Fine by me if you want to give up and die, but don’t do it in front of my store. How about this? I’ll do you one better. My friend and I just got over here, and we’ll buy you some time if you promise to save our store. Well, it isn’t our store, but it will be someday.”

Dragonfly watched Titanium Fist’s head as she was dragged through the crowd. The red light crawled across the ground. He panned for her but was unable to spot her red suit now that people were covered in guts. She watched a brick fly out from the crowd. A quiet dink rang when it hit Titanium Fist’s faceplate before it fell to the crowd.

A man elsewhere in the crowd pushed up his glasses then shouted, “It doesn’t reflect well that you are still doing this whole superhero-villain thing at such an old age. It’s unbecoming!”

He wore a Transaction Tavern polo with a nametag that read “Scott”. Before Titanium Fist could spot this man in the crowd, Scott dived back into the crazed horde.

“Was hoping his distraction would last longer. Ready to make your final stand?” Richard asked. He stopped tugging Dragonfly and pat her on the shoulder.

“I . . . I can’t beat him,” Dragonfly said.

“Never know if you don’t try!”

“I already did,” she said.

“Well, try again. You have my thoughts and prayers this time,” Richard said. Before he could escape, the crowd had dispersed. Richard and Dragonfly stood in front of Titanium Fist.

“Are you another hero?” Titanium Fist asked.

“When church lets out on Sundays, I think some people would consider me such,” Richard said.

Richard moved to stand in front of Dragonfly. The helicopter circled above. On the TVs at home, the camera zoomed in on the man standing next to Dragonfly. The orange on his polo appeared on their screens in stark contrast to the red surroundings.

“Move or die,” Titanium Fist said.

Richard stood still.

“No one will remember you for being a martyr,” Titanium Fist said.

“That’s not why I’m here,” Richard said.

“Just leave . . . let him take me,” Dragonfly said from the ground.

“Whenever you feel like getting up, I will happily step aside and stop buying you time,” Richard whispered. The magnets on Titanium Fist’s gauntlets hummed as he prepared to throw them forward.

“WAIT! We are here!” a voice shouted out.

The honking of a bicycle horn rang out from behind them. A tandem bicycle with three people simultaneously peddling grew closer. A box with a picture of a slice of pizza painted on it sat on the end of the bike. It swerved to a stop next to Dragonfly and Richard.

“Cat-atonic, hit this out-of-fashion oaf with everything you got!” the man in the front shouted. He wore a large suit that mimicked that of a pill bug.

“Moo-rowr,” the second entity peddling said. A humanoid cat reached into his trench coat and pulled out an enormous gun with coils lining the end of it. The end of it lit up blue, and a ray of energy burst forward into Titanium Fist’s head, knocking him backward. The third person peddling pushed his kickstand down with the back of his sandals, then held his toga up so he could run over to Dragonfly and Richard.

“You should feel no moral guilt for leaving now, civilian. Pillbug-Man and his sidekick, Philosopher, are here,” Philosopher said to Richard. He stroked his enormous beard as he analyzed their situation.

“You aren’t my sidekick,” Pillbug-Man said.

“Who really gets to say who is someone else’s sidekick. Is such a concept even ethical?” Philosopher asked.

“Do you know these people?” Richard asked.

“I can’t fight you today. Please, just get out of here,” Dragonfly said to Pillbug-Man and his compatriots.

“Can you not tell? We are here to save you! Imagine how much people would respect us if we took out one of the Alpha Squadron’s nemeses? The minnow will become the shark,” Pillbug-Man said. He adjusted his gloves as Cat-atic and Philosopher came to his sides.

They struck a pose. Pillbug-Man flexed, Cat-atic tipped his fedora, and Philosopher stuck his fingers up to his cranium to mime the act of thinking.

“Alright, I told you on the bike ride here. This guy shoots out his fists and is nearly impervious to damage. As I learned in the Scouts, be prepared. So, in honor of those campy, camp-happy boys Cat-atic’s gun should be able to break through that armor so we can get to the sweet, gooey filling on the inside.

“Philosopher, keep thinking. I’ll run a distraction while Cat-atic readies another blast. We’ll make these people regret implementing Hero Hunters, but not Nemesis Neutralizers.”

“On it!” Philosopher said. He immediately knelt on one knee and held his fist up to his chin.

“Moo-rowr,” Cat-atic said. He cranked a lever on his gun.

“That won’t work on me,” Titanium Fist said after finally picking himself back up.

“It might,” Pillbug-Man said.

“It won’t.”

“Probably will.”

Dragonfly watched these three take formation in front of her as Pillbug-Man teased his adversary. All she could think about was what these idiots could possibly be planning. They had to know they were going to be killed.

A metallic fist flew forward, and Pillbug-Man curled into a ball. He rolled down the road as the fist continued to follow him. Cat-atonic began charging up another blast when a second fist crashed into his body, knocking his muscular form back into a nearby building. His laser gun fell to the ground.

“Ah, yes. He has two hands which is one of the things that truly defines us a human. It would only make sense,” Philosopher said.

Titanium Fist turned toward Dragonfly. She looked up to the sky and saw that the helicopter was still flying above. She knew that people were still watching. Owen was watching her. Her mom was watching her. Children were watching her.

Once more, Dragonfly rose.

“My entire life I’ve had people tell me what I could or couldn’t do. All I’ve known is that I wanted to be a superhero since I first saw the Alpha Squadron on the news and I’m going to be that person on the news that the next generation of kids look up to. When the next generation of heroes rises to kick your ass, know it was because of what I did today.

“There will always be heroes. You will never win,” Dragonfly said.

“I’ll kill them too,” Titanium Fist said.

In the distance, Pillbug-Man continued to roll away from a fist chasing him. Cat-atomic was slowly throwing chunks of concrete off his body to free himself from the rubble. Richard stood next to Dragonfly with nowhere to run to. Philosopher continued to kneel on the ground thinking. Rider hobbled over from the inside of the store, using the spare staff as a walking stick.

“I call upon the strength of the great philosophers. May I be imbued with the mental potential of Aristotle, Plato, Socrates, Pythagoras, and Mr. Rogers!” Philosopher shouted. His brain pulsed as copious amounts of blood pumped through his veins. He would come up with a plan any moment now.

A brick flew out from the side and cracked against Titanium Fist’s helmet.

“That’s right! I had two of them! Get the hell away from my store!” Scott shouted. As soon as Titanium Fist’s head finished turning to look at Scott, a bullet ricocheted off the back of his helmet. A police officer stood to the side with his gun shaking in his hand.

“H—H—Hands up . . .” he whispered.

Richard snuck over to the gun lying on the ground from Cat-atomic and threw it to Dragonfly. It was still glowing; it just needed someone to pull the trigger. Titanium Fist threw a car toward the police officer and Dragonfly readied up the blaster.

In an instant, she had to consider what to do. She could shoot at Titanium Fist and if the shot landed properly, she could break his suit, or she could shoot the car and save the police officer. The night when they walked out after fighting Cicada Man filled her mind as she determined what to do.

Dragonfly pointed the gun to the car, but as she did Pillbug-Man rolled by with the fist flying after him. He dove toward the car flying at the police officer and slid under it. The fist collided with the car, knocking it to the side, and Dragonfly turned back to Titanium Fist. She pulled the trigger. The brightness from the ray overwhelmed her. When the light dissipated, it was apparent that a crack had formed in Titanium Fist's chest.

Dragonfly finally noticed Rider hobbling out from the Transaction Tavern.

"PASS ME IT!" Dragonfly shouted. Rider collapsed the staff and flung it through the air. Dragonfly caught it as she ran toward Titanium Fist. Dragonfly flicked the rod and the staff extended outward. The metal glistened from the spotlight on the helicopter. She rammed the staff into the ground, bending it briefly, before it straightened back out catapulting her into the air.

Dragonfly soared toward Titanium Fist. She punched the symbol on her chest and one of her wings popped out. He attempted to knock her back with a flying fist, but Dragonfly rolled to the side narrowly avoiding the collision. She held her staff forward and rammed it right into the crack on the suit.

The metal rod slid through the entry point and cracked straight into Titanium Fist's actual head, knocking him unconscious. His suit toppled backward rumbling the ground when it finally fell. Dragonfly landed on the ground. Each hero, and nemesis, stood silent waiting to see if he would get back up.

Dragonfly fell to her knees and grasped at the side of her stomach. She looked at her hands to see her bright red gloves had been coated in dark hues. Rider ran to her side.

"Stay with me here, Dragonfly. You can't go and leave right after taking down one of the biggest villains ever," Rider said. Dragonfly looked down at her suit. She didn't know if the blood was from her or the civilian that was killed.

"You're going to be fine. Just talk to me," Rider said. She cupped Dragonfly's head in her hands in the same way a child would grasp water out of a tidal pool. They would watch as water slowly slipped back into the pond.

Philosopher stood back up from his kneeling position. Pillbug-Man rolled to his side then unfolded. Cat-atonic ran over to the gun laying on the ground and slid it back into his trench coat.

"I think it's starting to hurt," Dragonfly said.

"No—No. You're okay. Those cuts aren't new. You fought the whole time like that. You're going to be okay," Rider said.

Scott ran over to Dragonfly and knelt to get a look at her wounds. He saw that her body had been torn to shreds from the battle. It was a miracle she was still breathing.

“I’m ex-military. Let me take a closer look at this,” Scott said. He stared at the gash on the side of her stomach.

“I can’t tell what’s going on inside of your body, so there could be internal bleeding. All I know is that if your cut was really bad, you would already be dead. You need an ambulance though,” Scott said. He looked over to the police officer who was still staring at the toppled villain.

“PULL YOUR HEAD OUT OF YOUR ASS AND CALL US AN AMBULANCE!” Scott shouted over at him.

“On it,” the officer said.

“I swear to god, she better have a private room. If a single person in that damn hospital learns about her identity, we will never fix another problem for you ever again,” Rider said to the officer

“... Yeah, I need the ambulance on my location A.S.A.P. Consider it done, Rider,” the police officer said.

“Dragonfly, it would help if you focused on something,” Scott said.

Richard walked away to retrieve Dragonfly’s cracked helmet.

“Think about something strong and vivid. You ever been in love?” Scott asked. Dragonfly nodded. “Well, think about the moment you knew you loved them. Remember that day. What were they

wearing? What did they do that made you fall in love? What time of day was it? What did the room smell like? Hold onto that moment,” Scott said. Dragonfly found that moment and soaked in it. She knew what they were wearing, what they had done, the exact hour in the day, and what perfume they had on. Rider squeezed Dragonfly’s hand.

“Keep thinking, Dragonfly. Don’t stop thinking,” Rider said. She buried her head in Dragonfly’s shoulder. Philosopher opened his mouth, but Pillbug-Man shot him a look before he could say anything.

“Not right now,” Pillbug-Man whispered.

Within minutes, an ambulance could be heard. The sound of the siren grew louder until it swung around the corner and pulled up next to them. Two medics ran out with a cot and delicately placed Dragonfly on it. As they walked her into the back of the van, Richard walked up to their side and gave Dragonfly back her helmet.

“In case you need it,” he said.

Pillbug-Man stood at the back of the van.

“Thanks for giving us the opportunity to beat Titanium Fist. We would have never known he was here if we hadn’t seen you on TV,” he said to Dragonfly while she was loaded onto the van. She gave him a brief smile.

The seven of them watched as the back doors were shut, and the ambulance rushed off into the distance.

Many days later, the wind blew through Brittany's hair as she sat atop a skyscraper. Her red helmet was sitting to her left, and to her right was Dani. They stared out at Skum City, soaking in the purple hues that cascaded the buildings and the countless yellow squares that each represented another individual life. Bat slept behind them.

"Okay. He's an eight, but he buys bulk packages of plastic water bottles to drink from," Dani said.

"Six," Brittany said.

"That's it? I would have docked a few more points."

"Alright, I have one. They're a four, but they love the same TV shows you do, and they listen to Radiohead," Brittany said.

"Five. I like the TV show part, but I don't care much about Radiohead. Here's another. He's a ten but hates the Alpha Squadron and all heroes . . . and he thinks your dumb for wanting to be a hero," Dani said. She looked over to Brittany.

Only the whispers of car horns honking made it up to where they sat. The violet lights of the city bounced off the buildings and rolled across Brittany's caramel eyes.

"He'll get it one day. Just give Owen some time. A lot of people need time to warm up to new ideas," Brittany said.

"I guess you're right. It just shouldn't be that hard. I want to be a hero, and he should just love me for that. I've always wanted to be a hero. I shouldn't have to explain it more than that," Dani said before rolling her eyes.

“I get that. Well, you do a good job as one,” Brittany said.

“Wasn’t me that made that grandstand against Titanium Fist. That was super badass of you,” Dani said. She put her arm around Brittany’s shoulder.

“I had already thought I was going to die, but I knew it for sure when Pillbug-Man rolled up,” Brittany said. They both laughed. “I have another. They’re a ten, but you have to keep your true self from them,” Brittany said.

“UGH. A six. I hated when I had to keep my secret identity from Owen. I don’t like how he treats ‘Rider’, but I would rather him know than keep hiding it,” Dani said.

“Yeah, same. That would suck,” Brittany said with a slight laugh made from a whimper of air escaping her chest. It took every ounce of strength she possessed to keep her teeth from nervously chattering now that adrenaline had been pumped through her body. Rider watched as Dragonfly looked away to fix her hair.

“Don’t worry about it, Brittany. I’ll find you a good boyfriend eventually. The winged woman has a great wingman,” Dani said with a smile.

“I—I appreciate that,” Brittany said.

Across the water, she could see the bright lights of New Hope City. Every inch of road was perfectly lit by streetlights. To her right, she could just barely see Moroseville at the top of its hill surrounded by fog. To her left, the land seemed to continue for miles, far into the

horizon line. Small patches of houses and a few roads that would comprise a town dotted the plains.

Below her, she could see the trash can tipped over on the street. A police car rang out in the distance. They continued to sit. The building across the street was missing chunks of brick and several of the windows on the lower levels were boarded up. Through the purple that coated Skum City, Brittany knew there were countless people hiding in wait that needed help.

Dani pulled a phone from her pocket and flipped it open. She fumbled with the keypad before holding it up.

“Let’s get a picture! It’s such a pretty night,” Dani said.

Dani and Brittany leaned together then smiled. Dani clicked a button on the side of her phone and the screen lit up white. She pulled the phone back. Dani looked at the photo, then tilted the phone to Brittany so she could see it. A pixelated picture of them both lit up the phone screen.

It was possible to make out their facial expressions, the color of their suits, and the tones from the city, but it didn’t capture much detail in anything surrounding them.

“Wow! That picture looks great!” Brittany said.

“Yeah, this new phone is awesome. I’ll try to email it to you when I get home to my computer,” Dani said before sliding her phone back into her pocket.

Regardless of if the city would ever accept her, Brittany would always work to protect them. It may only be her and Bat-Rider against the world, but that would be enough.

Crow

There once was a man by the name of Chris Bryon. He was like most other humans in many ways. He could not jump over buildings, run faster than the speed of light, nor did he have super strength. He had a friend just like you and me that he did most things with. He had a pet which was normal, but it was a parrot which was less so. How he got to where he is now is quite complicated. It would be easiest to start with the small things.

What separated Chris from other people was what his eyes saw. Although unlike most, these were never happy things. No, when Chris closed his eyes or let his mind wander, he saw carnage. He was told this is what made him special, why he had to be the one. He learned that this was a gift. He had the ability to see through the cracks in reality created by just one branch from the great tree. These branches allowed him to see.

Here is an example of what he would see . . .

Her body was slumped over in the wreckage. Metal scraps were spread across the road. Fire rose up from a stray tire. A motorcycle rested on its side bent in the middle, its exhaust pipe still crackling. Its light shined low on the road illuminating a red stain that carried on into the darkness of the night. She would never know, but his head had rolled down into the woods barely damaged under the helmet.

“You want any cashback?” the cashier asked. Chris’s perception shifted back to the present reality. He hadn’t heard her, after

all, his eyes saw things when he didn't want them too. The present was more than enough. When the visions got bad it seemed as if he could hear it too. To his relief, the cashier in the Transaction Tavern stood perfectly healthy behind the register. "Sir? Are you okay?" she asked. He rubbed his eyes.

"Yeah, sorry. I mean, no. I don't want any cash back," Chris said. When he spoke to her, he did not look into her eyes, but instead into the shadows of the customer service booth closed at this time of night. He could swear he saw a figure defined in the darkness for just a moment. His friend was always watching.

Chris grabbed his groceries then stepped out into the parking lot. The night sky shined down on him. He paused before leaving the sidewalk to let a car pass by. It drove slowly down the row of stores. He could see the man in the car eye him up and down as he drove by. While the man judged Chris for wearing sweatpants and a hoodie to the grocery store, reality began to shift again in front of Chris.

This man's ending did not involve a car. No, what Chris saw was the man sleeping in his bed. A masked person entered his room. The moon shined off the blade of the knife that the masked person lifted into the air. When the knife struck the man's body the first time, he writhed but before he could scream the masked man plunged the knife into his neck. He would never know, but this masked man was not some random person. It was a coworker he never co-worked with. It was the man who the man from the truck had taken the job of after the company fired him.

Chris rubbed his knuckles against his chest, sliding them over his ribs. The pain in his heart made this vision fade and he was back in the parking lot. After years of seeing such things, they did not startle him much anymore. All he cared to do was get out of the vision if he was together enough to do so.

He walked over to his car and beeped his keys. Chris sat down in the driver's seat. He adjusted the rearview mirror to see a figure sitting in the backseat. Similar to the parrot, most had a friend, but few had one like this.

A large cloak covered this entity and purple smoke slowly wafted out into the car from the bottom of the shadow coating the floor. The cloak was draped over this person's body, but everything beneath the cloth appeared to be a black abyss that went on infinitely. Woden had once been the king of the most powerful beings in the universe. He had golden armor and a palace all to himself. How he ended up on Earth in his current state, no one knew.

"Did I forget to take my medicine or something this morning?" Chris asked himself. His mind was so good at playing tricks on him that sometimes he imagined Woden was there so he could pretend a vision from himself was instead a gift from the God.

"You are . . . not ill. You have . . . a gift," Woden said.

"That sounds like something someone who was mentally unwell would say," Chris said.

Chris reached into the glove compartment. He grabbed two pills that were green and white, one that was a dark blue, and a large

white one. He sucked his cheeks in so spit pooled on his tongue and he used it to swallow the pills without getting a drink of water.

The robed figure did not disappear.

“Great, he’s actually here.” Chris started the car. “Got anything else to say, Woden? I know you always like to.” The shadow did not speak. “Do me a favor. Were those visions you or me?” The shadow remained silent. Chris rolled his eyes.

What complicated their relationship was Chris’ abilities. It was likely true that he could see singular branches from the tree poking into reality and the script that coiled around them. It was also true that some of Chris’ visions came from Woden. The fallen God of war and the dead kept his singular eye close to living beings predicting, no waiting, for their inevitable trip to Valhalla. He knew when the time was to steer an individual back on course with a warning.

What shouldn’t have been there, or maybe what was meant to be there, was Chris’ own intricacies. There was a reason Woden grew so attached to Chris. What Chris had been told was mental illness, was considered a magical gift in Woden’s eyes. Chris had been told that it was his overimaginative brain that operated faster than he could stop it, instinctively imagining the worst things that could possibly happen. See, Woden believed this was the branches of Yggdrasil speaking to Chris. That was why Woden worked with him. Most others who had not been exposed to the tree would have their mind shattered to pieces if Woden were to impart some of it onto them. Which vision came from Woden and which one from within Chris? There was no way to

know, but Chris was at least happy for the possible secondary explanation. Although, that did not fully explain why he had less visions after he began taking the medication.

After Chris parked in front of his apartment building, he went to the mailroom to check his box. A few rod lights hung from the ceiling shining yellow light down on the small room. There were no windows, and the only sound was the hum of the bulbs. In the mailroom, a woman spun the dial to get into her box. Her son stood at her side hanging onto her leg. Chris looked down at her son and gave a small smile before setting down his groceries to unlock his box. The mailroom began to fade.

Chris closed his eyes and hoped that when he opened them, he would see the mom and not the son. He looked. His hand jolted up to his mouth to keep it closed. The room was covered. He had no idea how many years from now this could happen. Maybe this was an adult's remains? Blood filled his mouth and the mailroom reappeared in front of him. Chris was biting his tongue keeping his mouth shut and blood had begun to slip down his throat. He had been facing his mailbox, and he could only hope they hadn't noticed.

He pulled out his phone and pretended to scroll on it, but he opened up the camera app. The camera faced him and he stared at his mouth. It was still closed. He had not said anything . . . or at least wasn't saying anything at that moment. Maybe he had let something slip when he was working on his lock and wasn't focusing. Chris quickly looked over in the woman's direction. She was still getting packages out of the box unaware of him at his locker.

Sweat beaded on his head as he thought about what would have happened to him if he had accidentally told the mom what he saw happen to her son. He'd be deemed a freak, most definitely. The neighbors would kick him out of the apartment building. What kind of person would think of such a thing? He would gain such a reputation that no other apartment building would let him stay. These people could never know what he saw when he looked at them. They wouldn't understand. They wouldn't get how he doesn't want to see these things.

The woman left with her package and her son trailing behind her. "Have a nice night," she said as she pushed open the door to exit the mailroom. Chris nodded back to her. He now stood alone in the mailroom. He opened his lips and let the air escape from his lungs. He could only assume he probably hadn't said anything about his vision to them or why would they have said goodbye so calmly?

Chris took a deep breath, checked his box, found nothing, then returned to his apartment. He lived a modest life, focused on serving others. In the main room a single lamp was on. It left half of the room near the TV and sofa lit but toward the kitchen it was dark. He put his groceries in the fridge. The white light from inside coated blackberries and shined off him. Once the groceries were away, the rest became a blur. He remembered starting to brew some decaf coffee. He remembered turning on the TV. Although that is all that could be remembered from that night before he fell asleep.

These visions that Chris was about to be shown again and had been shown for weeks were different than the usual. They certainly weren't from his own mind as he had never seen these people before, but this set of visions were the first ones in which he had seen the death of someone with powers. The death of such a powerful person left echoes. Most people he only saw die once, but these people's deaths had been ringing out for weeks and it had been agonizing. So much potential gone. He could only hope he had stopped it from coming to fruition.

Blood seeped out from his wrists into the cup. Slowly, each one filled before being poured down his gullet. Abraham's stomach was slowly stuffed with his own poison. At the start, he squirmed in his chair, but as time crawled onward, he began to ease.

Dust covered the purple demon's claws. Keratin scraped against stone as Golem's chest was torn open. Unable to stop it, he watched as pebbles trickled down onto the ground. The others attempted to intervene, but no one could stop Golem's body from being broken into pieces.

Her bangs sat jagged on her forehead. Blood dried the hair into unusual formations. Aristotle stared at a flower and counted how many petals were left on it. There were at least five white whisps attached. The width of her agape mouth grew wider as the skin steadily tore more from the force of gravity pulling down against her jaw.

His head was whipped downward. A blur of colors followed by darkness. Muffled screams grew silent in an instant. The last sense of feeling was pressure against the top and bottom of his head.

Chris jolted upward. His eyes opened and he saw that the television was still on in front of him. Would those people be okay? A cup of coffee sat on a table next to the sofa. Steam rose off it. He could not remember when the coffee was actually brewed, what number cup this was, or how long he had been out for. The morning sun shined in through the window revealing a bird cage on the other side of the room. Inside the cage, a green parrot pecked at its seeds. He looked at the television to see a man talking in front of a field of rotting daisies.

“I am here on the North-East point where an office building has mysteriously disappeared over night. No seismic activity was detected and with no eyewitnesses much is left to speculation. Mysteriously, mounds of rotting daisies are left where the building once stood.”

“Damn it. They didn’t listen,” Chris said as he sat up straight. The crows he had sent to warn them of their impending doom must not have been enough to dissuade them. Ever since those visions first occurred Chris sent out his warnings. Alas, at least the visions should stop now.

His black beard had grown unevenly across his face. He hadn’t shaved since the first premonition for the Nexus Magistrate had arrived weeks ago. He was still in his sweatpants and hoodie. The neck of his hoodie smelled vaguely of body odor. It was just slightly damp to the touch. He must have been sweating again in his sleep.

Chris took a sip from his coffee. It wasn’t as warm as he would have liked it to be, and he must not have put enough sugar in it. Chris

got up and walked over to the kitchen. He reached into the cabinet. As he dug through the shelves, a breeze blew past his ankles. He grabbed a bag of granulated sugar and shut the wooden door. When he turned around, he saw a shadowy figure standing in the entryway to the kitchen. Chris stared into the darkness.

“You’re blocking the only way out of the kitchen, Woden,” Chris said. The cloaked shadow floated to the side without making a noise. Chris walked past him. “I’m sure you saw the news. Another warning gone unnoticed. The crows did nothing to stop their deaths, as per usual,” Chris said as he poured sugar into his coffee. He looked up to the shadow.

The shadow did not move. His parrot hopped up onto its wooden perch. Chris sucked in his lips as he scratched his beard. An argument that frequently occurred was about to begin, but this time the Nexus Magistrate’s deaths were too much. They were enough for this conversation to be pushed farther than it ever had been before.

“You know, I get it. I’m just your mailman. You tell me we work together only because I am one of the few humans that has a connection to the tree, but sometimes I wonder if you just made that up. Maybe you just wanted someone messed up enough, looking for some sort of guidance, that would just take your word on what to do.” Not a single noise slipped out from the shadow.

This doubt in Woden was nothing new. He had never let Chris in on the magical secrets of the world. No one else had ever acknowledged Woden. Perhaps the entire thing was made up. What if Woden actually couldn’t control which visions reached Chris so he

wanted someone that already saw things and was unsure of themselves so Woden could pick which ones to verify?

“As long as you sent out your warning, that’s all that matters, right? All you let me do is send some vague messages. Can’t save too many lives. Gives something for the crows to eat, right?”

“Trust . . . me.”

Chris poured the sugar into his coffee and watched as the granules sunk into the bitter liquid. Were they being dissolved or was his coffee too cold and would they just sink to the bottom? Chris took a sip from the mug.

“You can warn a village . . . of raiders . . . but cannot choose if they listen . . . as long as one family leaves . . . you have saved one family,” a voice whispered from the darkness. Chris grabbed the remote and muted the television.

“What kind of Norse allegory is that?” Woden floated across the floor. He remained on the opposite side of the room from Chris out of the sunlight. “We aren’t giving people a fair shot. If we told them what was going to happen, I think most people would change.”

“What would you . . . tell someone . . . that may die . . . in a crash?”

“I don’t know. Wear a seat belt? Don’t text and drive? It doesn’t matter. I just know I could be doing more if you helped me see what was real and let me intervene,” Chris said. He turned toward the bird cage.

“No. Only I know . . . can know . . . whose life we can . . . shift . . . without hurting Yggdrasil.” Chris looked back and the shadow was gone. Yggdrasil was Woden’s favorite scapegoat. Chris had no idea how the tree worked or if such a thing was even real. Woden knew Chris didn’t know enough to be willing to take action on his own.

“Not much one for talking, is he, Cormy?” Chris asked as he opened the cage. The green parrot flew out of its cage. It soared across Chris’s living room before landing on the couch. Cormy perched himself on the top of the couch cushion, right where Chris’s head would rest when he watched television. Chris sat down on the couch and changed the channel. A change in him had begun, only visible to the likes of Woden.

That night, Chris awoke in a cold sweat that soaked the sheets to his bed.

“This . . . can be . . . changed. I must. I can’t just wait again.” He flicked on his bedside lamp and walked out to his living room. A towel laid over Cormy’s cage. Chris opened his closet and grabbed the purple cloak covered in crow feathers. He grabbed a pair of black boots then closed the wooden door. Woden watched his messenger from the other side of the room, barely perceivable in the darkness of the night.

Soon, Crow sat in his car waiting at the edge of a gas station’s parking lot. This gas station was located miles from anything else and the only person in it was a teenager at the cash register. Woden sat in the back seat. Smoke seeped out of the bottom of the car doors.

“It’s just a kid in there,” Crow said. A car drove past on the highway. They sat in silence. Woden had given Crow the ability to manipulate animals when he wore his cloak. A frequent choice was the crow, but tonight a crow would not be able to deliver the message to the inside of a gas station.

“Yes,” Woden said. What made him decide which potential deaths to act on was a mystery to Crow. It was unclear what made this teenager different from the cashier the other day or the man in the truck. He didn’t bother to ask because he already knew the answer would be “Yggdrasil”.

The moon shined through the windows. It reflected off Crow’s skin but seemed to soak into Woden’s shadow. “You think it’s even possible to actually change someone’s destiny? Maybe the people who die are meant to die. Perhaps my warnings aren’t changing anything. I’m just following the planned course of the world. The people I warn, I was always meant to warn. The people who listen, were always meant to listen.”

A second car drove past them in a blur.

“You . . . don’t have to . . . be this close . . . to send . . . in a warning.” Woden was correct. Crow had the capability to control animals across the area just from his room. Something was different this night.

“You’re all knowing. Tell me what I do tonight.” Crow looked to the back of the car and Woden was gone.

He closed his eyes and began to work on casting a spell. Within the building, a spider crawled out from under the counter. It skittered across the tabletop and climbed up the cash register. As the cashier stood unaware, the spider connected a string from the cash register to the keypad for a credit card. The cashier played on his phone as the spider slowly spun out a message with its webbing.

Termites in the ceiling began to chew at the wooden paneling so minuscule particles of dust sank onto the counter. As the particles got stuck in the webbing, the translucent cords slowly became more visible.

The cashier looked up from his phone to see one word spelled out.

“RUN”

“Oh, that’s funny,” the cashier said. He pulled out his phone. The spider aimlessly crawled across the counter while the teenager took a picture of the webbing. “They’re never going to believe this!” the cashier said. He tapped on his phone.

Meanwhile, Crow opened his eyes back up and looked into the gas station. The boy did not move from behind the counter. The insects had not been enough. This was why he stuck with crows. Another car pulled into the parking lot. As a woman stepped out of her truck Crow snuck out of his car. Her shirt was tucked in behind a pistol.

Woden appeared in front of Crow. His form sucked the light out of the atmosphere only letting the vague red aura of the gas station lights escape around him.

“Halt.”

“He is a kid. A kid with so much life to live. He could be capable of so much,” Crow said. Tonight was different. When Crow thought of this teenager, he did not see a horrible death. Instead, he imagined family dinners and a wonderful marriage. Brief glimmers of a happy future broke through to the present day.

“We did . . . our part.” See, at this moment the teenager’s future was not what Woden was fixated on. There was something else at play.

“I’m done watching. I don’t care about Yggdrasil. Get out of my way. I know every vision I see isn’t true. I know people will think I’m crazy. I know some people won’t listen, but I know I have to do something. I can’t let my mind control me. I am the one that controls it!” Woden did not respond. “Say something! All these years just leaving me in the dark to fight my own head. Just tell me one concrete thing!”

“You . . . aren’t . . . the first. It is not because of . . . Yggdrasil . . . I keep you away.” Woden floated forward. A decrepit arm reached out from the shadow and a rotten thumb pushed against Crow’s forehead showing him another vision.

“I’m begging you, Justice. You need to be careful. I’ve had visions for weeks. Something big happens today,” a man in Crow’s cloak said.

“Crow, you know I appreciate when you come to us with warnings, but there is nothing to worry about with today’s mission!” a man in orange spandex said. His chest was perfectly defined, and his

brown beard was chiseled so not a single hair stood out too far. A long, orange cape blew in the stale air.

Orange Android's eyes lit up blue before dimming. "I calculate zero casualties today," Orange Android said.

Spirit Rider stepped forward and put her left hand on Crow's shoulder. Her spectral scythe was in her right hand.

"Thank you for this intel, Crow. Hellraiser and I will be sure to keep an eye out." Hellraiser grumbled. His arms were crossed, and the road was melting beneath his molten feet. "Do you know what it is that causes all the death?" Spirit Rider asked.

"All I see is an explosion. There's too much death on the backend for me to see what comes before it," Crow said.

"When the other two get back, I will be sure to ask them if they have any idea what might cause this," Justice said.

"You don't get it. We have to get everyone out of here now," Crow said.

"Rest easy, Crow. I will keep everyone safe, like always," Justice said.

Crow stumbled backward and fell to the ground. "I—There was one of me there before?" Woden stood silent. "He never made it out of the city did he . . ."

"Messenger . . . must not . . . be present . . . or burns . . . with village."

Crow leaned to the right so he could see into the gas station. The woman entered the doors. He stood up and threw the cloak over his body.

“Do . . . not . . . go . . . in.”

“I can’t . . . I can’t live like this. Before I go, I need to know. Do you watch for when your messengers die?”

“I . . . did . . . not . . . used . . . to.”

Crow walked forward and through Woden who disappeared in a plume of smoke. The door to the gas station swung open. Crow stood in the doorway. The woman had her gun pointed at the cashier.

“Just give me the mon—Who are you?” she asked. She turned toward him and saw a shadowed figure covered in a cloak of feathers. His face couldn’t be seen under the hood. He clenched his fists before talking.

“My name is Crow. Let him go!” Crow hadn’t thought much past the idea of getting involved. He was far from a fighter. If he played his cards right, then maybe there was no need.

The woman’s hands shook in the air, rattling the metal of her gun. Her attention shifted to him, and she pointed the gun right at him. She had heard of supernatural beings but had never expected to meet one, let alone in opposition.

“Are you—Are you a hero?” she asked, staring into the dark hood of his cloak. While it allowed him to communicate with animals,

this cloak was far from bulletproof. All it would take is one motion from her.

“I’m here to make sure no one dies.”

“I . . . No one was going to get hurt,” she said.

“I saw otherwise,” he muttered from under the hood.

“What are you talking about?” she asked. The cashier ran out of the gas station while the woman was distracted. Crow looked at the woman’s hands. They were turning a shade of purple from clenching the gun so hard. A shadow rose out from the floor on the other side of the store. Woden stared at him from the darkness. “What did you mean when you said someone would die tonight?” He stared down the barrel of her gun. In the blackness of it he could see a piece of Woden.

Why was he just watching? Why didn’t he get involved himself? Was this woman going to shoot him? Would he tell her the truth and she fire her gun? What does Woden know?

“You were going to kill someone,” Crow said. His nerves ran wild, and he hoped that his cloak kept her from seeing the shaking of his arms. They stared at each other for seconds but it might as well have been minutes. Time seemed to move opposite of when he had a vision. No matter how much he waited it seemed like it was still stuck at this moment.

“I wouldn’t. You couldn’t have know that,” she said. She didn’t lower the gun. “Look . . . I need this money . . . I was desperate— and who says that person you saw won’t turn out to be you?” Hundreds of

visions danced at the cusps of Crow's mind, but he pushed them back. He had to stay in the present no matter how much his mind wandered and his heart raced.

"It doesn't have to be this way." Crow held his hands up in the air and began to speak beyond what Woden had shown him. Instead, Crow spoke of what he was just now starting to see. "There are as many possible outcomes as hues in a crow's coat of feathers and I can only see just one quill that fell to the ground." Chris had led a life full of horrifying visions. He took a step forward.

What he thought was a curse, something that Woden pried on to turn him into the perfect messenger, could be more than a burden to carry for everyone. What if there was meaning to it all? Maybe something instead of Woden wanted him to see these things. Crow took another step forward. He was mere inches from the gun. Maybe Crows getting this involved was a death sentence, but the thought that there had been a Crow before the Crow before him rose in his mind. The idea that someone before him had come to the same conclusion brought him some degree of comfort. To enact change, one needs to embrace the uncomfortable. To shift timelines, one needs to take risks. It is a law of the universe.

"Step back. I'm—I'm warning you."

"I'm telling you what I saw as a show of good faith. I don't hold it against you. God knows what can happen in a day. It was just one possibility in one day. A fringe branch like that could occur with anyone. I see them more often than I'd like but you, you, have the

option to prune that branch right now. I trust you to make the right decision.” Crow stepped forward one last time. The barrel of the gun was pushed up against his chest. It shook from her uneasy hands rubbing the metal into his chest and against his ribs.

That ability to see what could happen to a person. There had to be more to it. Suddenly, just as easily as Chris once saw their potential deaths, now he could see the option for a peaceful future. Crow stood there silently. It would be different this time. It had to be.

“I’m not a bad person,” she said. Crow reached forward and grabbed her hands. He stopped her shaking then took the gun from her grasp.

“I know you’re not,” Crow said. He looked to the corner of the store. Woden was gone. Once she no longer held the gun, she collapsed to the ground and began crying.

Many nights past this revelation, a man with a thick, brown goatee and mullet slept quietly in his bed. The moonlight shined through the window coating the right side of the man’s bed in an opal hue. His chest rose up, then fell as he took heavy breaths. The hinges on the door to his room squeaked while Crow entered his room. Crow pulled a chair out from the man’s desk and set it next to the side of the bed that was coated in light. He danced across the room preparing for the spiel. The floorboards creaked under the chair’s legs as Crow sat with his stomach leaning against the back of the chair and his legs

straddling the sides. He had learned over the past weeks that the more ethereal he appeared the more effective his messages were received.

“Do you think this looks intimidating enough?” Crow whispered to the darkest corner of the room. Woden nodded, at least Crow thought he did. Crow moved his hand, so it rested over the man’s shoulder. He held it there for nearly a minute before grabbing hold of the man’s shoulder and shaking him awake.

“WHO—GET OFF ME!” Crow let go of the man as he thrashed in his sheets.

“Calm down. I’m just here to talk!” Crow shouted and the man scrambled out of his bed, so he was standing on the side opposite of Crow. “Do not reach for the baseball bat under there. I already took it away anyway. Don’t go checking under the pillow either. I took your pistol too. Sit back down on the bed.”

“What . . . I . . .” the man mumbled. He crawled back into his bed.

“The name is Crow. Our futures are like the end of a branch on an old tree that we are all connected to. I am the crow that harks to alert of bad branches. It is up to you to prune. Don’t do what you’re going to do next week.”

“I don’t know what you’re talking about.”

“Maybe you do. Maybe you don’t. Doesn’t matter much to me, but I will be keeping an eye on you . . . vicariously.”

Crow lifted up his cloak and a purple crow flew out of it and landed on the windowsill. The hue coating the room shifted from the moon's pale glow to the crow's purple aura. The corporeal energy the crow was made of pulsed in and out cascading against itself never shifting far from the intended imagery.

"That bird there is a friend of a friend, and she is going to stay with you for exactly one week, always watching no matter where you go." The crow opened its mouth to squawk, but instead it croaked.

"What the hell kind of a crow is that?"

"So, she'll remain for one week. Nothing happens, she will return to me. I trust you'll make the right call but just in case for even a second you look like you're going to hurt someone, I come right back and next time I won't even bother to wake you up." The man stared blankly into the abyss of Crow's cloak. "Keep up being a good guy and I foresee some good stuff in your future. Wouldn't want to lose that. We copacetic?" Crow asked.

"I look forward to never seeing you again."

"By the way, I really liked your coffee. Good stuff. I think I'll get myself a bag of it next time I head out to the store."

"What the hell . . ."

"Don't worry, I already cleaned the mug. You'd be surprised how much someone can do in your house before you even wake up!" Crow said. He put the chair back and walked to the doorway. "One

week!” Crow said before exiting. The man turned to the crow, who seemed to be preening its form with the resemblance of a beak.

Crow sat across from Swamp Gut in the Nexus Magistrate’s base. He had a mug of coffee in front of him, now cold.

Swamp Gut was leaning back in their chair when they asked, “Why did you tell the story in third person?”

“I think using the term ‘I’ implies more value to me than others. I am the same as anyone else, just another person,” Crow said.

“And so, we were supposed to just recognize those random crows as warning signs? I barely remember them,” Swamp Gut said.

“Oh, they were definitely there. But see, that’s the point. I want to move beyond that. I already have. I think I could do even more with you all.”

“Hmm. I’ll have to ask Charles about it, but I see no reason why this wouldn’t work. Anything else I should know? Any other pressing visions?” Swamp Gut asked.

“No,” is what Crow said, and this was not entirely a lie. What he did not share was his experience one week ago . . .

Chris awoke to a breeze rolling across his face. He opened his eyes to see Woden’s shadowy form at the side of his bed.

“What . . . what is it? Now I get why the other people hate when I do this,” Chris said.

“You . . . need . . . to . . . see. I’ve only ever shown you a small number of deaths. The reality is that in the coming years a number of world-changing events will occur. We can’t stop them all. There is a most important one you need to see that will be in two years. I now believe there is a chance to shift it.”

“Alright. I’m ready,” Crow said.

Woden extended a wrinkled finger out from under the shade. It reached forward and pressed against Crow’s forehead. The darkness seeped out from Woden and coated the room. Once every ounce of brightness was soaked up all of it coalesced in one bright white line that rose up behind Woden like a firework shooting off into the midnight sky. As this white line burst upward, offshoots of light fragmented off in straight lines. From these offshoots, more fractals of light split off in various directions never bending.

A tree of fluorescent, white light radiated a wonderous aura that seemed to stretch endlessly into the darkness. Purple, spectral crows flew all through the air flapping their hazy wings. Most of the luminous creatures perched themselves on the beams of white light, but a murder of them flew overhead off into the abyss. From the ground, all that could be seen were thousands of vaporous smudges moving inward and outward from this radiant centerpiece.

“What am I looking at?” Crow asked.

“Yggdrasil,” Woden said. A crow landed on his cloak without creasing the fabric. Crow stared at this creature’s body watching it

form and deform simultaneously only ever vaguely resembling a living crow. It squawked before flying away.

Woden lifted a hand out from his cloak and waved it in the air. Thousands of small sections at the end of various tree branches turned purple. Even with all of these pieces now purple, the tree was still almost entirely all white light.

“Those . . . Those are the ones you see. The most jagged . . . and thorny . . . The ones aggressive enough to poke through the veil. The very worst branch . . . for each person.”

Crow looked up at the tree, his eye darting from purple branch to purple branch. “Wow,” he said.

“There is something far worse. A rotting root. Are you . . . ready . . . to see?” Woden asked.

“I am.”

Another bird descended and landed on Crow’s shoulder. It felt as if his shoulder was covered with an ice pack. The creature appeared to turn toward him, and it opened its mouth. Crow stared into the frothing lifeform and waited.

As if he was waking up again, Crow’s vision was blurred when he reopened his eyes. Crow stood in the center of New Hope City, or at least he thought so. It looked just like Hope City did on S-Day. Buildings laid toppled on their side and chunks of concrete were lodged into the road. Intuition led him to believe this must be in the past, but Woden had told him this was the future.

Before he could fully see, the sounds warned him of what he was about to witness. Screams echoed out over snarls. Battle cries could be heard under the sound of energy blasts firing off. The crackle of smoldering remains prevented there from being a moment of silence.

Once his vision cleared, he could see he was surrounded by hundreds of people fighting monsters that could have only existed before in the deepest recesses of our mind. A species of monster was the size of a wolf but had six legs. Instead of a head, at the front it had one large mouth. At its back, a large tail extended outward thrashing wildly. On the end of the tail a large eyeball panned the area for anything to kill. Its skin was tinted dark purple and seemed slimy like that of a frog.

It crawled across the ground shrieking. It leapt at a man but was torn back when a harpoon impaled one of its legs. "Easy there!" Momentum shouted as he pulled backward on the cord. His metal boots slid across the concrete unable to anchor themselves down.

A chain whipped out and wrapped around another one of the monster's legs. Chainlink yanked the monster backward and together the two of them dragged it across the ground. A blast of blue lightning rocketed through the air striking the monster.

Crow looked over to the origin of the blast. The man the monster lunged at held a gun with dozens of metal pieces floating around the barrel. The metal retracted back to the barrel and the hero blew on the end of it before flipping the gun back into their pocket.

“Thanks for holding it steady,” the man said before the three of them ran off to fight something else. It became apparent how much was simultaneously happening around him.

Emerald Earwig flipped over Crow’s head blasting green energy at Hero’s gauntlets. They reflected off and bounced into monsters surrounding them.

“Ready?”

“Of course.”

Orobas held Teen Demon in his hand. Orobas’ biceps were as big as Teen Demon’s head. The runt was flung forward. Teen Demon spiraled through the air with his blade extended cutting through monsters that were crawling down a nearby building.

Swamp Gut grabbed one of the monsters and tore it in half. Their body was covered in a cyan goo that pulsed brightly with each breath they took.

A monster leapt at Mongoose, and she bashed it to the side with her hand. At her back, a man wearing a purple spandex suit crashed his fist into another monster. An explosion formed at the point of contact where his knuckles touched the creature’s moist skin and the monster dissipated in a cloud of dust.

One of the monsters leapt at Cobra Commando. Before its jaws could snap down on him, Transient appeared behind him and the two of them reappeared behind the monster. Transient teleported onto the

monster's back and the two of them blinked off the battlefield. Only Transient returned.

"That power is really handy, Nate," Cobra Commando said. He smacked Transient on the back. Transient wiped beneath his nose.

"Happy to help," Transient said.

Mindmeld stood in a circle talking to Eel Master, Crimson Claw, Totem, a woman with a strainer on her head, and a number of other people.

"We need to plan for the next wave. I would guess this was just meant to draw us all out into the open. Some of us need to remain on the offense while we plan for the next wave with a defense already set," Mindmeld said to them. A shriek of metal rang out from the distance.

"ARTILLERY STRIKE INCOMING! GET BENEATH MY SHIELD, NOW!" a woman shouted. Crow turned his head to see a hero wearing a costume that seemed to be made of the cosmos. It was as if she was a window to the stars. Her cape fluttered in the wind as she reached her arms upward. An enormous, purple tinted panel of energy appeared above them coloring the war violet. The stars trapped in the shield twinkled as explosions rocked against the other side of it.

Woden lifted his finger from Crow's forehead. Crow scrambled upward so he stood facing Woden. "What—What did I just see?"

"The . . . end."

"I have to tell them!"

“Not . . . yet. If we push . . . too hard . . . they will break. Let them form . . . then . . . we can mold.”

“When does it start?”

“These events . . . are already set in motion.”

We are the Ones Still Here

Thank you so much for sitting in for an interview with me, Mr. Pillbug-Man. How do you usually start a day in your life as a superhero? Do you eat breakfast?

It's my pleasure! I think the most important part about being a hero is starting out with a good, hearty breakfast. I usually make myself some eggs with toast!

The trill of Pillbug-Man's iPhone 6 played for exactly thirteen seconds at ten in the morning on a specific Monday. Pillbug-Man rolled over in his bed to grab at his phone. A text from Philosopher sat at the top of his notifications. "You up yet?" Below that, a selection of news articles his phone deemed relevant to him filled his screen.

"Nope. Can't do this today," he said.

Pillbug-Man opened his clock app and set an alarm for eleven then rolled back over.

After that, do you usually do some fighting training?

Of course I do! I need to stay sharp in case half the population were to disappear or something.

At eleven, Pillbug-Man's iPhone 6 began to hum again. He picked up his phone and stared at the notifications.

Today we honor the anniversary of S-Day and the deaths of . . .

Pillbug-Man swiped away the alerts and swung his legs so they hung off the bed. Small dust particles, that he hoped weren't asbestos, hung in the air of his empty room. In the corner of the room, a scratching post as tall as him lay stagnant. A fedora hung off the top of it. He looked in his closet to find seven copies of the same exact superhero suit waiting for him. He took the second one in and slid his wrinkled skin into the gray spandex. Curved metal plates lined the back of the suit, resembling the back of a pill bug, and six limp arms hung out of each side of the suit.

What do you do next?

On most days I then meet my students for their daily lessons.

Left these for you. At work. I told the students to take the day off. Dragonfly and Bat-Rider will keep an eye on the city. I will be back to check in on you at the end of the day. :) Take it easy today. Your sidekick, Philosopher

Pillbug-Man took the note off the container of confetti pancakes then plated them. As the rotund confections spun in the

microwave, he reached for the remote on the counter then turned on the TV to see a newscaster speaking at their table.

“Today we have an interview with a survivor of S-Day. Before we have them on, we will play some footage from S-Day and Justice’s rampage. We warn you that some viewers may find this footage disturbing.”

Pillbug-Man swung his hand toward the remote and grasped it. It slipped out of his hands and slid across the countertop then tumbled to the floor. He collapsed to the ground and reached out for the remote. That’s when he heard the TV. The sound of their bellowing lacerated his brain, and the pounding explosions plunged his heart deep into his stomach.

As the microwave beeped, he finally hit the power button on the remote. He sat on the ground until the harsh tones of the microwave rang once more.

What made you want to be a hero?

I suppose a sense of responsibility.

How did it feel to fight alongside Justice?

Well . . . we didn’t quite fight alongside each other. More an against each other sort of thing.

You were a villain?

Some would use that word. I prefer nemesis. Didn't the books tell you that?

I haven't read anything about you in any books.

You haven't been reading good books then! [Editor's note: Pillbug-Man struck a pose after saying this.]

I only read what my teacher assigns. My dad says you were always a hero. This project has to be about a superhero.

Well then, as far as your teacher needs to be concerned, I was always a hero.

What was it like on S-Day?

[Pillbug-Man rubs his knuckle against his chest before answering.] When S-Day happened, Hope City fell, and Justice just vanished. Not a lot of people were left to be heroes. That's when Philosopher and I hit our super heroic stride, so to say.

Do you think that Justice was responsible for what happened to Hope City?

I . . . I can only speak for who I knew him to be. I thought he was a mighty fine person to have as a nemesis.

Are you okay with him being a bully if he was also your friend?

We weren't friends. We were nemeses. There's a slight difference. But, again, I never saw him as a bully.

You run a school for new superheroes, right?

That is true. We are rocking a 2:1 student to teacher ratio!

What do you want your students to leave your school knowing?

I want them to leave knowing they aren't alone. Heroics isn't a solo act, and no one has to bear any burden by themselves. My hope is they leave this academy with the connections and know-how to act on a team out in the real world.

What do you do for lunch?

I try to catch Philosopher at his job during his off time. I can't tell you where that is for secret identity reasons. [Pillbug-Man winks.]

Philosopher sat at his desk skimming a philosophy textbook as he bit into one of the sandwiches Pillbug-Man brought him. They were smoked turkey, horseradish, lettuce, pepper, and cucumber sandwiches. Pillbug-Man sat across from him in Philosopher's office. The acronym "ELU" was printed in royal blue on a white banner hanging from the wall. A set of wooden shelves seemed to bow in the middle from the countless philosophy books placed on them. Outside the window, students walked to their next class.

"I think I added some people to our guild of nemeses with my midterm," Philosopher said.

"I'm sure you did a good job teaching the topics," Pillbug-Man said.

"You know it was just simple stuff like Social Contract Theory, truth, justice—"

Pillbug-Man choked on his sandwich and smacked his chest before continuing to eat.

“Sorry, don’t mean to mention him,” Philosopher said.

“It’s okay. Not your fault.”

“Regardless, I’m going to curve it anyways. Every year they throw a fit and suddenly the emails stop once the grades finally come out,” Philosopher said. He folded the corner of the page in his book. He closed it then looked toward Pillbug-Man. “How are you doing today? I know this is the anniversary.”

“I cried looking at Cat-atonic’s old scratching post.”

A sliced pepper slipped out of Philosopher’s sandwich. “That’s not who I thought you’d be crying about. You’re lucky I’m not the envious type. That cat was an awesome sidekick and strong to boot.”

“Yeah, I miss him,” Pillbug-Man said.

What do you do for dinner?

Erm. Takeout. I like Wendy’s 4-for-4s.

Chalk glided against the blackboard. Philosopher outlined logic equations for his students. He put the chalk down. He clapped his hands, creating a plume of white smoke, then turned to his students in the classroom.

“So, we know that if A necessitates B and A is given, what can we conclude?”

His evening class remained silent.

“B,” he whispered. “You are correct, class! It means B!”

The long-distance relationship bracelet on his wrist vibrated. He paused, opened his mouth, felt the bracelet vibrate again, then said, “Sorry, everyone. Class is cancelled. Next week we will work on truth tables.”

Who would you say is your best friend now?

Without a doubt, Philosopher.

Philosopher kicked down the door to Pillbug-Man’s room with his open-toed sandals. He ran through the doorway. His toga fluttered in the stale air as he said, “I heard your call on the L.D.R. bracelet and the Philosopher is here to help! Where are the villains?”

The long-distance relationship bracelet sat on Pillbug-Man’s bed next to him. He stared at the TV in his room. A picture of Justice was pasted on the corner of the screen as a person recounted their memories of that day.

“It was just—horrifying. The Alpha Squadron was there, and I remember the exact moment I saw Justice’s orange cape. I thought I

had been saved, but he just watched. He watched all of the carnage and heard all the screaming, and he didn't move—"

The screen flicked off. Philosopher appeared in the reflection of the screen with the remote in his hand. "You don't need to be watching that crap," Philosopher said. Pillbug-Man didn't look at him.

"I . . . I should've known. There must have been something I missed," Pillbug-Man said.

"You couldn't have known. He fooled all of America. It isn't logical to be so hard on yourself for not seeing that in a friend."

"But you don't get it. I idolized him! I wanted to spend every waking moment with him, but he was a monster that entire time! And you know why I can't let it go? Because I still would want to be his nemesis if he were to turn up alive," Pillbug-Man said. He buried his head in his hands. "I don't know how to do all of this. I didn't plan to lead others. All I ever wanted to be was his nemesis. Throughout all these years the only thing that happens to me is I lose people! They just keep leaving me whether they get killed or turn out to be a horrible villain."

Philosopher did his best to extend his arms around the spine of Pillbug-Man's suit.

"It's going to be okay. It's going to be okay because we are the ones still here and that is going to be enough."

Well. I asked all the important questions. Thanks for your time, Uncle—Mr. Pillbug-Man.

“My pleasure to help. I hope the project turns out great. You’ll do a wonderful job.”

Philosopher’s daughter hopped off her chair at the dining room table and ran to her room with a yellow flipbook full of notes in her hands. “She just asked me about food most the time, but she started grilling me in the middle though,” Pillbug-Man said as he stretched out.

“Sorry. The teachers must give them some questions they have to ask, and I can only imagine the kids don’t do a super good job of hiding those ones. Plus, she must overhear me talking to the Missus every so often. Thanks for helping her out with her English project,” Philosopher said while he stacked up the plates on the table to take over to the sink.

“I’m surprised they asked each kid to write a biography about a hero,” Pillbug-Man said.

“It’s supposed to be mournful; I think. Something like if you did a research project on a criminal only to reach the end of the Wikipedia page and learn they got the death penalty.”

“I’d like to think my life is at least a little better than that. Eggs and toast and all of that good stuff.”

“Eggs and toast my ass. I’ve never seen you so much as look at an egg,” Philosopher said. He smiled while he put another dish stained

with ketchup into the sink. Pillbug-Man put his foot on the garbage can peddle to lift the lid and reveal the black abyss into which he threw a Wendy's bag.

"The books written about me will say otherwise!"

They shared a laugh.

"She has your eyes," Pillbug-Man said.

Philosopher swept the crumbs on the table together and cupped his hand at the end then used the edge of his palm to sweep everything into it. He smiled, "She does."

Don't Know

“Why—Why couldn't you have just let me eat my croissant in peace.”

Blood slid down Garrett's arm onto the blaster he held in his hand. It fell from the blaster in droplets splashing against the roof. Garrett pointed the blaster downward, his hands shaking. He did not know if it was from exhaustion or fear. He raised his spare hand and slid it through his blond hair pushing the blood matted strands back so he could see the man lying on the ground clearly. Garrett knew this man, at least he once did.

Harold looked up into Garrett's eyes. His hands burned with energy he desired to let loose, but he continued to lay on the roof. From this distance, a shot like that would likely do him in. His red skin was cracked open revealing an even darker red flesh. The cloth he was wearing had been torn to shreds and his horns scratched against the roof as he leaned backward to look up at Garrett.

A compelling start to a story, is it not? I feel so. I made it happen after all. But see, how did these two men get here on a roof bleeding over a baked good? Well, there is something you should know from earlier.

“Erm—Could I get a croissant please!” Garrett said to the cashier.

No. I mean much earlier. All the way back to the last time they had worked together. Under the not so coded codenames Gadget Garrett and Hammer Harold, the two of them had spent years defending the city. They had never faced anything too big, mostly routine grunts. That changed when Beelzebub surfaced in the center of the city bringing hellfire with him on a quest to capture humans to use in his army.

Garrett, much more fit at this point, popped open an umbrella. Rockets attached to the brim turned on and he flew up into the air. He was in tight, blue spandex that covered his entire body and face. Chunks of the street below him spewed upward revealing plumes of lava seeping out onto the road. Down on the road, Harold donned a red spandex suit with a matching headband. He had two hammers in his hands which he slammed against the ground, pushing him upward. Harold flew through the air and Garrett grabbed hold of him.

“You’ll have to move quicker than that if you want to catch us, Beelzebub!” Garrett shouted. He slowly drifted down to a chunk of concrete about twenty feet tall floating in the lava. When they landed, fire spewed upward onto the side of the rock. It molded to form a figure taller than the two of them would be standing on top of one another. The figure changed to appear somewhere in between a giant man and a wasp.

“We can take him! Let’s do this, Gadget Garrett!” Harold said. Beelzebub cackled.

“Please do try,” Beelzebub said. His rugged voice somehow echoed out of a bug’s head. He snapped his fingers. Screams echoed out from the distance.

“Civilians? I thought we got them all!” Garrett said.

“We did! He’s just playing tricks to separate us. If we stick here, we can beat him!”

“I—I can’t take that risk. That could be someone’s family. Harold, stay safe here!” Garrett said. He popped back open his umbrella and flew off toward the screams. Harold turned toward Beelzebub who stood idly by watching them discuss.

Harold spun his hammers in his hand. “You think you won just cause you split us apart. Well, you got another thing coming!” He ran forward and leapt into the air swinging his hammers down.

Meanwhile, Garrett closed in on the screams echoing from a chunk of road flowing down the lava river. A kid hung off the side of the rock shouting out as his feet kicked helplessly against the wall unable to pull himself up. Garrett landed on the rock and ran over to where the kid was hanging. He reached his arms down. When his hands made contact with the kid’s the child disappeared in a plume of smoke.

“Oh, no. Harold!” Garrett stood up and flew back in the direction he came from.

When he landed where Harold was, Beelzebub had his insect-like legs crossed over Harold keeping him pressed against his scaled

body. Harold attempted to squirm, but Beelzebub seemed unphased by his movements.

“Should have listened to him, Garrett. I’m going to have so much fun with your friend,” Beelzebub muttered. Before he could react, Beelzebub sunk through the floor with the lava following after him. Within seconds the city returned to normal except for the chunks of rock thrown about.

All the light disappeared from Harold’s perception as he was pulled underground. His body seemed to slip through the earth, his molecules dripping between the sediment. He could not breathe while Beelzebub pulled him farther and farther down. Light returned and Harold could move again. He stood in an abyss. Darkness stretched out in each direction except for a lone campfire burning off in the distance. “Hello!” Harold shouted, but there was no response. Only him.

I know, quite a lot of theatrics, but I must keep up the persona to keep the purity of the results. What made Harold appealing as a test subject was his determination. Not the fact that he possessed it, many do, but that he had no reason to. There was nothing for him up above. He had no family, no career, no one except Garrett. No reason to push on. It’s such an intriguing branch of humanity to watch. It is almost miraculous that they can keep going with almost no fuel. I have no idea what it is in them that allows such things to happen. That’s why I bring them here. I need to find out what gives them this willpower.

I had expected him to crack as soon as he had been dropped off, but it appeared he had no intention of letting the underworld keep him. Not to worry, most made it at least a few stages before their willpower ran out and this was the first time I got to play with such a unique specimen so I was excited to see how far he would go.

He walked toward the campfire; the air entirely still and seemingly no heat coming from it. Once he was close enough, he could hear the crackling of the flames and saw a set of two charred skeletons sitting around the fire. Their motionless black bones leaned up against logs. He stared into the closest one's skull for longer than he cared to admit. Eventually, he continued to walk forward, or was it downward, or was it up?

He marched his way through storms that lasted days, never stopping. In this realm his body seemed to remain still metabolically speaking. He had no need for water nor ever felt the slightest bit of hunger, but he still felt pain.

Once he exited the storm, he found the ground to be wet, the sediment beneath him slippery. Trenches about as wide as a human's body were littered around him etching off into the distance. Upon hearing a squelching noise, he found the source of these trenches. Humans with their arms and legs tied together squirmed through the mud digging the trenches deeper and deeper. He carried on.

A hammer shop awaited Harold once he marched past the marshland. He stared through the windows to find countless copies of the tool lining the shelves. The head of his hammers had long since lost their shine. Blood stained the metal a foul brown. He tried to walk

around the store, but found he was unable to locate where it ended. So, he marched in through the door and passed the aisles. His eyes drifted to the hammers, but never did he reach for them. He carried on.

He stepped out of the back door to find concrete replicas of Beelzebub. Hundreds of them lined the horizon and filled the space all the way into the darkness. Harold pulled his hammer out and began to swing it, but before his hammer could connect with the first statue of Beelzebub a pain spread through his wrist. His blood outlined an invisible spike and when he pulled his hand off, he could see his blood drip down onto the statue coating dozens of other invisible spikes. Harold got on the ground and crawled beneath the statues. *I will say, this was the part I really thought would get him, but he carried on.*

By the time the hole in his arm had stopped bleeding, either because it clotted, or maybe the dirt just covered it up, he had reached the end of the army of statues. Whisps of smoke rose out from the ground in front of him. As he walked past them, he could hear faint murmurs coming from underneath the ground. He carried on.

Once the murmurs had faded, Harold found himself staring at an exact replica of himself that mimicked each motion he made as if he was in front of an enormous mirror. When he moved left, it moved right. When he tried to crawl forward it got down on the ground too. Unable to move past this replica, Harold paced for days. Out of options, he reached forward and hugged the replica. It hugged him back. As they were hugging, he side stepped so they spun in a circle

and when he let go, they were now on the opposite side to where they started. They saluted each other before walking off. He carried on.

Harold reached a frozen lake. He looked down into the ice. Corpses were frozen beneath him, their eyes wide open. Each step he took was intentional as he crossed the lake. Occasionally he would hear something crack below him, but he had no choice but to keep marching forward until he made it to the other side. There, he found a light.

Now see, while what I just told you only took a few minutes to say, this was the equivalent to decades for Harold, more or less. He spoke to himself a lot during this time. Ramblings about how Garrett would come for him. He tried to convince himself it was all a dream. So, one could only imagine how he felt when he walked into that light and found himself standing in a bakery watching Garrett place his order.

“You—You’re just here eating!” Harold said. At this point he was unrecognizable. During the countless years underneath his body had been covered in scraps of cloth that melded with his skin over the course of time. All that could be seen was his eyes and mouth. He held one hammer in his hand. The second had long since broken and he had connected the two broken pieces of the hammer’s claw to his head forming some resemblance to demonic horns.

“Are you talking to me? I’m afraid I don’t know who you are,” Garrett said. His hands were resting on the handles to a baby stroller that was currently empty.

“Oh. You will!” Harold lunged forward; his hammer stretched outward with infernal energy spiraling around it. Garrett pulled an umbrella out from the stroller and popped it open. Harold’s hammer collided with the umbrella sending a shockwave through the building, smashing out the windows. Garrett flew backward onto the street and Harold leapt after him.

Garrett used the boosters on the inside of the umbrella to prop himself up before Harold could reach him. Garrett retracted the umbrella and jabbed it forward as if it was a rapier. Harold leapt backward dodging the attack but found himself unable to close the distance. The umbrella thrust forward stopping right in front of Harold.

“Came up short!” Harold said. Garrett clicked a button on the handle of the umbrella, and a burst of blue energy shot outward knocking Harold backward. As he flew through the air, Garrett smacked his hand against his chest.

“Stroller, activate suit mode.” The stroller flew out from the bakery and broke into pieces remolding around his body. He had designed this for the horrific scenario that someone came to attack his son, so the suit was built for a smaller body. It only managed to cover Garrett’s legs and arms. He used the power in the suit’s legs to leap forward grabbing Harold midair and slamming him through the roof of a building into an empty art studio. Paintings lined the walls with mats covered in dried paint lining the ground. “I don’t know who you are, but if it’s a fight you’re looking for than I will deliver!”

“Come on . . . don’t recognize me? Maybe it would help if you could get a better look.” Harold slipped backward and snapped his fingers. A dozen fiery clones of himself formed around the studio. All of them charged Garrett at once. He popped back out the umbrella and charged forward impaling one of the clones. The tip of the umbrella pierced through the clone and he mashed the button on the handle firing shots into three of the clones. The clones’ burning skin melted off the cloth top of the umbrella.

Garrett stopped his charge letting the clone he had impaled fly off the umbrella. He snapped the umbrella on his knee and ducked down as a clone leapt across where he was. Garrett threw the pointed end of the umbrella outward knocking another clone into the wall. He grabbed the end with the handle and began firing off shots into the rest of the clones. Now that the barrel had been disconnected, he was firing shotgun-like bursts of energy that ricocheted through the room coating it all in a blue aura. He used his suit to flip through the air dodging the shots bouncing around as he continued to fire off more until it was just him and Harold.

“Seems like you still got it, Gadget Garrett,” Harold said.

“I always kept a trick around in case something like—Wait. How do you know that name?” Garrett stepped backward. “Harold. Is that you? You’re alive?”

“Why didn’t you look for me!”

“I did! I searched everywhere but there was no trace of you—”

“So, you just went along with your life? Went and found a family while I was stuck down there!”

“What was I supposed to do? I just—Ugh. I need a cigarette.” Garrett reached into his pocket and grabbed a pack. He took one of the cigarettes out and touched it to the end of his umbrella to light it before putting it in his mouth.

“You didn’t smoke before.”

“No, I always did. You just didn’t notice,” Garrett said. He took the cigarette out of his mouth and puffed a plume of smoke into the room. “So, are we still going to fight?”

“Are we still going to . . . You have no idea what I saw. It never ended! All of it because you didn’t listen to me!” Harold gripped his hammer tighter.

“Are you sure you want to do this?” Garrett asked. He took the cigarette out of his mouth and threw it to the ground then smothered it with his boots.

“Yes.” Harold lunged forward. Garrett shot a blast of raw energy forward, but Harold slammed his hammer down in front of himself splitting the beam, so it only cut the edges of his body. Garrett attempted to block the hammer swing with his armored arms crossed in front of himself, but Harold’s hammer swung down with such force that it shattered his arm pieces and pushed Garrett down into the ground cracking the leg portion of his armor.

Garrett used the last of his suit's energy to fly upward through the ceiling, his suit falling in pieces behind him. Harold snarled then jumped through the hole after him but was knocked backward by a blast of energy as soon as he exited the building. He rolled across the roof of the building crashing against a wall on the edge. Garrett stepped toward him, pointing the end of his blaster at him. They stared at each other.

"Just leave me be! It wasn't my fault!" Garrett said.

"I don't care whose fault it was!"

"Why—Why couldn't you have just let me eat my croissant in peace," Garrett said. The blue glow of the blaster shined against Harold's forehead. Harold laughed to himself. "What's so funny?" Garrett asked.

"I know the man used an umbrella as a weapon, but he wasn't that cheesy. Garrett, I know that isn't you. I knew it as soon as you ordered just one croissant. Nobody does that. Nobody human at least. Although, there have been times over the years I have wanted to hit you. I just wanted to get it out of my system. I know it wasn't your fault," Harold said.

Everything faded to black and before Harold could process what was happening, he was standing. "Tell me, was it the cigarette part? I just thought it would look cool." Harold turned around to see Beelzebub standing over him. Beelzebub was wearing a lab coat that had enough holes for each of his arms and his glasses curved around his enormous bug-eyes.

“No, I had it from the croissant part. How long I been out for?”

“About a month. Probably feels like longer to you though.”

“Yeah, you had me scared it was a few decades or something.”

“Nope, just the underworld warping your mind. I must thank you for this research. You provided such powerful data. I must know. How can you fight on? How can you keep going when there is no hope? How can you keep fighting even when I took Garrett from you? Why don’t you break? Why don’t you humans break?”

“Don’t know. It’s just what I do.”

“An underwhelming answer, but alas. You humans are so malleable. How intriguing.

“I can erase your memories then put you back to the moment I took your from with all the nothingness in store for you. Or I can put you in the present day, one month in the future, just as you are right now. Hardened. Proven to have more willpower than most. Your choice.”

“Can I think about it for a little?” Harold asked. Beelzebub nodded his head.

Harold walked back through the darkness until the fire appeared on the horizon. The two charred skeletons were still sitting around it propped up against logs of wood. He sat down next to the skeletons and leaned against the log so he stared into the fire. Sparks sputtered up into the air fading back into darkness before reaching the

ground. Harold sat there for a while. He could feel the warmth of the fire coating his body.

Pigeon Person

Momentum stuck his hand outward. It was stopped by a wall of spinning wind like that of a tornado except everything around him was blowing away as opposed to in. Instead of funneling up, this wind curved in onto itself forming an opaque white dome. He stood in a park located just outside of Skum City. Tensile and Burnout stood next to him.

“We only have a few minutes until the government shows up. They were just itching for something like this to happen,” Tensile said.

“Maybe they don’t know for sure he’s the one causing this?” Momentum asked.

“No, if Pillbug-Man was waiting for this to happen then they are sure to know too. They’ll send a small army and probably their attack dogs,” Tensile said.

“How are we going to stop this before they get here?” Momentum asked.

“I could probably make a countercurrent by running around it, but this wind is moving pretty fast. I think I could provide an opening for one person if they were pushed in before the wind would pick back up,” Burnout said.

“Good. Momentum, you’ll go in. I’m going to stay out here and call for backup. We’ll wait for the Colonel and buy you as much time as we can,” Tensile said.

“Why me?” Momentum asked.

“Well it is either you or me and you really want me to be the one to go in and talk to him?” Tensile asked.

“Yeah, you’re right,” he said. Tensile raised her scarf so it covered her nose.

Burnout marked an area on the ground with an X then slid their goggles over their face and muttered, “Come on. You can do it. You cleared out an apartment building. You can run farther than the average person.” They blasted off in a blur of red circling around the dome, kicking dirt into the air.

Momentum cupped his hands over his eyes to cut out the debris and aimed his anchor right above the X. The white wall wavered as the wind blew past them and dust kicked up in the opposite direction. It began to give way, and Momentum could just barely see into the center of the park.

“GO NOW!” Tensile shouted. She rammed into Momentum and he flew into the dome and through the wall of wind. He tumbled to the ground and watched as the wall turned white again behind him. The center of the park was untouched. Light still slipped through the wind, not one branch on the trees had been damaged, and the grass quietly blew as if a gentle breeze was rolling by. Momentum looked forward to see a costumed man sitting on a bench off in the distance. Pigeons sat around him.

Outside of the dome, as soon as Momentum was pushed through it, Burnout’s circular pattern broke and they tumbled across the grass leaving singed marks with each bump across the ground. Tensile ran over to them.

“I’ll be okay. First clearing out an apartment a few weeks ago, now slowing a tornado. Who knows. Maybe someday I’ll run around the world or something,” Burnout said before chuckling. When Tensile lifted Burnout up, she saw a shadow off in the distance outlined by the sun. It would rise up in the air then fall back down. It grew larger and larger until she could see that it was a woman in armor leaping toward them. She could now hear a pounding of the ground; she began to make out key features on the woman and could see she held a mace in her hand. Tensile rubbed the long-distance relationship bracelet on her arm.

Battle Gal crashed against the ground landing in the park. She kicked up dirt forming a trench when she came to a stop. Tensile and Burnout ran over to see Battle Gal brushing the dirt off her armor as she stepped out of the trench she had formed.

“Is this the disturbance?” Battle Gal asked them.

“Who’s asking?” Tensile asked.

“Not answering to some kid. Is this the disturbance or not?” Battle Gal asked again.

“Use your eyes and you tell me if you think that giant wind dome is a disturbance,” Tensile said. She crossed her arms.

“Good. Stay here and I’ll kill the blockbuster inside causing this,” Battle Gal said.

“No can do. We got someone in there right now. We’re not going to kill the powered individual here,” Tensile said.

“Do you know who you’re talking to right now?” Battle Gal asked.

“You’re staying out here until this is settled,” Burnout said.

“Tch. Whatever. I don’t feel like beating up kids today although my friends will be here shortly. You won’t like it when they get here. It would be in your best interest to let me handle this,” Battle Gal said.

Tensile pulled the scarf off from around her neck.

“My friends will be here shortly too. I advise you leave before they get here,” she said. Battle Gal snarled and swung her mace forward. Tensile flipped backward as Burnout dashed past Battle Gal punching her in the face then twisting her helmet so it covered her eyes.

Tensile spun out her scarf so it wrapped around the arm Battle Gal had her mace in and ripped backward but her arm would not budge. Battle Gal grabbed the scarf and tore it toward her. Tensile flew toward Battle Gal but midair was tackled to the side by Burnout in a burst of light.

“Just hold her back until Momentum gets done!” Tensile said. Battle Gal ran toward them dragging her mace against the ground.

Inside the bubble, Momentum walked up to the man petting the pigeons. Their silver bodies hopped over his feathered outfit and one laid next to him while he stroked their back with his gloved hands. He had a hood attached to his suit, but it was pulled off and hanging at his back. Momentum could see a piece of yellow plastic that looked like a bird’s beak right above the opening where the man’s face would go. The pigeons cooed as they fluttered into the trees once they finished the seeds he gave them.

“Penelope told me you would come,” the man said.

“Who’s that?” Momentum asked.

“She’s the god of pigeons. She’s the reason why I am able to make that dome. She’s why I need to keep all of the pigeons in Skum City safe here. This will be their sanctuary and I won’t let you take that away from me. I could pull the air away from you and let your lungs explode in a vacuum. Don’t test me.”

“I’m not here to fight you. I just want to talk. I know who you are. I know what you’ve done,” Momentum said.

“Good things?” the man asked.

“Nothing but.”

“Oh. Well, would you like to hold one of the pigeons then?” the man asked. He picked one up from the ground and gently held it out toward Momentum, the pigeon sat unphased by this man grabbing it.

“Um. Sure,” Momentum said. He took the bird out of the man’s hands and cradled it against his chest. The man picked up the bird that had been sleeping next to him and placed it on his own lap.

“Care to sit next to me?”

“Yeah, I can,” Momentum walked over to the man and into the flock of pigeons pecking at the ground careful not to bump any of them as he sat down. His metal grappling hooks clinked against the bench when he sat down.

“It’s nice to meet you Pigeon Person, my name’s Momentum,” Momentum said.

“Do you know who you’re protecting?” Battle Gal asked. She swung her mace forward and Tensile rolled to the side. Burnout dashed past her delivering a swift blow before running off again to line up another shot.

“Years of inactivity. Countless catastrophes ignored. The first thing that brings him out in years? He saw a pigeon get run over on his way home from work yesterday,” Battle Gal said. With each sentence Battle Gal swung forward. Tensile sidestepped her then spun backward so the heel of her foot crashed against Battle Gal’s face.

Battle Gal stumbled backward and a red blur appeared in the distance. It blasted toward her. Burnout leapt into the air and rammed her shoulder against Battle Gal knocking them both backward. Burnout quickly caught themselves as they tumbled backward and dashed back to Tensile’s side.

“That punch earlier was me running from a block away. Anymore, and I break my wrist. That tackle was from the end of the city. If it doesn’t stop her, I can’t hit her with anything harder before breaking—ARGH,” Burnout screamed out in pain. Their words were cut short by two gunshots followed by a bullet piercing each of their legs. They collapsed to the ground.

“BURNOUT!” Tensile shouted as she ran to their side. On a distant building Soldier 35 tipped his motorcycle off the edge of the roof and rode it down the side of the building. The gun slung over his back flew in the air behind him while his slicked-up hair did not move. Tensile could see the black strips beneath his eyes and the military grade clothes covering his body. When Soldier 35 reached the ground, he jumped off his motorcycle.

The motorcycle with no driver continued moving toward Tensile. Before the motorcycle crashed against Tensile it transformed into a robot that grabbed Tensile and then uppercut her with momentum from his charge. Tensile fell backward to the ground while H8ywire's wire frame body landed on the ground with a thump. Before she could gather her surroundings, Tensile was yanked off the ground by Battle Gal who spun her around then threw her. Tensile rocketed toward a nearby building and through the glass doors of their entrance. She toppled across the lobby before coming to a stop.

Burnout continued to writhe on the ground.

"Quit squirming or I'll fire a few more into those legs. We know how you speedsters can be with your healing," Soldier 35 said. He lifted his boot up and pressed it down on Burnout's legs, pushing more blood out of the wounds. They screamed out as Soldier 35 giggled.

"Enough fooling around. You think we can get through this?" Battle Gal asked. She pointed toward the wind dome.

"Let H8ywire take a look at it. I'm sure he can find a way through," Soldier 35 said.

Inside the dome, Momentum and Pigeon Person's conversation continued.

"You know, I figure this is the least I can do for the pigeons. It isn't their fault we domesticated them then abandoned them. Even worse, people view them as pests now. How could someone think such a thing about these creatures? I see how intelligent and emotional they

are. They each have a personality if you just look,” Pigeon Person said.

Momentum stared at the pigeon sleeping on his lap. Its stomach pushed in and out with each breath occasionally nodding its head in its sleep. Up this close, he could see how the feathers changed hues as they stretched across the bird’s body from greys to greens and blues.

“You know my favorite part about them?” Pigeon Person asked.

“What?”

“You don’t have to hide yourself from them.”

“What do you mean?”

“I—I sometimes have bad thoughts. I know everyone does sometimes, but mine scare me. I know the power Penelope gave me. I know what it could do to someone. I know I wouldn’t hurt someone, but the thought that I could . . . sometimes I feel like a bad person even when I haven’t done anything bad at all.

“Why do some of us get to have so much influence on others?” Pigeon Person asked.

“I think we all have the same influence on people. It’s just some people care more about others,” Momentum said. He slowly pet the pigeon in his lap. It cooed softly when he rubbed his finger across its back.

“I wish I could see it that way . . . Here let me show you what I mean,” Pigeon Person said. He picked up the pigeon in his lap and lifted it up so the bird was level with his head. Pigeon Person stared at the sleeping bird and said, “I’m sorry I thought about bursting the

lungs of the man driving that car yesterday. I wouldn't ever do that to anyone. I don't know why I thought it. I just . . . I'm sorry. I know I'm not a violent person."

Pigeon Person slowly set the bird back down on his lap. "See. All better now and the pigeon doesn't care that I thought such a thing. It just knows me as a caretaker. Why don't you try?"

Momentum nodded his head and picked up the bird in his lap, so he was level with it. The bird's black, beady eyes opened briefly and met with Momentum's brown eyes. Momentum thought of what to say, opened his mouth, then said, "I'm sorry I'm not the hero I should be yet. I should have been saving people all this year, not going to group therapy and stuff. I wish I was stronger." Momentum set the bird back down in his lap.

"Feel better?"

"A little."

"You know, I had a woman I was seeing to talk about things. Hard when you can't tell someone everything. Even though I only knew her as my therapist I just didn't want her to see me that way. I don't want anyone to know," Pigeon Person said.

"I had a guy I could tell everything to. He was married to someone in our line of work. His wife was this angel and his life was crazy, but the same kind of crazy as mine."

"I guess we all hope for our spouse to be an angel," Pigeon Person said.

"No, like she was literally an angel . . . at least that's the working theory."

“Fair enough. You said ‘had’ a person to talk to.”

“Yeah, I wish he was here still cause I think you’d like him. I’d tell you something he told me, but I’d just mess up his own words.”

“I appreciate the sentiment at least,” Pidgeon Person said.

“I am detecting a brief interval every thirty-four seconds within which I would be able to cross the boundary,” H8ywire said. It moved its hand away from the dome.

“So do it then!” Soldier 35 shouted.

“Roger—” H8ywire was cut short by a metal rod bouncing off the back of his head. The shiny silver pole hit his head then landed on the ground standing straight up as if magnetized to the road.

“Where did that come from?” Battle Gal asked.

“I don’t detect any—” Soldier 35 was cut off as a man in a toga appeared out of thin air and uppercut him. Soldier 35 went flying backward. An enormous Bat lunged out of nowhere onto H8ywire pushing his metallic body against the ground as Rider shouted from the side for him to tear the robot to shreds.

Pillbug-Man, Dragonfly, and Microcosm appeared by the pole. “Nice work, Microcosm! We did it!” Pillbug-Man said. He pat her on her shoulder before running over to Burnout. He reached his hand out and grabbed them lifting Burnout up, so their arm was wrapped around his shoulders. Burnout muttered something incoherent as he dragged them off the battlefield.

“Don’t worry. The cavalry is here. You did what we needed you to do,” Pillbug-Man said. Dragonfly grabbed her staff off the

ground, spun it in the air, then pointed it toward Battle Gal. The light from the sun moved up the pole glimmering at its end.

“Battle Gal, how about you pick on someone closer to your age!” Dragonfly shouted.

“You’re like sixty!” Battle Gal said.

“Don’t act like you’re so different. I know what you are,” Dragonfly said. Microcosm stepped in between them.

“Let me handle her,” Microcosm said.

“We can do this together!” Dragonfly said.

“No. I can handle this.”

“You! So that’s how they appeared here. I remember that bronze hue and your father’s crafty abilities,” Battle Gal said.

“Then you also remember that he outlasted you that night. You’re pathetic. A brute that swings first and asks questions later. Too brash to make any actual difference in the fight. I know I can beat you alone because my dad outlasted you. I am everything he was and more.”

“Then raise your hands and fight me!” Battle Gal shouted.

Microcosm grabbed a penny out of her pocket and flipped it in the air. “When this lands, step back,” she said before throwing a small bronze orb forward. It collided with Battle Gal, and she instantly disappeared followed by Microcosm shrinking herself down.

Battle Gal was ripped downward and when she finally was able to understand her surroundings, she could see the markings of Abraham Lincoln’s nose. She was no larger than one of his nostrils, so small that the only thing beyond the penny was darkness. Microcosm

crashed down against the penny larger than Abraham Lincoln's head. Battle Gal was knocked backward and before she could land against the ground, Microcosm picked her up in her hands and swung her against the penny, smashing her body against the ground again and again.

After hitting the penny numerous times, her helmet shattered, Battle Gal bounced back up into the air. The pieces of the helmet scraped against her face as they flew off into the distance. Microcosm shrunk down so they were the same size and dropkicked Battle Gal knocking her to the edge of the penny. She rolled off the side of it and hung by the ridges.

"You were supposed to keep him safe!"

"I tried!" Battle Gal shouted.

"No. No you didn't. Not really," Microcosm said. She turned around and walked back to the center of the penny as Battle Gal pulled herself back up. Battle Gal rolled back onto the penny and on to her back.

"So, kill me then! It's just us right now," Battle Gal said between breaths.

"Why bother. You'd just come back anyways. It isn't your fault that you're weak, but I won't let you contribute to another hero's death."

Dragonfly watched the penny flip through the air falling toward the ground. At the moment it touched the ground, Microcosm and Battle Gal appeared in front of her. Battle Gal laid on the ground gasping for air, her helmet missing and blood dripping from her mouth.

“Told you I had it,” Microcosm said. As Microcosm walked by Dragonfly she pat her on the shoulder. Still unsure what she just saw, Dragonfly stared at Battle Gal lying on the ground. Her gaze was only broken when she heard Bat howl in the distance. She popped open her wings and flew toward Rider and Bat.

Philosopher and Soldier 35 spun around each other trading blows. Soldier 35 jammed the butt of his gun forward, but Philosopher smacked it to the side. Any swing from Philosopher never got close to connecting with Soldier 35.

“You know, I have a lot of students just like you. Driven. Determined. Confident. They possess all of those traits but yet can’t tell me why. What are they reaching for? Why are they pushing so hard? What makes them think they can do it?”

“Shut up. I don’t need some lecture from a washed-up Greek,” Soldier 35 said.

“Funny coming from the man who allies himself with the woman in Spartan gear,” Philosopher said before dodging a spin kick from Soldier 35 by striking The Thinker’s pose. “That ‘why’. It’s important. For example, why are you Soldier 35? What happened to the rest? Why do so many of you come and go? Why is it you that is the one here now?”

“I have a job to do and that’s it.”

“See, it is that rugged, macho thinking that had led our military to become what it is today,” Philosopher said.

“Enough!” Soldier 35 rammed the point of his gun into Philosopher, knocking him back. He aimed his reticle straight at

Philosopher's head. Before he could pull the trigger, a fist collided with his jaw sending him down to the ground. He looked up to see Pillbug-Man standing above him.

"Real heroes don't use guns," Pillbug-Man said. Soldier 35 reached for his rifle, but Pillbug-Man slammed his boot against Soldier 35's head knocking it toward the ground rendering him unconscious. Pillbug-Man ran over to check on Philosopher.

In the distance, Bat continued to swing H8ywire back and forth like a dog trying to tear open a toy. Bolts flew off the robot clinking against the ground. H8ywire pressed a button on its wrist and electricity flowed across its frame then into Bat loosening his grip. Bat crumpled to the ground with a howl as H8ywire's body adjusted itself to be upright. Its metallic fingers moved up and down the frame, assessing the damage.

A metal rod slammed against the back of H8ywire knocking it forward into a spin kick from Rider. H8ywire spiraled backward and slid against the ground. Dragonfly leapt into the air and jammed the pole through H8ywire's chest into the ground. H8ywire reached its arms up at the pole weakly attempting to pry it out from its chest before the light on its head went out.

The heroes gathered with Battle Gal, Soldier 35, and H8ywire unconscious on the ground tied together. "No wonder Tokyo fell. These three are pathetic," Microcosm said.

"Indeed, they are, but I must ask you to step away from government property," Colonel York asked. She let go of the rope and landed on the ground next to them. Dozens of soldiers armed with

guns and camouflage armor descended from helicopters above landing on the ground behind her. Pillbug-Man looked to the wind dome.

“Who told you all about me? I haven’t been active for a long time,” Pigeon Person asked.

“Pillbug-Man did. He’s been keeping tabs on you to make sure you were okay. You can come home with us today and see him.”

“That’s real nice of him considering how much we used to fight back in the golden days.”

“You’re a good man. You were a good hero. That’s why Pillbug-Man kept tabs on you.”

“I’m glad he sees me that way. It’s sort of funny I picked a pigeon to dress up as. I wanted to represent them. I wanted to be what was viewed as less but capable of more. I didn’t expect to become one of them. There’s no real room in the world for people like that.”

“Why would you say something like that?”

“It’s just . . . forty some years of fighting out here and where are things? If anything, the world I live in now is worse than the one I started in. There’s no Alpha Squadron. There’s nothing to keep us all together.”

“So what if heroes are the pigeons of the world now? There are still people who like to feed birds,” Momentum said unsure if he was able to keep up with this analogy.

Outside, Pillbug-Man noticed that Colonel York’s hair had not changed much in the years minus a few gray hairs spread in the black

although they were almost unperceivable because she slicked it all back. Her skin sagged beneath her eyes, but otherwise she was not too different from the woman Microcosm's father had met.

Pillbug-Man, Philosopher, Dragonfly, and Microcosm stood facing the soldiers. Tensile and Burnout were still out and injured. Rider was off tending to Bat.

"Colonel York, is it?" Pillbug-Man asked.

Microcosm ripped her helmet off to shout at Colonel York.

"You're the one who sent my dad on that suicide mission?"

"I sent him off to do his job," Colonel York said.

"You cold hearted—" Microcosm began to say.

"Save it. If I stopped doing what I do every time I felt bad this world would have ended three times over by now."

"I don't think we could take these guys," Philosopher whispered to Pillbug-Man.

"Yeah, not in a fight," Pillbug-Man whispered. He stepped forward so he now stood in front of the heroes. "Is this the same way you approached Stupendous Man? Guns at the ready."

"No, I just approached him and had a conversation."

"Which I'm sure you handled tactfully," Pillbug-Man said.

"I will admit that I may have overstepped my boundaries at points, but I am not paid to sugarcoat things."

"You're here to kill Pigeon Person, aren't you?" Pillbug-Man asked.

"I'm here to eliminate the threat."

"Yeah, use the term 'threat'. That will make it easier for you to kill a human being."

“And who do you think you are, Pillbug-Man, to manipulate my words like that?”

“I’m what’s left. I’m all you’d have left to call upon if another world ending threat would arise again. We are the ones that remain, and this isn’t going to work if we fight. It didn’t work when Alpha Squadron imploded, and it won’t work right now if the military turns on us because when the day comes it will take all of us. We cannot lose any more good people.”

Philosopher, Dragonfly, and Microcosm stood watching Pillbug-Man speak. The soldiers left their guns pointed at Pillbug-Man. He stepped onto a piece of rubble to continue speaking. The wind from the dome still spun around them kicking up dust. Civilians stood off in the distance hiding behind nearby buildings watching the military stare down the heroes.

“There are times to fight, do not misconstrue my words. I will fight when the threats awaiting Earth arise, as will my fellow heroes. Today is not one of those times. That man out there is hurt. He is not broken. He is not worthless. Let my people continue to talk to him and I guarantee no one dies today and he comes home to fight with us when the looming threats arise.

“Please. We can’t afford to reset again. The world can’t wait another twenty years to be ready. Today, we have the opportunity to be better than the Alpha Squadron. I apologize for what my team and I did to your soldiers. It was no different than the Alpha Squadron turning on each other and destroying Hope City. We didn’t see another way out. One of my students had been shot and your soldiers seemed

determined to kill my friend. It can stop right now though. Just let my people finish what they started,” Pillbug-Man said.

Colonel York looked toward the ground. She raised her hand up and pinched the bridge of her nose rubbing against the bone. Her foot tapped on the ground as her hand drifted up to her forehead. “Ten minutes,” Colonel York said.

“Sometimes when it gets real bad, I can’t hear people’s voices. It’s just this violin sound that I hear when they open their mouths. Not in a beautiful way but like in the way of playing a low note for too long.” Pigeon Person laughed to himself. “Man, I sound crazy. That should have been saved for the pigeons.”

“No, you don’t. When things were really bad for me, I heard people call my name and when I looked around there was no one looking at me. I used to relate to this one artist called Blood Girl. I felt she was the only one who felt the same way I did.”

“That doesn’t sound like a great musician to be relating to.”

Momentum laughed to himself.

“Nope. Robbie Dupree, she was not,” Momentum said.

Pidgeon Person laughed.

“How does he relate to anything?”

“I don’t know, his music just makes me think he’d be a good guy to be like,” Momentum said with a smile.

They sat in silence with the quiet whoosh of wind in the distance.

“How do we get better?” Pigeon Person asked.

“Slowly, but together,” Momentum said. He gave the pigeon in his hands one last pet before setting it to his side. “I really enjoy talking to you here, but there’s some people out there that aren’t happy with what you’re doing,” Momentum said still sitting on the bench.

“I know.”

“My friends are out there right now, but it might not be long before someone else comes looking.”

“Have you ever seen a bird get run over?” Pigeon Man asked. Momentum’s heart plummeted at the thought.

“No, luckily.”

“When they get hit, they don’t splat like other animals. They erupt in a beautiful plume of feathers. Even in death, they are beauty. It isn’t like that with humans.”

“No. It isn’t,” Momentum said. He watched a pigeon in front of them peck at the ground. “You know you aren’t broken, right?”

“Sometimes I do,” Pidgeon Person said.

“I think that’s what makes us heroes. That feeling that creeps up of being worthless or broken. It’s a good thing. It shows we still care so much. If we never questioned our actions, then would we truly be heroes?” Momentum asked.

“Thanks, Kid.”

“This doesn’t have to all end today in this wind dome. Come with us. We can all work together.”

Outside, Colonel York continued to pace in circles. Wind blew past them pushing at her jacket and rustling her hair. Her soldiers

remained steady. She stopped and looked up toward Pillbug-Man, “Your ten minutes are almost up.”

“Have a little faith in humans for once, will you?”

Colonel York rolled her eyes before continuing her pacing. Slowly, almost unperceivably, the wind began to slow. Philosopher was the first to notice. He ran over to Pillbug-Man and shook his shoulder then pointed at the dome. Slowly, the white wall of wind began to fade, and the greens of the park started to shine through again.

Once the wind had subsided two people could be seen in the park walking toward them. As they grew closer it was apparent that they were each holding a pigeon. A flock of pigeons hobbled after them trotting across the ground.

The soldiers raised their guns and pointed them at the two figures.

“Hold your fire!” Colonel York said.

Soon, it became apparent that Momentum and Pigeon Person were the ones walking out of the park. Pigeon Person had birds perched on his shoulder as he pet the one cradled in his hands. The birds followed in his shadow, never straying more than a few feet from him.

“Good to see you, Pillbug-Man!” Momentum shouted.

“I knew you could do it!” Pillbug-Man ran forward to give Momentum a brief hug before setting him down.

“I—I just said some stuff. It was really nothing.”

“You spoke from the heart. That’s something.” He turned to look at Pigeon Person. “Good to see you again, old friend.”

“Thanks for keeping an eye on me,” Pigeon Person said.

“Thanks for standing up against me back in the day,” Pillbug-Man said.

Colonel York walked up to them. Her black boots were now covered in dirt.

“I see your optimism has proven fruitful today, Pillbug-Man. May it do the same when larger threats arrive.” She turned around and returned to her soldiers. A half-dozen helicopters materialized in the air above them. Ropes flew out of them, and the soldiers grabbed onto them before ascending upward.

Pillbug-Man cupped his hands around his mouth and looked up to her zipping to the helicopter. “People rise up to the occasion. You just need to give them the chance.”

The New Year's Special

It was all purple. The purple scarf wrapped around a grunt's arm before he could reach for a baseball bat. Tensile pulled back and the man was tugged forward. As the grunt stumbled toward her, she wrapped the cloth around his leg then ripped it backward. The man fell to the ground. It was all pink. Momentum zipped past her. The cords attached to his grappling hooks retracted into his belt. His knee collided with a grunt's chest and Momentum continued to fly toward the wall where his hooks had been anchored. The grunt let loose a gasp of air as his body was crushed between the concrete and Momentum. It was all green. The lights beneath the plastic floor continued to shift colors while a disco ball above split light into white fragments covering the walls.

Momentum pulled himself over, so he stood next to Tensile who stared down another three grunts.

"They'll keep coming. You know that, right?" Shakedown asked from his enormous green velvet chair. He sat on a stage many feet up in the air, leaning forward with his chin resting on the top of his cane.

"I could take down a hundred of these grunts before even breaking a sweat. They're nothing compared to me," Tensile said. An end of her scarf was wrapped around each of her hands.

“Maybe you could, but I don’t need them to win, just to keep you busy for long enough,” Shakedown said. Momentum spit out saliva from his mouth.

“Why did you do that?” Tensile asked.

“People do that to get blood out of their mouths,” Momentum said.

“I know. But there wasn’t any blood in that. It was clear,” Tensile said. She lunged forward and whipped her scarf out so it coiled around a grunt’s chest. She tore her arm back and the man spun backward into another grunt.

“You saw what I spit out?” Momentum shouted. He swung through the air kicking grunts. It was all orange.

“So, an admission of guilt?” Tensile asked. She wrapped the scarf around a woman’s neck.

“What? No, I’m just confused—” Momentum was cut off. A fist cracked against his cheek. He stumbled backward as his grappling hooks released from the wall and zipped back into his belt. Momentum looked up to see the grunt sneer while they cracked their knuckles. Tensile leapt onto the grunt’s back and wrapped her scarf around their head covering the grunt’s eyes.

“Please do try to pay attention, Momentum!” Tensile shouted. It was all pink.

“Make sure to bundle up. It is unbelievably cold outside,” Tinkerer shouted. She stood in front of the stove stirring a pot of hot chocolate. A green entity on four legs scampered into the kitchen then stood up next to her. He wore a small, handmade hat. His horns stuck out through holes crocheted into the yarn. Tinkerer turned to look at him.

“Please do not say it.”

“OH MY! You look adorable!” Tinkerer said. She pinched Teen Demon’s cheeks.

“I am beyond concepts like ‘adorable’. It is pathetic to hear such things from a human,” Teen Demon said.

“Not beyond wearing that hat I made though,” Tinkerer said. She turned back to the stove to hide her smile. Mindmeld stepped into the kitchen barely recognizable under the many layers of coats and pants he was wearing. Teen Demon collapsed to the ground and rolled around laughing.

“You . . . look . . . adorable!” Teen Demon said as he cackled.

“We will see who gets the final laugh once we are outside in the cold.”

A gust of wind blew through the kitchen and Stupendous Man appeared next to Mindmeld.

“Ooh! I love that you are bundled up. I can hold you without worrying about your powers!” Stupendous Man said. He picked up Mindmeld with one hand and began chasing after Teen Demon with

his free hand outstretched. Tinkerer poured out four cups of hot chocolate as Stupendous Man continued shouting in the background. “I am holding both of my boys! I have both of them and they can’t escape!”

Markie floated into the kitchen and the boys froze in place. Stupendous Man held both Mindmeld and Teen Demon under his armpits.

“Perfect! I have my hands free for you now!” Stupendous Man said as he ran toward Markie.

“Run, Markie! He’s gonna get us all soon!” Teen Demon giggled.

Markie did not move as Stupendous Man lifted her higher into the air with his free hands.

“Is he planning to hold all of us so we can see the fireworks?” Markie asked while Stupendous Man spun them around.

“No, that’s why we had the gazebo built. We’ll all get in there and he’ll lift that up. Ooh, and the hot chocolate is done!” Tinkerer said.

Stupendous Man set all the others down. The three children each took a mug filled with hot chocolate and topped with whipped cream. Stupendous Man took an empty mug. Tinkerer took the last filled mug as they filtered out the door to the backyard.

It was all blue. Pillbug-Man fell through the skylight and into the warehouse at the shore of Skum City. Philosopher landed next to him. Pillbug-Man's back was against the ground, and he rocked around trying to flip himself back over.

"I knew the window would break if we both stood on it!" Philosopher said. He reached his hand out to Pillbug-Man.

"Great! Reinforcements have arrived!" Momentum said. A harpoon shot out from his belt and blasted past a grunt. The hooks plunged themselves into one of the metal shelves that lined the wall. Momentum clicked a button on his belt and the anchor retracted, bringing the shelf down on the grunt.

"Took you two long enough!" Tensile said. She spun around the opposition knocking them off balance. A grunt ran toward Philosopher, and they reeled their arm back while they tightened their fist. Right before the fist collided with his face, Philosopher knelt down and took a thinking position. Philosopher sprung upward as the grunt crossed over him. His fist collided with the grunt's groin. The grunt went flying backward and tumbled across the ground. It was all green. A large screen behind Shakedown lit up to reveal a countdown with only six minutes left.

"Bring as many heroes as you want. In six minutes, I press the button in my pocket and while everyone is distracted by the ball dropping and firework display, I will release thousands of nanobots that will fly through the air and infiltrate their phones. All their information will be mine. Any scandalous photo, all their bank info, and whatever else is valuable will become mine!" Shakedown said as

he stood up from his chair. He wore a cuffed white button-up shirt with a green vest and black pants.

“That’s no way to start the new year! Why are we dealing with these grunts? Can’t you just go for the stage and take down Shakedown then this is over?” Pillbug-Man asked. He dodged a punch.

“Hmm. Didn’t think of that actually,” Momentum said before zipping up into the air and toward the stage. It was all yellow.

“Welp, not a lick of crime in Skum City tonight,” Cobra Commando said. He had one foot up on the barrier to the side of the roof. He leaned into that leg so he could brood over the city. He stared down at the crowd waiting for the ball to drop. His costume formed a vaguely snake-like outline from the holiday lights shining against the front of his body.

“Careful you don’t slip. Mighty cold out tonight,” Totem said. She rubbed her hands together then held them over her amulet.

“We have no health insurance, don’t forget!” Phantom said. Cobra Commando stepped back from the ledge.

“You all never let me look cool. I wanted to brood. We’re heroes, away from our families, forced to spend the night protecting the city,” Cobra Commando said.

“Leave the theatrics for Phantom, Cobra. We’re getting paid to do this,” Chainlink said. Her jacket seemed to be stuffed to the limits as she had her chains hidden beneath the fabric.

“No one broods better than you, my friend,” Phantom said. He nodded at Chainlink.

“It’s a gift . . .” Chainlink said.

“. . . and my greatest curse!” Cobra Commando gasped. He held his hand upward and clasped an invisible skull. Chainlink smiled.

“Why are you hiding the chains under your jacket?” Phantom asked.

“It’s because her skin will rip off if the metal is too cold,” Totem said.

“No . . . It’s because I don’t want Cobra Commando tripping on them then falling off the roof,” Chainlink said.

“You know, I appreciate you. I do,” Cobra Commando said. He looked back down at the crowd. Five minutes until the new year.

Momentum ran forward and leapt upward. His harpoons dug into the ground by Shakedown’s dress shoes. Shakedown dove to the side as Momentum zipped down to the ground. His boot cracked the plastic flooring. It was all red.

“Just you and me up here. My grunts won’t let anyone else up on the stage. I could have made sure none of you got up here, but to be

honest this felt too easy. I like to get my hands dirty,” Shakedown said. He pushed his sleeves up so the cuffs now sat above his elbow.

“I’m going to kick you so hard you’ll go all the way back to last year,” Momentum said. He closed the distance between them. Shakedown blocked a roundhouse kick with his cane then used it to sweep at Momentum’s legs. The harpoons shot out into the ceiling and lifted Momentum upward. Momentum wrapped his legs around Shakedown’s head and swung his body so Shakedown went spiraling backward. It was all purple.

Shakedown stood back up. “Four minutes left, Momentum.” Shakedown threw his cane at him. It was all orange.

“Nathan, there’s some cookies in the break room if you want them,” Jeff said from the checkout lane one over.

“Are there enough left back there to last till my break?” Nathan asked.

“Erm. Not too sure with these folks around,” Jeff said. He nodded toward the deli section of the store.

“You think I can sneak back and grab some?”

The Transaction Tavern was empty except for the workers.

“Yeah, I think you’ll be just fine,” Jeff said. He continued to wait for the fireworks on the TV at the front of the store. A countdown in the corner of the screen read three minutes.

Nathan pushed through one of the swinging doors to the backrooms of Transaction Tavern. He turned the corner to the break room to find the table that freebies were usually left on. He could see a cookie container on the table, and he picked up his pace. Judging from the size, this was a bulk package so there had to have been at least fifty cookies in the container at launch, even conservatively estimating. With about ten or fifteen workers left in the store and an assumption that only two thirds of them had taken their breaks so far there had to be cookies remaining.

Nathan finally made it to the cookie container and tore off the clear plastic lid to better assess what remained. An assortment of ten cookies was left on the black tray. They were in various holiday shapes. Nathan reached for a Santa shaped sugar cookie, a safe bet, and bit down.

“YOUCH!” Nathan screamed out as his teeth flared with pain.

“What seems to be the issue, Nathan?” Richard asked as he walked over from the delivery bay.

“How old are these?” Nathan asked. He nibbled on the edge of Santa’s hat.

“They’re a part of a Christmas selection that no one bought.”

“So, you just gave us the leftover, stale cookies?” Nathan asked.

“Yes. Would there be a problem with that?”

“Hmm. I guess not. Why are we even open right now? We are a grocery store, and it is almost midnight on New Year’s Eve,” Nathan said.

“There always must be a groceryvenience store open. I can’t let another . . . incident go unfixed,” Richard said as he stared off. “Wait, why are you here? Don’t you have any friends?”

“You are the one that scheduled me.”

“Hmm. Don’t look at me. You were the one that left availability for this night. We truly live in a world created by our own actions,” Richard said. He walked off.

With each jab, the lights changed beneath them. Momentum dodged another punch from Shakedown who then dodged a harpoon shot at him. Below the stage, Pillbug-Man, Philosopher, and Tensile held off the grunts.

“We have to get up there somehow to help him!” Tensile said as a grunt fumbled a punch and stumbled past her. She tripped him and he fell face forward. The ground continued rapidly changing colors. Blue, orange, then green, then red, then purple, then pink.

“Should I call in Dragonfly and Bat-Rider?” Philosopher asked.

“No, they’re busy tonight,” Pillbug-Man said.

“What about the Protectors for Profit?” Tensile asked.

“No. We have to trust that Momentum can handle it. We will do our part down here and he will do his part up there,” Pillbug-Man said. He punched a grunt, and they flew backward into another grunt. Pillbug-Man curled into a ball and rolled into the first, knocking them both backward.

On the stage, Momentum raised his arms to block a punch. Shakedown broke through his guard and knocked Momentum backward onto the stage. Before Shakedown’s shoes could crash into his face, Momentum’s grapple hooks pulled him toward the wall. Momentum stumbled back to his feet.

“They sent their weakest to shine in my spotlight,” Shakedown said. He took off his vest and threw it into the crowd below. Shakedown spit blood out of his mouth.

“What the—Oh, this cologne smells nice,” Philosopher said from below.

“I’m not weak just because I’m in the middle of my character arc,” Momentum said. They charged at each other. Shakedown swung his right fist forward and Momentum stopped it with his left. Momentum swung his right fist forward and Shakedown stopped it with his left. They pushed against each other with their hands interlocked. Two minutes left. It was all red. Momentum could see the veins popping out of Shakedown’s neck and hear the grinding of his teeth.

There was only one way out of this. It would require precision, sacrifice, and left no room for errors. If he managed to pull this off, for

once Tensile would be proud of him. Just this once. It didn't matter what pink orbs he had vomited or other various issues that pestered his mind in both past and present. He could do this one thing right. He could be the hero, not the one being saved. Everything everyone invested in him would pay off in this singular moment. If Momentum was able to do this, New Year's would be saved for everyone. It was all purple.

"I don't see anything! I don't think they started yet," Crimson Claw said from Golem's shoulders. They watched the skyline of Skum City from the edge of the mountain Moroseville sat on.

"Good. Good. We got here with just a minute to spare!" Abraham said. Only his face could be seen from under the blankets wrapping his body. "How are none of you cold?" Abraham asked. Golem, Bliant, Swamp Gut, Etheria, and Slime Knight were not wearing anything aside from their normal costumes.

"Being around you makes me feel all warm in my face," Bliant said.

She bearhugged Abraham who said, "You are too kind to me, you know?"

"No. Perception. Of cold," Golem said.

"The Absence is a little colder than this on a spring day," Etheria said. Her hood fluttered in the wind, never moving enough to reveal any portion of her face.

“I am . . . long since the point of feeling cold,” Zombie said.

Slime Knight gave a thumbs up.

“Nope . . . I’m not cold . . . at all. I could kill . . . for your cooler, Slime,” Swamp Gut said. Their teeth chattered. They shivered with only a pair of pants and a cut off t-shirt on. Slime Knight went to hug Swamp Gut like how Bliant had done for Abraham, but Swamp Gut yelped as they jumped back.

“No! Your armor . . . is freezing. That metal will . . . suck the heat right outta me!”

Slime Knight stepped back and seemed to be hanging their non-present head down. Abraham reached into his tote bag and pulled out a fleece blanket. “Here! I have a spare!” Abraham threw the blanket over to Swamp Gut and Slime Knight helped adjust it so it covered them fully.

“Sorry for yelping, Slime. I appreciate you looking out for me,” Swamp Gut said. They put their hand on Slime Knight’s shoulder pad briefly before retracting it beneath the blanket. The Nexus Magistrate and company stood waiting for the fireworks to start.

Thirty seconds left on the clock. It was all pink. Courage surged through his body as he pushed against Shakedown. It was so clear now with this man standing across him why he chose to fight, why all heroes chose to. He stood for an ideal, the ideal that all people

deserve a chance at this wonderful life. This was Momentum's chance to act as the people's shepherd.

Momentum gathered all he could muster. He sucked everything to the center of his mouth then spit forward. A loogie of saliva and blood flew into Shakedown's eyes. It was all orange. Shakedown recoiled as he wiped at his eyes.

"Oh . . . shit! Did you just spit in my eyes?!?! You little . . . do you know how unsanitary—"

Shakedown was cut short as the back of Momentum's boot collided with his chin. It was all green. Shakedown fell to the ground and a small device slid across the ground.

"No! The activator . . ." Shakedown extended his arm out toward it, but a harpoon flew into the ground piercing the device. It fizzled briefly before the harpoon retracted back to Momentum. They watched the countdown finish. Ten. Nine. Eight. Seven. Six. Five. Four. Three. Two. One.

The countdown disappeared to show a drawing of Shakedown laughing. He had a big head and a very small body with two tiny arms holding bags of money. The picture shook on the screen as the mini-Shakedown's mouth opened and closed. It was all white. Shakedown's laugh echoed from the speakers. The picture froze then flickered and enormous red letters spelling out "Error" appeared on the screen.

"Did you really thing I was going to start the new year with a loss?" Momentum asked.

Tinkerer, Markie, Mindmeld, and Teen Demon watched the fireworks from the sky as Stupendous Man held the gazebo from below. Colors splashed against their body before fading to reveal another burst of light. Steam rose off their filled mugs, except for Markie's. Hers sat cold as she had absorbed the heat to power herself. Teen Demon had asked her to save the cold drink for him to consume later.

"How does it look up there? Does it look as beautiful as it does from down here?" Stupendous Man asked. He held the gazebo with one hand and the empty mug upright with the other.

"Eh, I've seen better," Teen Demon said.

"It looks just wonderful from here, Honey," Tinkerer said.

Just the faintest boom could be heard from the edges of Moroseville as the Nexus Magistrate watched the colors coat the skyline of Skum City.

"Man, how much you think that all costs?" Swamp Gut asked.

"A fraction of what the underground base did," Crimson Claw said.

"Are you talking accounting for inflation?" Swamp Gut asked.

"What? Of course, I was accounting for inflation. I'm not that detached from normal human occurrences . . ." Crimson Claw said.

“So, was the uninflated base still way more expensive than the fireworks?” Swamp Gut asked.

“Huh? Probably. I don’t really know. Why are you so curious? You plan on selling it?” Crimson Claw asked.

“Just thinking about what to do once I become the leader eventually,” Swamp Gut said as they stretched their arms into the air.

“There are literally half a dozen people in the queue before you,” Bliant said.

“WHAT! Six! Like who?”

“Me, Etheria, Aristotle . . . maybe. Golem . . . probably—”
Crimson Claw said.

“Golem likely.” Golem said.

Crimson Claw laughed before continuing to list. “Abraham. Maybe even . . .” Crimson Claw kept talking.

Yet Zombie heard none of their banter. His head did not turn from Skum City. The light from the fireworks firing off into the air just barely grazed his teal skin, only slightly tinting his hue. In this moment it was all forgotten. Last year and all that came before were one step farther away. This was a new year. A chance to be someone new, mean something more, grow more efficiently. There was no doubt that on this night Zombie felt the feeling stronger than anyone in the world that Skum City was stunning.

“It . . . is . . . beautiful,” Zombie muttered to himself.

“WOAH! WE ARE WAY TOO CLOSE TO THESE!” Cobra Commando shouted as he dove to the ground covering his head.

“Just hide as close to the ground as you can, and it will all be over soon!” Phantom said.

“Figures the officials gave us a position so close to the fireworks,” Chainlink said.

A golden scarab formed next to them. It grabbed Phantom, Cobra Commando, and Chainlink with its pincers then it flew off the building toward the Prol district.

“What’s that?” Nathan asked as he pointed to the TV in the lobby.

“What’s what?” Jeff asked. Nathan, Jeff, and Richard stood at the front end of the store, each with an off-brand soda can in hand.

“Didn’t you see that golden thing fly off?” Nathan asked.

“It is getting a little past your bedtime. Perhaps you are seeing things,” Richard said. He laughed to himself then he cracked open his can. The three of them clunked their soda together.

“To a year of people signing up for our membership program!” Richard said to one excited cheer and one half-hearted cheer.

“You did it! I never had a single doubt!” Tensile said. Momentum landed on the ground next to them.

“She tells no lie!” Pillbug-Man said before patting Momentum on the back. “You really knocked that viridescent villain so hard he’s going to wake up worrying about Y2K!”

“That was an absolutely enriching engagement with the opposition,” Philosopher said. Every grunt in the room laid unconscious on the ground.

“Another flawless victory from the PMA. This will go under the staff plus student excursion section of the yearbook,” Pillbug-Man said. Philosopher pulled out his phone and flipped it, so the camera was facing inward.

“Do colleges do yearbooks?” Tensile asked.

“Mine does!” Pillbug-Man said.

“Smile!” Philosopher said. Pillbug-Man wrapped his arms around all of them and pulled them tight.

“Say Happy New Year!” Pillbug-Man shouted.

Prettiest at Sunset

I haven't been sleeping well. It's not that I can't fall asleep. It's just that I wake up at night randomly. My moments of lucidity are so brief it's hard to remember how many times I actually woke up once morning comes, but I feel the fact that I did during the day.

I keep having this dream. Cat-atonic is there. We're together, sitting on the couch and I am petting him. I can feel his fur. It is a little coarse, because of course he's getting older. Cat-atonic's once muscular form is now covered in saggy skin. His once black mane is now stained gray. His once wide eyes now struggle to stay open. We're watching TV and I love him as if he was my brother.

In this dream, I'm not sure why, but when I am petting him, I go to smell him. I expect to smell dirt, musk, and that peculiar scent old animals give off. But when I smell him, I just smell me. That's when I wake up. I am smelling my own pillow.

I've been thinking more about him than I used to. I'll just be standing there living my life and then I remember how he'd blink his eyes or the sound he made when getting comfortable and my eyes start to water. I don't cry, just shake a little. I often wonder if people will remember Cat-atonic? He's worth being remembered, but I doubt many people think about him anymore except for me. So, what happens to him once I go? I'd like to think part of Cat-atonic is now me and when I impart a piece of myself on someone else, that means Cat-atonic is there too.

The most recent time I thought about him was when I stopped by the bank. It was nothing out of the ordinary. I just needed to get some money for this cash-only restaurant I planned on going to tonight. Although I must confess, I did visit the bank more than I had to. Maybe I was always waiting for something to happen.

So, there I stood in line, waiting my turn to talk with the teller. Suddenly, a man started shouting. He was going on about how the person on the other side of the counter needed to listen to him or things would get messy. This man didn't look like a bad guy. He was just like you or me.

He could have used a shave, his hair was stuck to his head damp with sweat, and he wore jeans with a plaid long sleeve shirt. Hardly what I would have dressed in to rob a bank, I would know. Everyone around me turned to look at him. That was when he pulled the gun out of his pocket. The people started running, but I, the hero I am, walked toward him.

I have this song I like to sing to the animals that have graced my life before they die. It's called "Goodnight My Friend". It's this fun little song from this silly musical/TV show called *Galavant*. I'm not sure why it charmed me so much. Perhaps I am impressed by this comedic actor's vocal prowess?

Before they die, I like to sit with them. Sometimes I play the song out loud and sing to it. Sometimes I hum it. Sometimes I just sing it on my own. I'm sure they can't understand it, but I hope it relaxes them at least. I sing it mostly for me. I just want them to know it is

okay that they leave now. I want them to know that I— See . . . there I go getting choked up again. I want them to know that I will be okay. That they've done their part and can rest fulfilled. That I'll carry on for them. If I had ever had kids, I wanted to sing this to them as a lullaby every night. When they thought of their dad, I wanted them to think of him leaning over the crib singing that song.

Each time I start a fight with someone, for just a moment, I think of that song. I think of all the living creatures I carry within me. Would there be someone to sing to me? I approached the gunman. I didn't have to do it, but I saw his arms shaking. He didn't want to do this; no one wants to be violent. Soon, just the teller, the gunman, and I were alone in the bank.

"Who do you think you are?" the gunman asked, turning to me.

"I'm Pillbug-Man!" I responded.

"Who are you?" he asked, an understandable mistake. After all, I wasn't in costume.

"You must not recognize me since I'm not in costume," I said. I took another step. The man did not lower his gun. Instead, he pointed it at me.

"Don't take a single step closer!" he shouted.

"It's okay. I once robbed a bank too. They really do deserve it for wasting so much space in small towns. It doesn't define us. We are more than our most rash decisions."

“I’m serious! Not one more step!” So, of course, I took another step forward. Perhaps all the years of wearing that suit started to get to me. Bullets don’t scare you the same after you fight shadow monsters and crystal creatures.

“Just . . . put . . . the . . . gun . . . down,” I said, reaching my arm out. The tips of my fingers touched the top of the barrel. It was warm from being in his pocket, and I slowly pushed the gun downward. Then, the teller leapt out from behind the counter tackling the gunman. When they hit each other, he must have accidentally pulled the trigger. The sound echoed around the room and then it was silent.

“I—I didn’t mean to do that,” the man said before the teller’s fist crashed into his face. I don’t think their fight went on for long, but they didn’t pay much attention to me.

“It’s okay . . .” I think I said. That’s when I reached my arm up and felt right beneath the front of my shoulder. My shirt had been ripped and it appeared that I had quite a nasty gash in the shape of a small circle. I used my other arm to reach behind and feel my back. To the right of my spine, I felt a wet spot and when I poked it pain seared through my body.

The pain really started after that. I was never good with pain. In all reality I had never taken that much of a beating in a fight. I usually just snuck up and finished the fight while someone else did the brunt of the work or I just talked my way out of it. I have never felt anything quite like this. My head began to spin and my chest felt warm. I

stumbled toward an exit, tripping once, then I got back up and stepped out of the building entering the alleyway.

I pushed that door open and there I was in between the buildings awestruck at the wonder of this world. Beautiful green moss grew on the sides of the bank, and a cool breeze blew through the alley. I could hear pigeons fly up above and saw them cross over the buildings. The last thing I remember was an orange blur and then here I was.

Did you know pill bugs aren't actually bugs? They're actually crustaceans. Guess I was wrong about that all these years. I still think they're cool, just wanted to make sure you knew I figured that out eventually.



Pillbug-Man finished recounting his story to the man standing above him. They both were on a flat piece of rock that was just a small piece of the mountain that led to Moroseville. From there, they could see it all. Skum City began to turn purple as the sun started to set. New Hope City still stood shining. The suburbs sprawled on as far as they could see. It all looked so pretty at this time of day.

Pillbug-Man sat on the ground with his back against the mountain. The man paced back and forth. His orange boots moving back and forth in front of Pillbug-Man who took shallow breaths in and out.

“No . . . there’s no hospitals that can save him. He’s lost too much blood and is too old. Maybe I can . . . There was that one cleric

Spirit Rider knew . . . No, I have no idea where she is. This wasn't supposed to happen."

"I didn't know they made it so your angel was the most beautiful person you ever knew," Pillbug-Man said. He stared up at the man's brown beard perfectly chiseled. A few white hairs outlined the edges of it. This angel had an orange J on his chest just like Justice did.

"I'm not an angel—I . . . You're dying and there isn't anything I can do about it!"

"Yeah . . . that's what I alluded to in my recollection," Pillbug-Man said.

"Stop being so nonchalant. You can't die now. Not like this!"

"Why not?" Pillbug-Man asked.

"No, but you have to fight. You can't go like this," the man said.

"Mmm. Hey, do you know where Momentum is? He's probably looking for me," Pillbug-Man said.



"I have no eyes on Pillbug-Man!" Momentum shouted high above the street flipping past the buildings. The sun was beginning to set, and he feared their chances of finding him would decrease in the night.

“It’s impossible. He couldn’t have gotten far. We got the call only a few minutes ago!” Tensile said into her bracelet. She was at the bank studying the droplets of blood on the ground and their sudden disappearance once they reached the alley. Who was to say what happened to him and she feared at his old age he wouldn’t last long out there.

“Has anyone seen my buddy!” Philosopher shouted riding the tandem bicycle down the street pushing with enough force to move the entire bicycle even though he was the only one on it. He feared of what he would tell his daughter when he got home if Pillbug-Man were not to be found.

“It was just some random guy that shot him, not some villain. He wasn’t kidnapped,” Rider said leaping from roof to roof atop Bat’s back. She feared the idea that Bat wasn’t able to sense his presence.

“Pigeon Person and I got the main streets. We can see everything up here!” Dragonfly shouted. Pigeon Person and Dragonfly danced through the air. He flapped his arms pushing wind down so he could keep up in the air and with the bursts of wind pushing against the ground then back upward Dragonfly had enough air so she could glide with him. She feared being the one to find Pillbug-Man.

“Perhaps we need to call in an assist,” Pigeon Person suggested.

A red ball of energy darted across Skum City weaving through every building covering miles each minute. Burnout’s limits had been

broken with Pillbug-Man's motivation once before, but they feared that would not be enough to save him now.

"Dom, give Tara a call. We could use her people," Burnout said.

"On it," Momentum said.

A manhole cover flipped up, and Microcosm appeared in the middle of the road. "He didn't escape to the sewers. Perhaps we should call in the Protectors for Profit?" she suggested.

"Can we trust those guys?" Rider asked.

"Call them! We need every boot on the ground," Tensile said.



Cobra Commando leaned back in his chair, one hand scrolling through the news as the other dug into a bowl of peas. His research was halted with the ringing of a landline on the other side of the room. He slammed the chair back down and put the pea bowl back on the counter as it rang the second time. During the third ring he stumbled to a run, his legs asleep. When it rang the fourth time he reached out for the phone.

His hand was knocked to the side by Chainlink's hand as she grabbed the phone and raised it to her ear. Cobra Commando listened to the muffled words coming out of the phone.

"Yes, this is us . . . Pillbug-Man? . . . I think I've heard the name . . . Missing? . . . You want our help?" she said into the phone.

“A hero wants our help!” Cobra Commando shouted without going above a whisper. Chainlink held her finger up to her mouth to indicate that he needed to be quiet.

“Got it . . . No, no charge. We don’t do that anymore. . . We’ll be out A.S.A.P.” Chainlink set the phone down. “Call Totem, Hero, and Flora. We have a hero to find!”



From the side of the mountain Pillbug-Man noticed more about the view now that the sun had set. For example, there was this red blur dashing throughout the streets that was visible for just moments before disappearing again. A green light appeared off in the distance and landed down in Skum City. A yellow light flew across the skyline. Leaning against the mountain he just watched.

“Before Cat-atonic had to be put down, he looked weak. I guess I’m grateful he showed me that. I needed to know that he needed to go. He’d sit by the door. The blinds were closed, but he just sat there staring at the door as if he had somewhere to go. In the last few nights, he was restless. I could hear him toss and turn in the night, but he didn’t complain.

“When morning came, I could see him sitting up as if things were normal, but his eyes would start to close before he’d wake himself back up. He’d just sit there leaning against the wall trying to act as if nothing was wrong.” Pillbug-Man looked up to the angel standing next to him. His orange cape blew in the night breeze.

“Why did you take me here?” Pillbug-Man asked.

“Because—Because I need to fix this. I have to. This wasn’t supposed to happen. I was making sure of it.”

“Then you must not be an angel. An angel would let me die with my friends.”

The man sat next to Pillbug-Man and leaned against the mountain. He took off his orange cape and draped it over Pillbug-Man covering his wound. The man took off his left glove and extended his arm out, so his hand sat over Pillbug-Man’s right hand.

“Pillbug, I’m not an angel. It’s me. I need you to know that.”

“Heh. I want that to be true. Maybe it’d be best for me if you were just an angel.”

“I am true,” Justice said. Justice turned toward Pillbug-Man. The stars shined down above them casting a white glow that reflected off Pillbug-Man’s face. One would imagine this color reflecting off his pale skin would suck the life from his image, but he appeared to be glowing under the night sky. “I’m sorry. I had to hide myself after S-Day. I’ve heard how you talk when I’m watching from above. I know you hate me, but hopefully someday you understand.”

“Hate is a strong word. I would more say I just worked for decades to undo the damage you did to our world in a matter of days,” Pillbug-Man said before turning to Justice. Their eyes locked.

“I saw all of it. I—I thank you,” Justice said. He broke eye contact to look off to the sky before turning back toward Pillbug-Man. What was it about the sky tonight? Why did he keep looking at it? Did

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it truly look that beautiful or was it just a chance to breathe? A chance to look away and back at him. To see if he truly is as beautiful as you tell yourself. That he looks the same as he does in your dreams.

“Did you sing that song to Hammer? You know, before we had to put him down.”

“I did. It was when you stopped to get gas.”

“Thank you.” Justice wrapped his fingers around Pillbug-Man’s. His fingers were strong while Pillbug-Man’s had a slight shake he tried to hide. This tremor had grown worse as more blood slipped out from his body, but Justice held his hand steady. Pillbug-Man could smell his cologne. It was this pine-like one that Justice had been using since they first met.

“I wish you’d come around earlier. We would have lived a wonderful life together,” Pillbug-Man said.

“I’ve lived hundreds of lifetimes with you over and over up here,” Justice said. He nodded his head toward Pillbug-Man. “It could have been so simple. Just you and me. The stuff with the Alpha Squadron just got so complicated and I—”

“And yet the world remains. I’ve thought about you so many times, but it was always the same. I figured we could get a dog. I would have liked an apartment in the city. We’d go for walks in the park together. We’d sit together and watch TV at night. I still got some of that sorta,” Pillbug-Man said. He leaned his head to the side, so it rested on Justice’s shoulder. Perhaps his body was losing its strength or maybe Pillbug-Man just wanted to rest his head there. They enjoyed

the view together, attempting to make memories meant to be made over years in minutes.

“God, it’s not fair. You can’t just show up like this, not right at the end. I’d be real mad right now if I wasn’t so happy to see you alive. Not much time left to hold a grudge anyway.” There was so much more to say but not enough time to say it. Should his previous sentences have been different? What would he choose to be his last? Could words ever express everything he was feeling all at once? Pillbug-Man laid his head against Justice’s chest.

“Why’d you even bother to show up now?”

“I couldn’t let you go without knowing. I had always planned to come back. I’m—I’m ...” Justice wiped his sleeve across his eyes. “Oh god. I’m going to miss you. How come humans live such a short, fragile life?” A tear slipped down the left side of his face. Pillbug-Man sat back up then reached over and wiped it away.

“We live longer than pill bugs though. From that perspective, we live very long lives.” Justice laughed before sniffing. They were now both facing each other, their hands interlocked, Justice’s eyes watery, and blood dried on Pillbug-Man’s chin.

Constellations floated in the sky above them and the sounds of car horns echoed out from the city. In this moment, their souls reached a harmony of sorts. Hundreds of thousands of decisions led each of them to this cliff. From the first pill bug they saved to the destruction of their home planet. All of it led them to this one moment, together.

“I’m sorry. I’m so—I’m so sorry,” Justice said. Pillbug-Man wiped another tear from his face.

“I’m sorry too. We had a lot of good days back then though.”

So many people come and go. Each of them leaving a small part of themselves with you. What really are we except the composition of everyone we have ever known? A ball of strings intertwined and inseparable. A pile of cords stuck behind the TV. With so much at play, it is a miracle that two people can love the big, ugly, and vibrant hodgepodge that each other carries inside.

They leaned closer and closer to each other. Pillbug-Man closed his eyes. Justice rested his palm against Pillbug-Man’s ear bracing his head. His skin was warm against Pillbug-Man’s fading body. For just a brief moment, their lips touched. Pillbug-Man felt the brush of his beard on his chin. It sent tingles down his spine. Decades of dreaming of this one moment and it was even better in reality. He was stable. He was safe. He was actually here right now.

After sharing a kiss under the night sky, they leaned back.

“I loved you,” Pillbug-Man said.

“I love you,” Justice said.

Pillbug-Man’s body began to shake just slightly, unable to stop it. He could not tell if it was his body giving out in its final minutes or if the euphoria of this moment was getting to him.

“Even with everything, I am still happy I got to see you, but please take me back so I can die with my friends,” Pillbug-Man said.

“Of course.”

“Think about sticking around one of these days,” Pillbug-Man said.

“I will.”



Momentum swung around the outside of Skum City. It was now dark, and they still had no sight of him. As he flipped through the air an orange blur blew past him, knocking him further upward. He saw the blur dash off into Friday’s Cemetery.

“I think I might have a lead. Prepare to close in on my position,” Momentum said. The anchors shot out from his side, and he swung after the blur. Within minutes he had crossed dozens of streets. Once he had moved out of the city, he used the trees to grapple toward the graveyard off in the distance. Swinging beneath the leaves and over branches his motions had to be far more precise than in the city but he still rocketed forward.

Momentum swung off the last tree before the cemetery and flipped over the metal fence. He shot an anchor into the ground and blasted downward kicking up dirt as his boots crashed into the ground. He stood in the center of the cemetery, the lights of Skum City shining in the distance. Momentum spun in circles looking at the countless gravestones surrounding him. He could have sworn that this was where the blur had gone to.

“PILLBUG-MAN, WHERE ARE YOU?” Momentum shouted.

“... over here ... kid.” Momentum ran over to the voice to find Pillbug-Man sat up against a gravestone. His left hand covered his shoulder, and his face was even paler than usual. An orange cape was draped over his legs with blood stains spattered across it.

Momentum raised his wrist up to his mouth, “I found him! Close in on me!” He ran forward and sat next to Pillbug-Man. “Oh God ... it has been like an hour. I thought we’d never see you again!”

“Oh ... Well, I tried my best ... to hold out. I’m ... glad to see you,” Pillbug-Man said. With a groan he reached his left arm up and put it around Momentum. Blood was stained on his palm. His breaths were slow and when his mouth slipped open, Momentum could hear how raspy they were. He was shaking. He tried to hide it, but he was shaking. Both of them were. “I’m ... not going to make it.”

“No, don’t talk like that. It’s going to be okay.”

“I’m happy ... to die like this. I wanted to say goodbye when the time came.”

“I called Tara and all of them. The whole city was looking for you. They’ll come here and we’ll save you.”

“That’s real kind of them ... I don’t know if I am going to make it till then though. Please tell them all how much I loved them.”

Momentum’s throat began to burn. He sniffled before speaking, “Come on. You can’t just die with me here. They’d want to see you.”

Pillbug-Man looked up to Skum City. Its purple light shined out into the night. He was in awe at how magnificent it looked at night.

A single tear rolled down his face on the side opposite to where Momentum sat. He blinked his eyes pushing the burning sensation back down. At this point, the pain had changed from a fiery spike that pulsed to a dull, constant pain.

“I lived a good life. You all gave me that. Thank you. It was a pleasure to be your mentor. You kids are going to be alright; I just know it.”

“You were the best mentor too! I—Thanks for taking a chance on me. No one took me seriously until you. Without you none of this could have happened. All these people are here today because of you.”

Pillbug-Man choked out a laugh. “They’re here because that’s who they are. People are good when you let them be.” He took a breath. “Don’t forget my bench, will you?”

“Of course. I’ll make sure it is in a nice and good spot and is super welcoming.”

“You’re . . . the . . . best.” Pillbug-Man’s head began to tilt away from Momentum and fall to his right side before catching himself and adjusting so he was leaning against the gravestone.

“You really are going now. Aren’t you?”

“Afraid so.” Pillbug-Man’s eyes grew heavy. He blinked, trying to keep them open before he could not anymore. The world went black. The last thing he could feel was an embrace. “What a joy to be a part of it all.”



In this great, beautiful world of heroes. A world of floating islands and magic that goes beyond the eyes. The world left by the Alpha Squadron. The one I didn't run from. A place where golems guard werewolves and children train under the watchful eye of their mentors in farmyards. Where people fight to keep just one street safe. Where an underdog cannot accept defeat. How wonderful it is to take part in the story.

When the entire story is done, I know I will be but a fraction of it all. It will take hundreds of heroes and I was only one. When parents tell their children about the next generation of protectors the words "Pillbug-Man" will never grace their mouths. And that is okay.

As I take my last breaths, my life does not flash before my eyes. No, I am at my grandparents' house. I woke up to the sound of my grandmother yelling at Dad. They don't know I've been watching from the stairs.

Minutes passed. She's now asleep on the couch. Dad sits opposite her. He watches her breath in and out, her lungs still heavy from the shouting. The TV is on, playing some meaningless history show. When he gets up, he puts a blanket over her before going to bed.



Tara was the first to get there and she found Momentum silently sitting next to Pillbug-Man's body. Her suit could sense Pillbug-Man had no heartbeat. Momentum was looking forward, staring at Skum City. The purple aura reflected off his face. Her

booster retracted back into her suit and Tara ran forward. She slid to the ground and hugged Momentum.

“I’m sorry. I’m so, so sorry. He was a good man.” Momentum reached his arms around her and leaned against her shoulder. His eyes were red, but he wasn’t crying. A gentle breeze blew through the grass.

The rest of the heroes arrived within minutes. Momentum, Tensile, Pigeon Person, Philosopher, Dragonfly, Bat, Rider, Burnout, Microcosm, Tara, Teen Demon, Mindmeld, Markie, Tinkerer, Flora, Cobra Commando, Chainlink, Hero, and Totem stood around Pillbug-Man.

Cobra Commando stepped forward and put his hand on Momentum’s shoulder. “My best friend is here too. I’m sure he was there waiting for Pillbug-Man.”

“Thank you,” Momentum said. Rider and Dragonfly were petting Bat. Philosopher stood next to Tensile who was comforting Burnout. Microcosm stood off to the back with Pigeon Person. Flora, Totem, and Chainlink were looking off at a gravestone in the distance. Teen Demon stood next to Mindmeld. Markie hovered in the air just behind them by Tinkerer. Tara stood close to Momentum. They were together. The day was over.



You get out of your car in the driveway. You are alone and carrying a cardboard box. You start to walk up to your house. You notice a pill bug crossing your driveway. You pause, reach down to pick it up and carry it to the other side of the driveway. You keep walking up to your house and in through the door. Someone is waiting for you.